

Finding Lucy

*A Journey of Wellness, Self-Discovery
and Transformation*

Lucy Mworira

FINDING LUCY: A JOURNEY OF WELLNESS, SELF-DISCOVERY AND TRANSFORMATION

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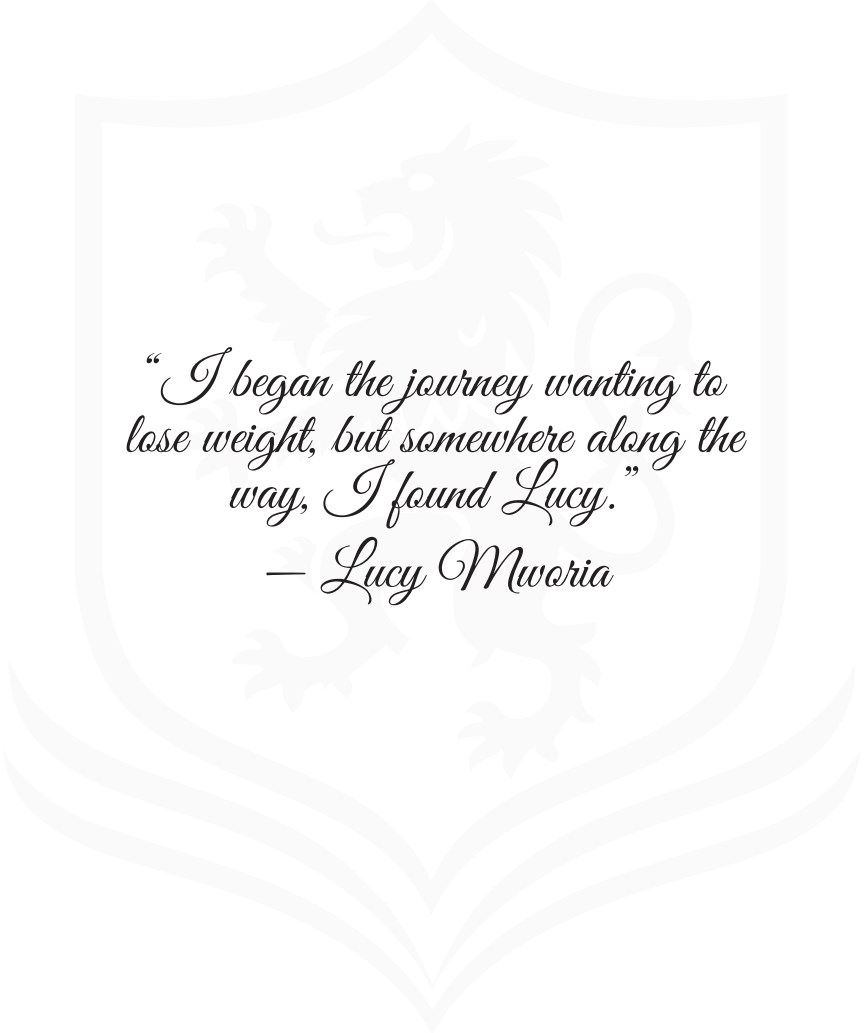
Email: rose@ssaliresearch.com | ssalirose@gmail.com

WhatsApp: +27 725 276776 | +255 75230 8506 | +254 707903552

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Disclaimer

This book describes the author's personal experience with wellness, food, fasting, exercise, sleep, and weight loss. It is not medical advice and is not intended to diagnose, treat, cure, or prevent any condition. Lucy Mworio is not presenting herself in these pages as a doctor, nutritionist, or fitness professional. Individual needs differ. Readers should seek appropriate professional guidance before making significant changes to diet, fasting, medication, or exercise, particularly if they have a medical condition or take prescription medication.



*“I began the journey wanting to
lose weight, but somewhere along the
way, I found Lucy.”*

— Lucy Mweria

About the Author

Lucy Mworira is a Kenyan development professional, advocate, and wellness storyteller whose work has centred on leadership, community development, and the dignity and inclusion of older persons.

She holds a Master of Development Studies (MDS), specializing in Organisation Development, and a Bachelor's degree in Leadership and Management from St. Paul's University in Kenya. She also trained in nursing in the United States.

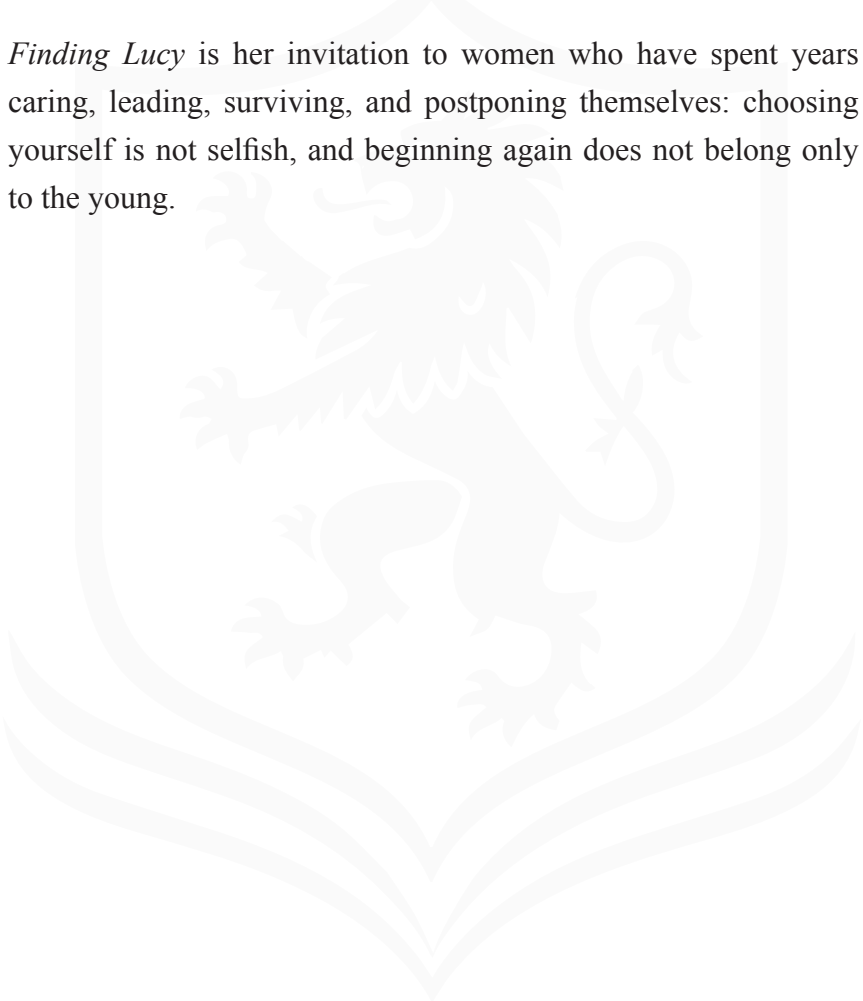
After returning to Kenya in 2012, Lucy pursued public service and contested elections in 2013, 2017, and 2022. Her professional life has continued to include advocacy and work with older persons and community organisations.

After sixty, a personal health journey changed the way she understood discipline, ageing, confidence, and self-care. Beginning at 115 kilograms, she lost approximately 30 kilograms through lifestyle changes that included changes in food, intermittent fasting, walking, dancing, strength work, hydration, and improved sleep. She shares those experiences as her personal story rather than medical instruction.

This is why I no longer define discipline as severity. Discipline is remembering what matters after the exciting beginning has passed.

It is also knowing how to begin again without insulting yourself. Shame has never been my most reliable coach. Responsibility is better. I can tell myself the truth, accept the choice I made and make another one. That is a relationship with myself I can sustain.

Finding Lucy is her invitation to women who have spent years caring, leading, surviving, and postponing themselves: choosing yourself is not selfish, and beginning again does not belong only to the young.



Dedication

In Loving Memory Of My Beloved Son, Murithi Mworia

You were my firstborn, my constant encourager, and a source of strength throughout my writing journey. Thank you for always taking the time to read my work, offer honest feedback, and believe in me even when I doubted myself.

Your simple words, “Keep going, Mum,” carried more meaning than you may ever have known. They encouraged me to persevere, to finish what I had begun, and to continue sharing my story with others.

I am deeply proud of the man you became and profoundly grateful for the love, kindness, and support you gave me. Although you left this world before this book was completed, your voice, your encouragement, and your memory remain woven into every page.

This book is lovingly dedicated to you, my son. May your memory forever be a blessing, and may the words you inspired me to write continue to speak to others.

With all my love,

Mum



*“I thought I was searching for
a smaller body; I was really
searching for myself.”*

— Lucy Mwiria

Acknowledgements

This book is the story of one woman's decision to change her life. While the journey required personal commitment and discipline, I did not walk it alone. I am deeply grateful to the people who believed in me, encouraged me, and stood beside me along the way.

First and foremost, I give all glory, honour, and thanks to Almighty God. He gave me the strength to begin, the courage to continue, and the grace to persevere when the journey became difficult. Without Him, this transformation would not have been possible.

My heartfelt appreciation goes to Dr. Maryam Badamana of Aga Khan Hospital, Kilifi. Thank you for planting the seed that transformed my life. When I came to you complaining about my painful knees, you discovered that I weighed 115 kilograms. With kindness, compassion, and confidence, you told me,

“Lucy, you need to lose weight, and yes, you can do it. You just need to make a personal decision.”

Those words marked the turning point of my life. That day, I made the decision that forever changed my health, my mindset, and my future. Dr. Maryam, I will forever remain grateful for your encouragement, your professionalism, and your unwavering belief in me. May God richly bless you as you continue transforming lives.

To my dear friend Zena Salim, thank you for your friendship, encouragement, and support. You were instrumental in helping me find the villa I eventually purchased, now known as Kilifi Wellness & Holiday Villa. It has become a place of peace, reflection, and a beautiful marker of this chapter of my life.

To my beloved sister, Purity Nkirete, thank you for celebrating my victories with genuine joy.

With love to my granddaughters who have added their voices to my story: Thank you.

And to my daughter Kit: you did much more than read these pages. You asked me the questions that made me remember the woman behind the lessons. You pushed me to tell the stories I might have skipped, protected my voice when it would have been easier to make it sound more polished, and reminded me that this book should sound like me. You were determined that the reader should meet Lucy, not simply receive advice from her. Thank you for helping me find the story inside my story—and for knowing when your mother had finally answered enough questions for one day.

To my family, friends, neighbours, and everyone who encouraged me, prayed for me, walked with me, or simply noticed that I was trying: thank you.

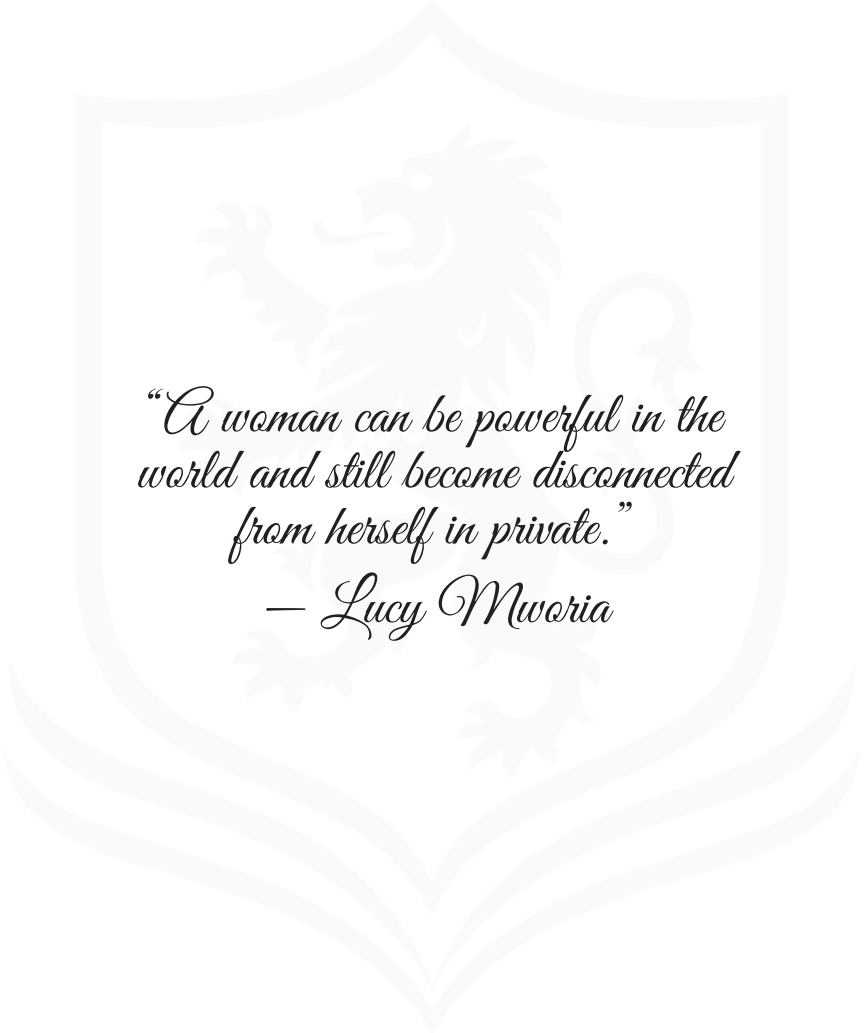
I wish to express my sincere gratitude to my editor, Rose Ssali, for her invaluable editorial expertise, guidance, and support throughout the development of this book. I am equally grateful to the Creative Director at Ssali Publishing House the exemplary

artwork, which has added beauty and character to the book. It has been an incredibly rewarding experience.

With heartfelt gratitude,

Lucy Mvorira





*“A woman can be powerful in the
world and still become disconnected
from herself in private.”*

— Lucy Mwarira

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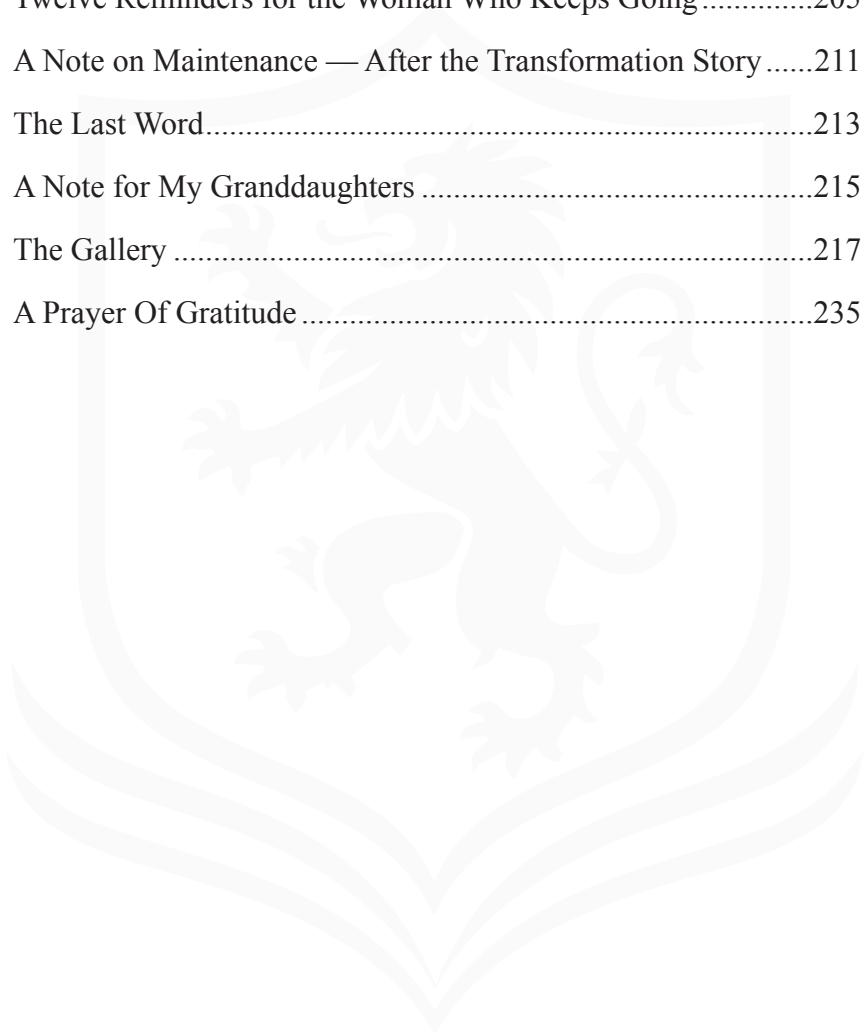
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*“This is not merely a story of
weight loss. It is the story of a
woman returning to herself.”*

— Lucy Mworia

Preface

I began this journey because I wanted to lose weight.

That is the simplest version of the story, and it is true. I weighed 115 kilograms. My knees hurt. My sleep was poor. I had lost interest in photographs, clothes, and many of the small pleasures that had once made me feel like myself.

But weight loss is not the reason I wrote this book.

I wrote it because somewhere between changing my food, learning discipline, walking along Bofa Road, dancing, lifting weights, being criticised on social media, travelling, laughing at myself, and trying on dresses simply for the pleasure of seeing myself in them again, I discovered that I had been looking for much more than a smaller body.

I was looking for Lucy.

I am not writing as a doctor, nutritionist, or fitness expert. I am writing as a woman who reached a point in her life when she had to decide whether to accept the story being handed to her—You are older now. This is what happens. Be content with decline—or become curious about what was still possible.

My methods were personal to me. One Meal a Day worked for me. Walking worked for me. Changing the food in my home worked for me. They are part of my story, not a prescription for yours.

What I hope is universal is the question underneath them: What happens when a woman decides that caring for herself is not selfish?

For many years, I had no difficulty showing up for other people. I could lead, advocate, work, raise a family, carry responsibilities, and enter rooms where difficult things needed to be said. Yet a woman can be powerful in the world and still become disconnected from herself in private.

This is the story of how I turned some of that strength inward.

I thought I was trying to become the woman I used to be. I found someone I had not met yet: more peaceful, more grateful, more contented, more loving, and more certain that my life was still mine to live.

That is the woman I found.

Introduction

There are many ways for a woman to lose herself.

Sometimes it happens dramatically, through a crisis, a profound disappointment, a loss, or a life-altering event that changes everything at once. More often, however, it happens quietly. It happens in the middle of responsibilities, family demands, work pressures, stress, grief, sleepless nights and the countless small sacrifices that women make without stopping to consider what those sacrifices are costing them. It can happen through years of putting everyone else first and reassuring yourself that you will take care of your own needs later.

The problem with later is that it can become a very long time. I know because that is what happened to me.

My own turning point did not begin with a diet plan, a weighing scale or a carefully designed wellness programme. It began with a photograph. I saw myself in a way I had been avoiding and, for the first time, I was willing to acknowledge that I was no longer comfortable with the woman I had become. Yet the photograph also gave me something I desperately needed. It reminded me that change was still possible.

That realisation became the beginning of a very different relationship with myself.

Over time, I lost thirty kilograms, and that achievement changed my life in ways I could not have imagined when I began. My body became lighter, but the transformation went much deeper than the number on the scale. I began to think differently about food, movement, discipline, rest and the choices I made every day. I became more attentive to my body and more honest about what it was telling me. Most importantly, I began to understand that looking after myself was not an act of selfishness. It was an act of responsibility.

This book is therefore about health because health matters. It is about weight loss because losing thirty kilograms was an important part of my story. It is about fasting, movement, food, choices and the practical lessons that helped me change.

But this book is also about something much bigger than any of those things.

It is for the woman who has no desire to fast, count her steps or fit into a particular dress size. It is for the woman who is perfectly happy with her body but knows there is another part of her life that needs attention. It is for the woman who has achieved much and still wonders when she disappeared from her own priorities.

It is for the mother who is always needed and has become accustomed to putting herself last. It is for the woman who is beginning again after disappointment or loss. It is for the caregiver who spends so much time looking after others that she barely notices when she herself becomes tired. It is for the professional, the leader, the

entrepreneur and the woman carrying responsibilities that seem to have no end. It is even for the woman who has abundant support around her but still feels guilty whenever she wants something for herself.

And it is for the woman who has become so accustomed to survival that she has forgotten what joy feels like.

Perhaps that is why this story is not really about losing thirty kilograms.

It is about what can happen when a woman finally decides that she is worth finding again.

My journey began in my body, but it eventually reached every part of my life. As I changed the way I ate, moved and cared for myself, I began to examine other areas of my life with the same honesty. I began to ask what I really wanted, what I had postponed, what I had accepted unnecessarily, and what parts of myself I had allowed to become quiet.

I discovered that weight can be measured on a scale, but there are other kinds of weight that cannot be measured so easily. There is the weight of responsibility, the weight of expectations, the weight of guilt, the weight of disappointment and the weight of continually telling yourself that everyone else comes first.

Sometimes, losing the physical weight gives you enough space to recognise the rest.

That is what happened to me.

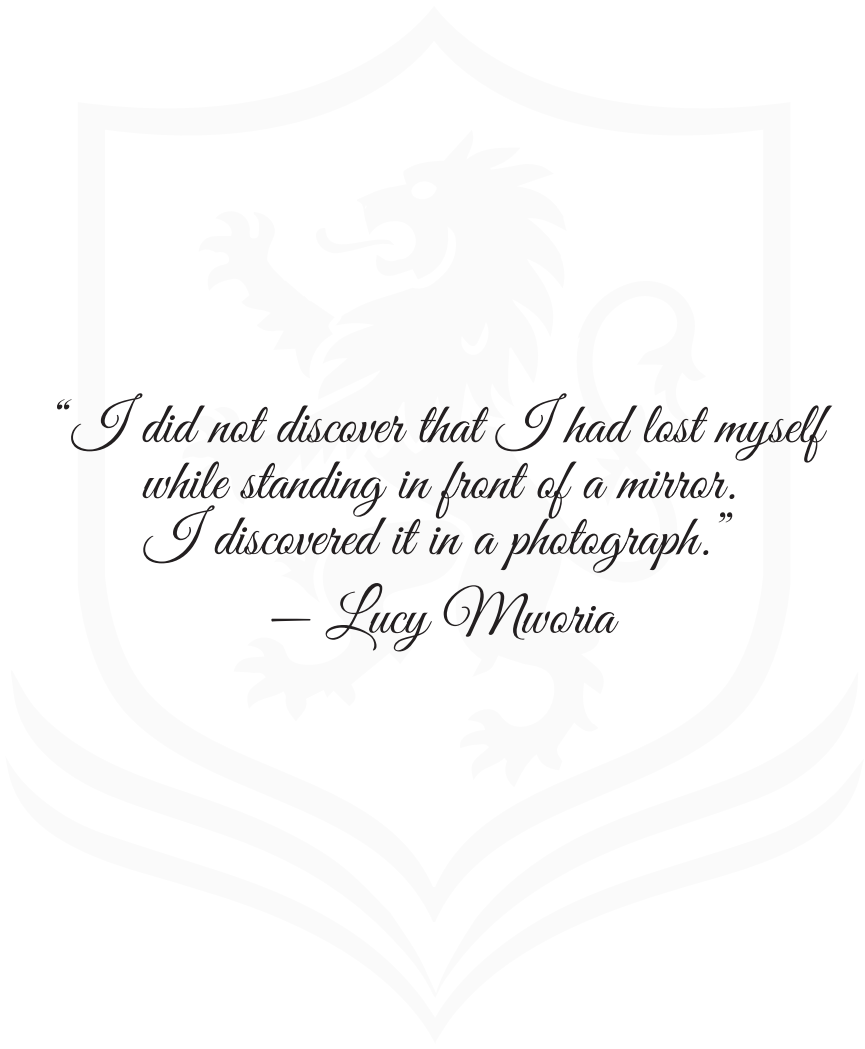
I began this process because I wanted to change my body. Along the way, I discovered that I was also changing my relationship with myself. I was learning to listen to my body, to respect its needs and to make decisions that supported the life I wanted rather than simply accommodating the life I had become accustomed to living.

Perhaps most importantly, I discovered that the woman I thought I had lost was never completely gone. She had been there all along, waiting beneath years of responsibility, habit and postponement.

I simply had to make the decision to go looking for her.

And when I did, I found more than a lighter body.

I found myself.



*“I did not discover that I had lost myself
while standing in front of a mirror.
I discovered it in a photograph.”*

— Lucy Mworira



PART ONE

The Woman I Missed

CHAPTER ONE

Going Home

In 2012, I moved back to Kenya.

A move like that can be described in one sentence, but a life does not fit neatly inside one. I had spent years building a life abroad. I had worked, raised a family, studied, developed professionally, and learned how to move through a world that demanded competence. Returning to Kenya was not a retreat from that life. In my mind, it was the beginning of another one.

I came home with ambition.

I have never been a woman who was afraid of responsibility. I liked being useful. I liked leadership. I liked work that had consequence. I had opinions, energy, ideas, and the conviction that if something mattered, one should not merely complain about it from the side.

Immediately before I moved, home was Oceanside, California. I had lived in the United States for more than twenty years. I had built routines there, raised children there, worked there, studied there, and accumulated the ordinary evidence of a settled life: furniture, household things, clothes, memories, people who knew where to find me.

I was not packing for an experiment.

I sold and gave away almost everything.

What I kept, with great seriousness, were many of my beautiful clothes and shoes. This should tell you something about me. I was prepared to dismantle an American household, but apparently I was not prepared to abandon a good wardrobe.

That wardrobe had history. I had always enjoyed presentation. For a period in America I sold Mary Kay and even drove the famous pink Cadillac. Anyone familiar with Mary Kay knows that the car was not merely transportation. It announced that you had worked for something. I loved makeup, power suits, beautiful shoes, and the ritual of putting myself together. I could be practical and glamorous in the same afternoon.

When I decided to return to Kenya, I did not imagine myself coming back to the United States because the plan had failed. In my mind, I was going home permanently. Kenya was where I believed I could make the greater difference. I had watched the country's politics from abroad, returned on visits, complained as Kenyans do, and wondered why things could not be better. Constitutional changes had created new possibilities for women's political representation, and I saw a place where service and leadership might meet.

There is a confidence required to sell the furniture before life has proved you right.

I had that confidence.

Or perhaps I had enough conviction that confidence and foolishness were temporarily indistinguishable. Many of life's biggest decisions

look obvious only after we know how they end.

I boarded the plane carrying less of my old household and more certainty than I probably had any right to possess. I was going home. I was going to serve. I was going to win.

Life, as it often does, had not signed my version of the agreement.

Politics seemed like one place where that conviction could become action.

I moved first to Isiolo and rented a three-bedroom house. I was building a Kenyan life again after decades away, which is different from visiting the country you call home. A visit allows nostalgia. Living somewhere requires electricity bills, transport, work, neighbours, disappointments, and the discovery that memory has never had to negotiate rent.

I had family history in Kenya, cultural fluency, and a deep sense that this was home. I was also returning as a woman changed by more than twenty years elsewhere. Homecoming can contain both belonging and adjustment at the same time.

I threw myself into the work.

My first election was in 2013. I ran again in 2017. I ran a third time in 2022.

Three elections are three public campaigns, but they are also three private experiences. A campaign asks for your confidence before it gives you any guarantee of success. It asks you to stand before people and say, in effect, I believe I can serve.

It asks you to be judged publicly. It asks you to keep smiling when you are tired, to answer questions when you would rather be quiet, and to discover that everybody has an opinion about what you should have done differently.

Campaign life also gave me stories that make me laugh now, especially the ones involving my friend Mama Safi. We have known each other for more than thirty years. At some point after she moved to Isiolo and had a hotel there, this longtime friend somehow became my driver and campaign manager. I am not sure either of us ever held a formal meeting to approve this organisational structure.

Campaigns have a way of turning whoever is available, loyal, resourceful, and willing to keep moving into essential personnel.

Mama Safi was all of those things.

By the last campaign, money had become painfully tight. We were using her car. There was a moment when the car needed fuel and we did not have the money for it. We had to call her children to help us with petrol. On another campaign drive toward Meru, the engine overheated while I was already discouraged and financially stretched.

This is the part of public life that rarely makes the campaign photographs: two women, a tired vehicle, a political dream, and not enough money for the next practical problem.

On election day I slept at Mama Safi's place. By then there was little left to perform. We had done what we could do. The votes would become numbers, and the numbers would become an answer.

I lost.

Again.

The third loss in 2022 was especially hard. I had given up work to run. When it ended, I was looking at no elected position, no job to return to, and the familiar responsibilities of life still waiting for me.

Mama Safi could not fix that. Friendship is not always the person who fixes the impossible thing. Sometimes it is the person whose car also overheats beside you.

I knew how to do the public part.

That sentence will matter later.

I knew how to enter a room. I knew how to speak. I knew how to advocate. I knew how to dress for an occasion and carry myself with confidence. I loved beautiful clothes and high heels. I owned six pairs of four-inch heels that I particularly loved because I knew exactly which dresses belonged with which shoes.

Clothes were never the most important thing about me, but they were part of my pleasure in being myself. There is a difference.

A woman can care about serious things and still enjoy a beautiful dress. She can discuss policy in the afternoon and care very much which shoes go with dinner. We sometimes speak about accomplished women as though femininity must be edited out of the biography before the achievement becomes respectable.

I have never agreed.

When I look back at the woman who returned to Kenya, I remember her as a woman in motion. She believed the future was open. She was not afraid of beginning again.

There is a photograph of the younger version of me that still lives in my mind even when I am not looking at an actual picture. She is dressed. Her shoes are right. Her face is done. She has somewhere to be and expects to matter when she gets there.

I do not romanticize her. She had problems too. She was not more worthy because she was younger or smaller. But she had an ease in her relationship with her own presentation that I would later miss. Getting dressed was pleasure, not camouflage. A camera was not something I prepared to dislike.

That is why the clothes and shoes I brought back to Kenya matter in this story. They were not simply fashion. They were evidence of continuity. I could change countries, careers, houses and plans and still recognise the woman deciding which pair of heels belonged with which dress.

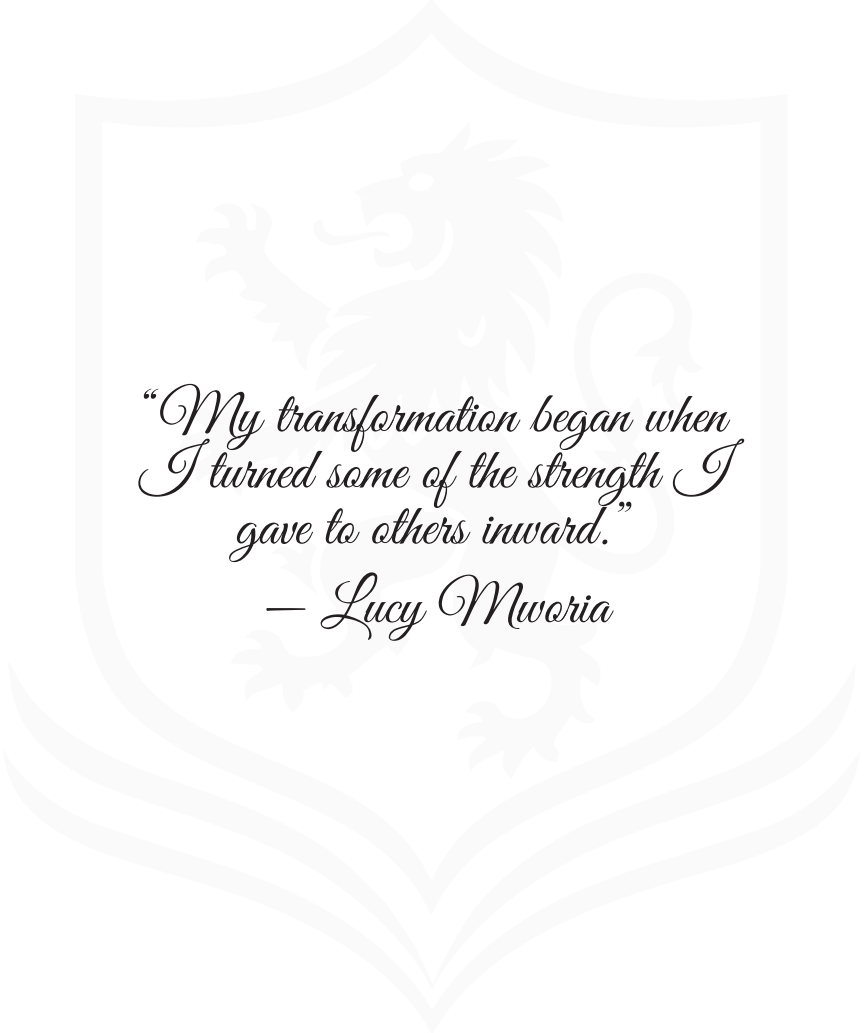
For years after returning, those clothes would witness versions of me I had not anticipated. Some would stop fitting. Some shoes would become impractical because my knees objected. The wardrobe I had insisted on carrying across an ocean would eventually become a quiet measure of how far I felt from the woman who packed it.

I did not know then how many kinds of beginning again life would eventually require of me.

Reflective Question:

When you picture yourself at the beginning of a major life decision, what part of that woman do you still recognise today?





*“My transformation began when
I turned some of the strength I
gave to others inward.”*

— Lucy Mworira

CHAPTER TWO

When The Plan Does Not Become The Life

There is a particular kind of exhaustion that comes after you have worked hard for something and the answer is still no.

After an election, the public story is simple. Someone won. Someone lost. Numbers are announced. People move on.

The private story can take longer.

After losing an election, I had to face the ordinary consequences that do not appear in political photographs. There was no job waiting for me. Money became uncertain. Family responsibilities did not disappear because my professional plan had changed. Stress did not arrive as one dramatic event; it settled into daily life.

The years between 2012 and 2022 did not move in a straight line from one ballot to the next. There were campaigns, losses, work, study, rebuilding, another attempt, and another rebuilding. At one point I worked with the County Government of Isiolo while also returning to school and taking classes at night. Reinvention became less of an inspirational concept and more of an administrative requirement.

After one election loss, I fell behind on rent on the three-bedroom house in Isiolo. One month became two. Then three.

People I had considered friends could be remarkably practical about my circumstances: when I entered an election, had I not known I was renting someone's house?

They were not entirely wrong about the landlord needing rent. That did not make the season less painful.

Eventually I moved in with a friend. There is humility in rebuilding when the life you had pictured for yourself has become smaller in very concrete ways. It is one thing to speak publicly about resilience. It is another to look at your belongings and work out where you are going to sleep.

Then I got a job. I worked. I studied. I rebuilt. Later, I resigned to run again.

That sentence looks questionable even to me when I read it now.

But public service mattered to me, and I still believed there was work I could do. So I tried again.

When I am stressed, I tend to withdraw.

I also console myself with food.

For a while, that was how I coped. Food did not ask me to explain what had happened. It did not require me to be optimistic. It was simply there.

I ate three meals a day and snacks between them. I ate late at night. Social gatherings had food, and I ate because food was available. Processed foods, wheat products, sodas, and sugar in tea and coffee

were ordinary parts of my routine.

I did notice the weight. I was not unaware of it, and I did not wait until one photograph to have the thought that I should change.

I tried.

I would decide I was going to eat better. I would promise myself that I would not eat something, and then I would eat it. I would tell myself I was starting properly, do well for a while, lose the thread, and begin negotiating with myself again.

Tomorrow is a very generous place. It accepts every plan we do not want to carry out today.

I knew enough about health to know what better choices looked like. Knowledge was not my problem. Consistency was.

That distinction became important later. I did not need one more piece of information telling me that vegetables were better for me than constant snacks and sugary drinks. I needed to become a woman whose private decisions had weight with herself.

At that stage, they often did not.

I could make a promise to myself in the morning and overrule myself by evening. The broken promise looked small because nobody else had heard it. But repeated often enough, those small private negotiations changed the way I trusted myself.

This is why I am careful now when people reduce transformation to information. Most of us know more than we consistently practise.

The distance between knowing and doing is where much of the real work lives.

Then my sleep deteriorated.

Some nights I slept only four or five hours. Insomnia has a way of making the next day feel as though it begins before the previous one has ended. You wake already tired. Decisions feel heavier. Comfort becomes more attractive. The body you are asking to carry you through stress is also the body you are not allowing to recover.

At the time, I did not sit down and announce, “I am emotionally eating.” I was living.

That is important to me now because hindsight can make us unfair to our former selves. We look back after change and turn every old habit into evidence of laziness or weakness. Life is rarely that simple.

I was disappointed. I was stressed. I had responsibilities. I was sleeping poorly. I withdrew. Food became comfort.

And my body changed.

The weight did not arrive in one dramatic moment. Neither did the loss of energy. Neither did the discomfort in my knees. Neither did the gradual loss of interest in photographs.

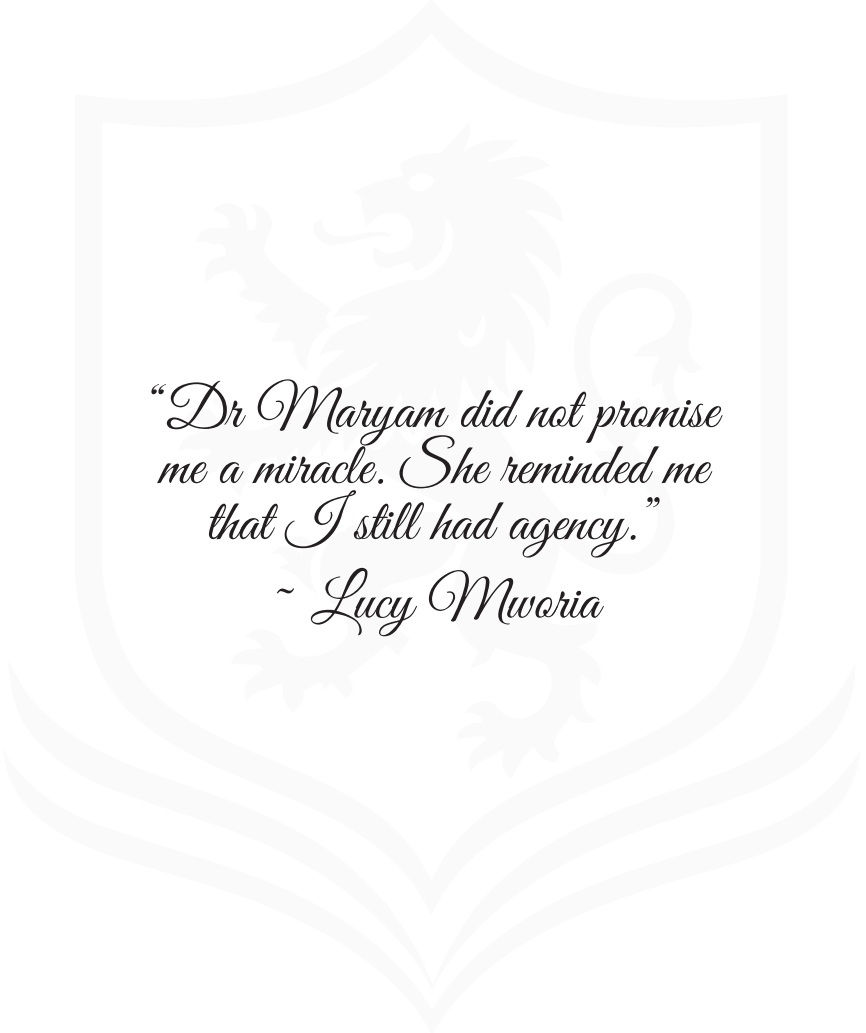
A woman can disappear from herself by inches.

That is one reason it can take so long to notice.

Reflective Question:

What happened around the time you began the habit you now criticize yourself for? What changes when you look at the whole story instead of only the habit?





*“Dr Maryam did not promise
me a miracle. She reminded me
that I still had agency.”*
~ Lucy Mworira

CHAPTER THREE

Huyu Mama Ni Kibonge

Sometimes life gives you a profound moment of self-awareness.

Sometimes two men trying to get you into a boat call you kibonge.

The setting was beautiful: a villa out over the water, the kind of place that makes inconvenience look romantic because the only way in and out is by boat.

We had spent the afternoon out on the water. At one stop there was music, dancing and plenty to drink. I joined in. I danced. I drank. I enjoyed myself.

By the time we were returning, I was not approaching the next logistical challenge with the precision of a sober athlete.

I stepped off the boat at a dock and then discovered that I was not, in fact, finished with the boat. I needed to get back in.

This became a problem.

The dock was slippery. My knees hurt. I weighed around 115 kilograms. Getting down into the boat required a combination of balance, flexibility and dignity, and I was temporarily short of all three.

Titus, my driver and a man who by then might as well have been another son, found the situation extremely entertaining. He was laughing when I felt he could have been applying himself more seriously to rescue operations.

The men helping with the boat tried to lift me. That was when I heard the assessment: “Huyu mama ni kibonge bwana.” This mama is big.

They were not whispering.

They tried. I tried. The boat refused to cooperate with our strategy. Eventually people had to get out and the boat had to be repositioned closer so I could be pushed and manoeuvred back in.

By then I was laughing too, partly because the alternative was to submit a formal complaint to the Indian Ocean.

When I tell the story now, I say I was rolling around the boat and then rolled into the villa. My family knows I am painting the picture. The point is that I felt enormous, unsteady, slightly drunk, and completely ridiculous.

That was my Zanzibar experience as a kibonge.

On a trip to Zanzibar, I stayed at a hotel that could only be reached by boat. By then I had gained a great deal of weight. Getting into the boat was not graceful. Two men had to help me.

As they did, they commented to one another, “Huyu mama ni kibonge.”

This mama is big.

There are moments when dignity suggests you should pretend you did not hear something.

There are also moments when the only reasonable response is to tell your family later and let everybody collapse laughing.

My family did exactly that.

I laughed too.

That story is funny to me. It was also true. Those two things can coexist.

I had become much heavier than I was comfortable being. Movement required more effort. My knees hurt. I was beginning to organise my life around physical discomfort. The boat did not create that reality. It merely provided two witnesses with no commitment to subtlety.

I do not tell this story because I believe a larger body is a humiliation. I tell it because it captures something about that period of my life: I could laugh, carry on, travel, work, and still know privately that I did not feel well.

Humour has always helped me survive the absurdity of being human. If I waited until every difficult thing stopped being funny before I laughed, I would miss half of life.

Later, when I became serious about my health, I did not need to turn the Zanzibar version of me into an enemy. She was still me.

She deserved care, not punishment.

But I was allowed to want something different for her.

Reflective Question:

Can you tell the truth about something you want to change without turning the person you were into someone you despise?



CHAPTER FOUR

The Photograph

I did not discover that I had lost myself while standing in front of a mirror. I discovered it on Facebook, and the shock of seeing those photographs remains difficult to describe.

I had joined members of Older Persons Organisations on a courtesy call to the Cabinet Secretary responsible for Social Protection. It was important work, the kind of work I understood and had become accustomed to doing. I knew why I was in the room. I understood the issues before us, I knew the concerns we were bringing forward, and I was comfortable speaking on behalf of people whose interests and dignity mattered to me. I was engaged, articulate and completely at ease in my professional role.

After the meeting, photographs from the courtesy call appeared on the Cabinet Secretary's Facebook page.

I clicked on them casually.

Then I stopped.

I stared at the screen.

For a few seconds, I could not believe that the woman in the photograph was me.

I enlarged the picture, hoping that perhaps the angle had been unkind, that the camera had distorted something, or that I was simply seeing an unfortunate photograph. I moved from one image to another, almost willing the next picture to look different. It did not. There I was, in photograph after photograph, standing among the people I had gone there to meet, smiling and looking perfectly composed, while I felt completely stunned by what I was seeing.

My first reaction was disbelief.

My second was shock.

My third was an uncomfortable recognition that I could no longer explain away what was in front of me.

The woman was me.

I remember thinking, *When did this happen? How did I get here without seeing it?*

That was the disturbing part. It had not happened overnight. I had not woken up one morning and suddenly become a woman I did not recognise. It had happened gradually, in small changes that were easy to excuse and even easier to overlook. Yet the photograph gathered all those changes into a single frame and presented them to me without the explanations I had been using to make myself comfortable.

I was horrified.

I say that plainly because I think there are moments in a woman's life when pretending to be diplomatic with herself serves no purpose. I

did not look at that photograph and think, “Perhaps I need to lose a little weight.” I looked at it and thought, This cannot be me.

And yet it was.

I looked at the woman in the picture and felt that strange distance between recognition and familiarity. I knew her face. I knew the clothes she was wearing. I knew where she had been standing and why she had been there. But the woman I saw did not feel like the woman I carried in my mind when I thought of myself.

It was not simply the number on the scale that shocked me. It was the realisation that I had become disconnected from the way I saw myself.

For years, I had loved dressing well. I loved beautiful dresses, elegant shoes and the small pleasure of putting an outfit together with care. I loved the feeling that came from looking in the mirror before leaving the house and knowing that I had made an effort. I owned six pairs of four inch heels that I particularly loved because I knew exactly which dresses belonged with which shoes. Getting dressed had once been one of those ordinary pleasures that made me feel good about myself.

By then, the heels were mostly resting in my wardrobe.

My knees hurt, and I had begun wearing flat, open shoes that I could easily slip off in the car. People around me had explanations for the pain. I was told it was arthritis. I was told it was age. I heard variations of the same message often enough to begin believing it myself: after fifty, perhaps this was simply what happened.

The body became heavier. The knees became painful. High heels became impractical. Certain activities became things you used to do. A woman adjusted herself to what her body would permit and carried on.

Perhaps that was how I had managed not to confront what was happening. I had accepted one small adjustment after another until the accumulated changes no longer looked small.

I had stopped asking why I could no longer do certain things comfortably. I had simply started doing them differently.

But the photograph changed something.

Suddenly I could see the difference between adapting and surrendering.

I missed the woman who enjoyed dressing. I missed choosing a dress because I loved it rather than because it hid the parts of my body I did not want to see. I missed photographs that I could look at without immediately searching for an angle that made me appear smaller. I missed videos in which I could watch myself without becoming distracted by my size. I missed dancing without thinking about my knees. I missed moving through the day without constantly being aware of my body.

Most of all, I missed the excitement of being Lucy.

That photograph disturbed me because it showed me something I had managed not to examine closely. It was not only that I had

gained weight. It was that I had gradually become unfamiliar to myself.

Yet there was another truth that made the situation even more complicated.

I had not lost my ability to lead. I had not lost my voice or my professional confidence. I could still walk into an important room, engage with people in authority, advocate for others and speak clearly about matters that mattered deeply to me. I could still function. I could still perform. I could still accomplish.

Publicly, I was still Lucy.

Privately, however, I had stopped feeling entirely at home in myself.

That distinction became important to me because I learned that confidence is not one thing. A person can be confident in her work and deeply uncomfortable in her own body. She can be decisive in a meeting and uncertain in front of her own mirror. She can be dependable to everyone around her while quietly breaking promises she makes to herself. She can be strong in circumstances that demand strength and still reach a point where she admits that something is no longer working.

I was all of those things.

What made that period particularly deceptive was that I had not disappeared from public life. I was still attending meetings, appearing on stages, participating in events, being photographed and appearing in videos and on social media. I was still visible.

From the outside, there was no dramatic collapse that would have warned anyone that I was becoming increasingly uncomfortable in my own skin.

I showed up.

That is why I have come to believe that we should be careful about judging wellbeing by appearances. A woman does not have to look defeated before she is allowed to admit that something in her life is not well. Competence can conceal a great deal. So can a smile. So can good clothes. So can lipstick and confidence in the workplace.

I could stand beside important people, smile for the camera, discuss the rights and dignity of older persons and do the work I had come to do. Then I could return home, take off the flat shoes I had substituted for the heels I loved, sit down and feel the ache in my knees after standing for too long.

Both women were me.

The public woman was not an act. She was real. The woman who laughed, worked, led and advocated for others was genuinely confident in those spaces. But the private discomfort was real too. I had simply become very good at keeping the two worlds separate.

In fact, I think my public confidence made it easier for me to postpone the private problem. Because I was still working, still contributing and still functioning, I could point to everything I was accomplishing and tell myself, See? I am fine.

Fine is a useful word. It allows us to move on quickly when someone asks how we are doing. It saves explanations. It protects privacy. But sometimes “fine” becomes a hiding place.

The photograph broke through that hiding place.

It did not expose me to the world because I was already visible to the world. It exposed me to myself.

For the first time, I could no longer tell myself that I was imagining things, that people were exaggerating, that it was simply age, or that I should accept my discomfort as an inevitable part of getting older. The photograph had become evidence. More importantly, it had become a question.

Is this really how I want to feel in my own body?

I did not yet have the answer to what I would do about it. I had no carefully constructed plan. I had not discovered One Meal a Day. I had not become devoted to walking along Bofa Road. I had not started dancing in my living room or lifting weights. None of that existed yet.

What existed was a moment of unmistakable clarity.

Something had to change.

I did not know exactly what the change would look like, but I knew I could not simply look away again.

That was the beginning.

Not the day I lost weight.

Not the day I changed my food.

Not the day I discovered a new exercise routine.

The beginning was that photograph, and the shock of finally seeing myself with enough honesty to admit that I wanted something different.

Looking back, I am grateful for that uncomfortable moment. At the time, I would not have called it a gift. I was shocked, embarrassed and deeply unsettled by what I saw. But sometimes the truth arrives before we are ready to welcome it, and sometimes the thing that disturbs us most is precisely what finally wakes us up.

The photograph did not tell me who I should become.

It simply showed me that I could no longer remain exactly as I was.

And that was enough to make me begin.

Reflective question:

Where in your life are you still functioning well while quietly feeling unlike yourself?

CHAPTER FIVE

How I Got There

My weight gain did not begin because I suddenly stopped caring about myself. Looking back, I can see that it emerged during a difficult period in my life, when several areas of my world became uncertain at the same time.

I had lost an election. There was no job waiting for me on the other side, and money was uncertain. The outcome affected more than my professional plans. Family responsibilities did not disappear simply because my circumstances had changed. The people who depended on me still needed me, bills still had to be paid, and life continued to demand the same level of responsibility from me even though the path ahead had become less clear.

I found the uncertainty difficult.

When I am under significant stress, my natural tendency is to withdraw. I become quieter and spend more time inside my own thoughts. I do not necessarily talk about what is troubling me, and I have often found it easier to carry difficult emotions privately than to explain them to someone else.

At the same time, I have always found food comforting.

There is something deeply human about turning to food when life feels unsettled. Food can provide pleasure, familiarity and a temporary sense of comfort when other things seem beyond our control. For me, it became an easy source of consolation. It was always available, it did not require an explanation, and for a few moments it allowed me to focus on something pleasurable rather than on the uncertainties occupying my mind.

The problem was not a single meal or even a particular food. The problem was the pattern that gradually developed around eating.

I ate three meals a day, but I also snacked between meals and often ate late at night. When I attended social gatherings, I could easily continue eating simply because food was there. Processed foods and wheat products had become ordinary parts of my diet. I drank sodas, and I routinely added sugar to my tea and coffee. None of these choices seemed particularly alarming when viewed individually. They were simply part of how I was eating and living at the time.

My sleep was also changing.

I developed insomnia and sometimes slept for only four or five hours a night. I began to understand how much poor sleep can affect the way a person feels, thinks and functions, although at the time I did not necessarily connect it with my changing weight. I was simply tired, stressed and trying to get through each day.

That is how unhealthy patterns often establish themselves. They rarely arrive announcing the consequences they will eventually

bring. A late-night meal does not tell you that it is becoming a habit. One packet of processed food does not appear particularly important. A sweetened cup of tea is just a cup of tea. A few hours of missed sleep can be explained away as a temporary inconvenience.

A stressful week becomes another stressful week, and eventually the weeks become months.

By the time I began to recognise what was happening, the accumulation had become difficult to ignore.

It showed itself in my weight, but that was only part of the story. I had less energy than before. My knees hurt. My clothes began to feel uncomfortable. My sleep remained poor. I was increasingly aware of my body in ways I had not been previously, particularly when I saw myself in photographs.

Yet I did what many of us do when confronted by changes we do not know how to explain. I looked for reasons that would make them easier to accept.

I blamed age.

I blamed menopause.

Those explanations were convenient because they made my situation feel inevitable. If the changes were simply the unavoidable consequences of getting older, then perhaps there was little point in fighting them. I could adjust my expectations, make myself comfortable and accept that certain parts of the woman I had once been were simply no longer available to me.

But deep down, I was not satisfied with that explanation.

I knew I was getting older, and there was nothing wrong with that. Age is a privilege, and I had no desire to deny the passing of time. What troubled me was the assumption that growing older meant surrendering parts of myself that still mattered to me.

I did not want to spend the rest of my life negotiating with my knees. I did not want to remove my shoes in the car simply because my legs and feet could no longer tolerate what I once enjoyed. I did not want to avoid photographs because I was uncomfortable with what they might reveal. Most of all, I did not want to keep telling myself that the woman I remembered belonged to another age.

Perhaps the most important thing I began to understand was that getting older and giving up were not the same thing.

Age could explain some of the changes I was experiencing, but it did not have to determine what I did next. I could acknowledge that my body had changed without accepting that change as the end of the story.

I began to see that there was a difference between accepting myself and giving up on myself. Acceptance meant recognising where I was without judgement. Giving up meant deciding that nothing could or should change.

I was not yet ready for a complete transformation, and I certainly did not have all the answers. But something had shifted in me. I was beginning to question the story I had been telling myself about what was inevitable and what was not.

For years, I had thought of change as something that happened when circumstances changed around me. I was beginning to understand that sometimes change begins when we decide to respond differently to the circumstances within us and around us.

My weight had not appeared overnight, and neither would it disappear overnight. The habits that had brought me there had developed over time, and changing them would also take time. What mattered first was recognising the connection between what I was experiencing emotionally and the choices I was making physically.

I had been carrying uncertainty, disappointment and stress, and I had found ways of comforting myself without asking what those comforts might eventually cost me.

That realisation did not make me feel ashamed. It made me curious.

I began to ask myself a different question: what had changed in my life before the habit I now wanted to change appeared?

That question is worth asking whenever we find ourselves struggling with a habit that no longer serves us. Sometimes the behaviour is not the beginning of the story. It is the response to something that came before it.

For me, food had become part of the way I coped with stress, while withdrawal had become part of the way I coped with difficult emotions. Understanding that connection would become an important part of learning how to change.

A Moment to Reflect

Before trying to change a habit, it may help to look back with honesty and compassion rather than blame. Ask yourself what was happening in your life before the habit became established. Was there a loss, a disappointment, a period of uncertainty, increased responsibility, loneliness, exhaustion or some other change that affected you?

Reflective Question:

What changed in your life before the habit you now want to change began?

CHAPTER SIX

The Seed

Seeing the photograph did not transform me overnight.

I wish transformation were that efficient. It would save all of us considerable time.

The photograph made me uncomfortable enough to try harder. I thought about dieting. I ate better for periods. I made promises. Then I broke some of them. I told myself I would not eat and later found myself eating. I would begin with conviction and discover that conviction had apparently left the premises by evening.

The problem was not that I did not care. I cared very much.

The problem was that wanting a different life and building a different life are not the same activity.

I had not yet built consistency.

That gap between intention and action is humbling because it happens in private. Nobody has to disappoint you. You hear yourself make the promise. You also hear yourself explain why today should be the exception.

For a while, I lived in that gap.

Then my knees took me to see Dr Maryam.

The conversation that changed my direction happened at Aga Khan Hospital in Kilifi.

I went because of my painful knees. By then, I had heard plenty of informal diagnoses. People with similar pain told me it was arthritis. Others told me it was simply what happened to older people.

Dr Maryam Badamana did not tell me that.

She told me that my weight was contributing to the strain on my knees. I weighed 115 kilograms. She told me I needed to lose weight and, crucially, that I could lose weight if I decided to.

That sentence stayed with me.

You can do it if you decide to.

She did not promise me a miracle. She did not tell me that every pain would disappear or that one method would work for every person. She gave me something both simpler and more demanding: agency.

She could advise me. She could not decide for me.

That is why I say Dr Maryam planted the seed.

A seed is not the finished thing. It is possibility.

I went home angry with myself, but also awake.

For a long time I had been asking what was happening to my body. I began asking a different question: What am I willing to do about it?

I thought about the years ahead. If I continued in the same direction, where would I be in five years? Would movement become more difficult? Would I continue withdrawing? Would I keep telling myself that age had made the decision for me?

I had spent years believing that strength meant being able to carry whatever arrived. The doctor's conversation introduced another possibility: perhaps strength could also mean responding before the burden became heavier.

There is a difference between accepting yourself and abandoning yourself. I had confused the two at times. I thought kindness toward ageing meant I should stop expecting anything from my body. I thought accepting my circumstances meant I should not challenge habits that were making those circumstances harder.

I could love the woman at 115 kilograms and still want to care for her differently.

That became an important distinction. I did not have to hate myself into change. I could tell the truth and choose from there.

I did not want that future.

So I made a decision.

Not a perfect plan. Not a dramatic announcement.

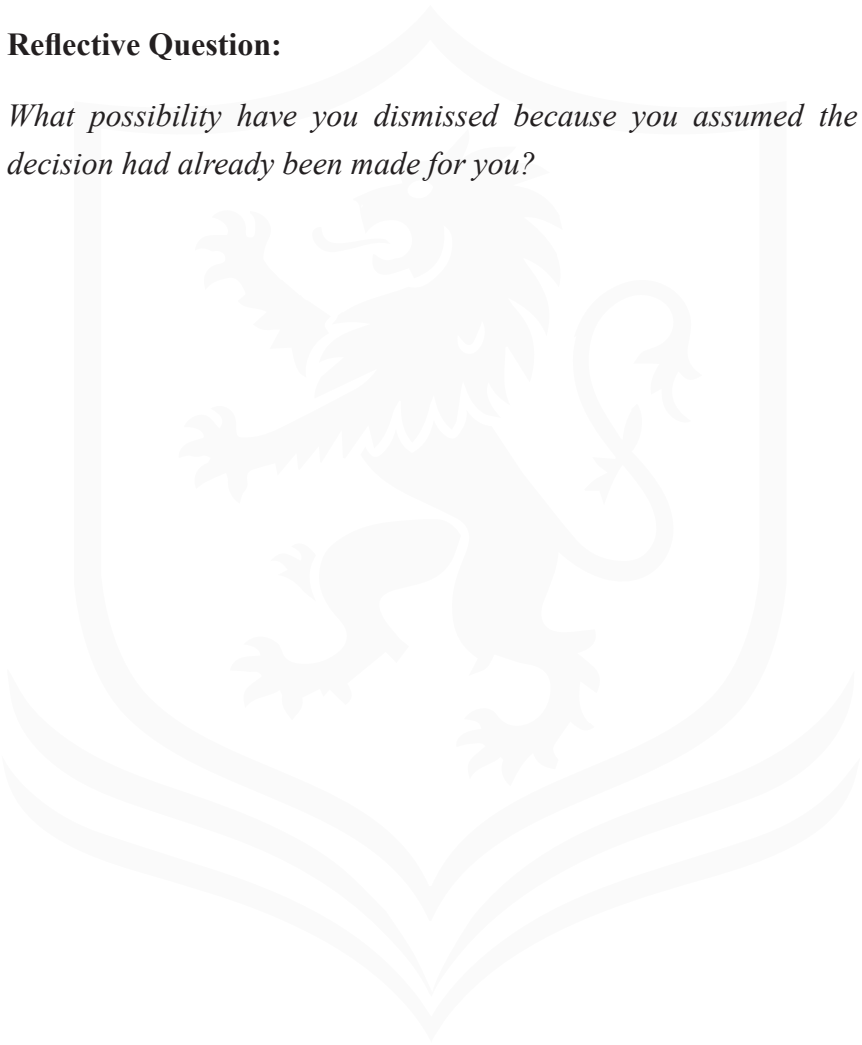
A decision.

I would stop treating myself as though I were the one person in my life who could always wait.

I realised, even then, that sometimes another person does not give us the answer to our problem. Instead, they help us see that a possibility exists where we had previously seen only limitation.

Reflective Question:

What possibility have you dismissed because you assumed the decision had already been made for you?





“Haba na haba hujaza kibaba.”
— *Little by little fills the measure.*
~ *A Swahili proverb*



PART TWO

Choosing Lucy

CHAPTER SEVEN

I Cleaned Out The Kitchen

If I was going to fight with myself, I was at least not going to stock the opposition in my own kitchen.

I had made my decision, and now I needed to act on it.

There are moments when a decision remains only an idea until something visible is done to prove that you mean it. I had spent enough time thinking about what I should do. I knew that if I wanted things to change, I could not continue living exactly as I had been living and simply hope that my intentions would somehow be stronger than my habits.

So I emptied the kitchen.

I opened my refrigerator, my cupboards and my pantry and removed the foods I had decided I no longer wanted to keep in the house. I got rid of the sodas, processed foods, sugary foods, refined carbohydrates, biscuits, sweets and other packaged foods that had become part of my ordinary eating habits. I gave them to my workers. I did not want them sitting on my shelves, waiting for a weak moment or inviting me to reconsider a decision I had already made.

When I finished, the kitchen looked completely different.

What remained was simple: meat, vegetables, eggs and avocados. That was about it.

Looking back, I realise that the contents of that kitchen represented much more than food. Removing those things was an act of commitment. I was saying to myself, very simply and very clearly, I am doing this.

I was no longer talking about changing. I was creating the conditions in which change could begin.

None of this felt particularly dramatic. There was no grand announcement and no audience applauding me for my determination. I was simply making changes in my own home, where nobody could see them and nobody could make them for me.

But there was something powerful about that.

I had reached a point where I did not want to keep making promises to myself and then quietly breaking them. I wanted my decision to have some weight behind it. I wanted to look around my kitchen and know that I had made a choice and acted on it.

It was a step beyond intention.

It was commitment.

I knew myself well enough to understand that there was little wisdom in deciding that I would no longer eat certain foods and then keeping them within easy reach. I did not need to test myself unnecessarily. I did not need to demonstrate extraordinary willpower by opening a cupboard and negotiating with myself every evening.

I preferred to make the decision once, at the supermarket and in my kitchen, rather than twenty times a day.

There was another reason emptying the kitchen mattered to me. I was tired of the gap between what I said I wanted and what I was actually doing. I had reached a point where words were no longer enough.

I needed action.

I needed to see something change.

And the kitchen was the most immediate place to begin.

There was something almost satisfying about opening a cupboard and finding that the things I had decided to move away from were no longer there. I did not have to argue with them. I did not have to exercise restraint every few hours. I did not have to make a fresh declaration every time I felt tempted.

I had already made the decision.

My environment now reflected it.

That mattered to me because I was not trying to punish myself. I was trying to support myself. I was not declaring war on food, and I was not trying to become morally superior to anyone who ate differently from me. I was simply taking responsibility for what I wanted to put into my own body.

My kitchen had become a statement of intent.

It said, without words, that something had changed.

For a woman who had spent much of her life being capable and decisive in the public sphere, there was something unexpectedly powerful about bringing that same decisiveness into my private life. I knew how to make difficult decisions at work. I knew how to advocate for other people. I knew how to walk into a room and speak when something needed to be said.

Now I had to do something equally important in my own life.

I had to act on my own behalf.

That was what emptying the kitchen represented. It was not the whole answer, and it was not the end of anything. It was simply the first physical evidence that I had stopped negotiating with myself and had begun to take my own decision seriously.

I had said that I wanted change.

Then I opened the cupboards, cleared the shelves and made room for it.

I emptied the kitchen, and in doing so, I made a statement to myself that I was finally ready to keep:

I am doing this.

Reflective Question:

What could you remove, rearrange, or protect so that the choice you want to make becomes easier?

CHAPTER EIGHT

Seven Kilograms of Evidence

The first seven kilograms mattered to me for a reason that had very little to do with seven.

They contradicted a story.

For a long time, I had heard versions of the same message: this is age, this is menopause, this is genetics, this is what happens. Some people told me that being big simply ran in the family. Others treated my desire to change as though I were attempting to negotiate with gravity.

Then the scale moved.

My dress size changed.

My body felt different.

The result was not yet dramatic enough to silence everybody around me. In fact, some people told me they could not see any change at all.

That was useful information.

Not because they were right, but because I began to understand how dangerous it would be to make other people's reactions my measurement system.

If I needed applause every week, I would fail the first week nobody clapped.

If I needed somebody else to notice before I believed my own effort mattered, I would give strangers too much power over my life.

The first visible progress also changed the emotional temperature of the work. Until then, every choice required faith in a result I could not yet see. Once I had evidence, the future became less theoretical.

My knees did not suddenly become somebody else's knees. I did not wake with a new personality. But I could feel small differences. Clothes sat differently. Movement felt a little less demanding. The plan was no longer a speech I was giving myself. It was producing consequences.

That matters when you have disappointed yourself before. Evidence interrupts cynicism. It says: perhaps this time you are not merely talking.

Seven kilograms told me something privately: Lucy, keep going.

That became more important than whether anybody else could see it.

There is a stage in any change when the evidence is mostly yours. You know you slept better. You know you kept the promise. You know you walked when you did not feel like it. You know you did not reach for food every time stress arrived.

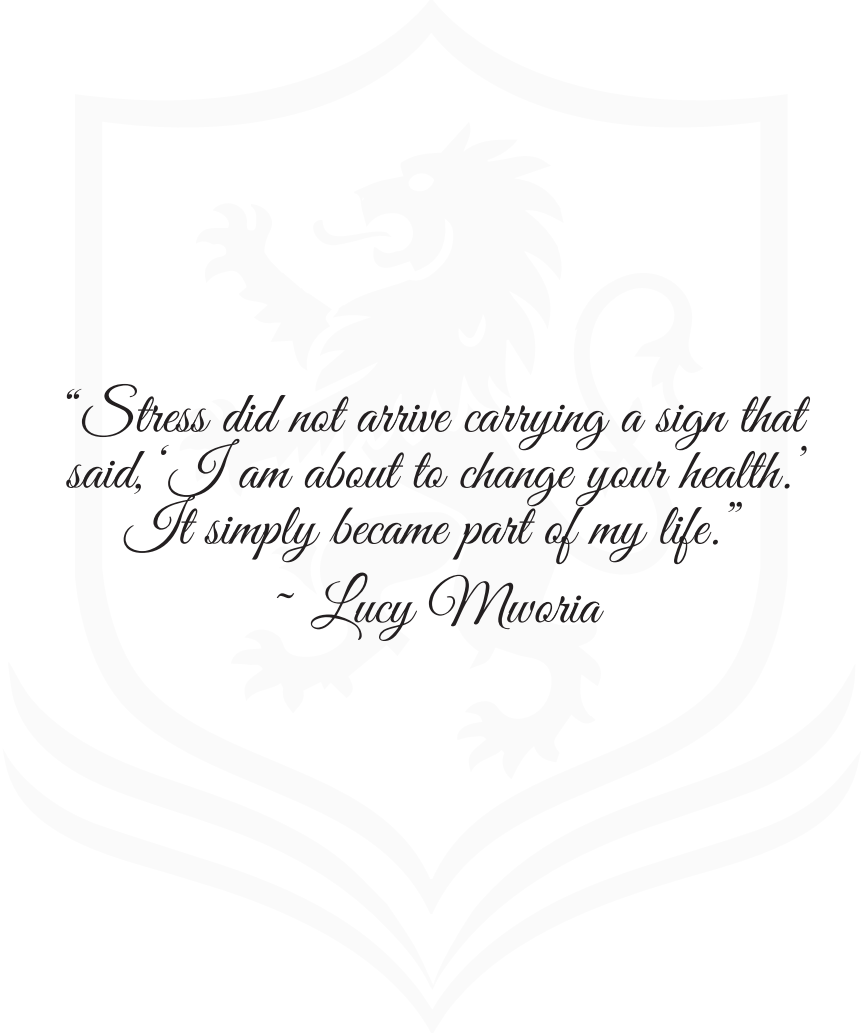
Protect that stage.

A seedling does not need an audience. It needs conditions that allow it to grow.

Reflective Question:

What evidence of progress have you been dismissing because nobody else has noticed it yet?





“Stress did not arrive carrying a sign that said, ‘I am about to change your health.’ It simply became part of my life.”

~ Lucy Mweria

CHAPTER NINE

The Hill Called Discipline

Motivation introduced me to change. Discipline kept us acquainted.

After the first seven kilograms, I began taking One Meal a Day, or OMAD, seriously.

The transition was significant.

I had been accustomed to breakfast, lunch, dinner, snacks, late-night eating, and food as part of social life. Suddenly I had to learn the difference between hunger and habit.

They are not the same.

Sometimes I wanted food because my body was hungry. Sometimes I wanted it because the clock said I usually ate then. Sometimes I was bored. Sometimes I was stressed. Sometimes I simply knew exactly what was in the kitchen.

The first weeks taught me to notice the difference.

I chose an eating window and built my meal around simple foods that satisfied me: eggs, fish or lean meat, beans and lentils, vegetables, traditional greens when available, salads, yoghurt or fermented milk, avocado, and water.

OMAD worked for me. I want to be clear about those words: for me.

I do not believe my personal success turns one eating pattern into a universal prescription. Bodies, health histories, medications, nutritional needs, and circumstances differ. Anyone considering a major change in eating pattern should seek appropriate professional advice.

What OMAD gave me psychologically was structure.

I no longer negotiated with food all day.

But structure is not magic. There were difficult hours. I wanted to eat from habit. I had cravings. I had to learn that a desire could be present without becoming an instruction.

This is where motivation became insufficient.

Motivation is wonderful when it visits. It is also unreliable. Some mornings it arrives dressed and ready. Other mornings it does not answer its phone.

Commitment had to carry me when motivation disappeared.

I began repeating three sentences:

I love myself.

I am doing this for me.

I am responsible for my actions.

The middle sentence became especially important.

I am doing this for me.

Not for the person who said I had lost no weight.

Not for the person who thought I was too old.

Not for the person who might compliment me later.

For me.

A hill is difficult partly because you can see how much farther there is to go. Many people begin climbing with enthusiasm and turn around when the excitement wears off.

Some days that decision looked impressive. Other days it looked like nothing anyone else would notice. I would simply reach the time when I usually ate and not eat. I would drink water. I would wait. I would remind myself that wanting something was not an emergency.

There were also days when I did not execute the plan perfectly. That became another test. Could I make one imperfect choice without using it as permission to abandon the whole effort?

Earlier versions of me liked the clean drama of Monday. If today had gone badly, Monday could become the day I transformed. Monday was organised, innocent and always a few days away.

Eventually I stopped needing Monday.

The next decision was close enough.

I decided I would keep climbing.

Reflective Question:

When motivation disappears, what commitment remains?



CHAPTER TEN

Protecting The Journey

There is one complication I should introduce before I pretend this was simply a battle between discipline and temptation.

Her name is Zena.

Zena lives in Kilifi and has been my friend for many years. She was raised on the coast and cooks the kind of food that makes a wellness plan reconsider its values: chapati, pilau, samosas, and the sort of meals that arrive with hospitality already built into them.

When I began losing weight, Zena had a very reasonable proposal whenever delicious food appeared: I could start tomorrow.

Then she would cook.

Then, if I survived the meal with any remaining discipline, she might pack food for me to take home.

This was not the sort of environment in which a person casually practised restraint. It required advance planning, emotional preparation, and occasionally the wisdom to leave the house before another serving appeared.

Zena's house also represented something I did not want wellness to take away from me: ease. Friendship. A place where one can arrive, eat, talk, laugh, and apparently choose from an unreasonable

number of beds when it is time to rest.

I did not want to become the woman who entered every home mentally calculating what she was allowed to enjoy. At the beginning, however, I needed stronger boundaries because my habits were fragile. Later, I wanted something more sophisticated than avoidance.

I wanted choice without fear.

A good friend who is a great cook is dangerous.

The danger is made worse by the sleeping arrangements at Zena's house. She has beds everywhere. This is not metaphorical. There are two beds in her room, beds in the other bedrooms, and a beautiful handmade Swahili bed on the covered front veranda, a family heirloom from her great-grandmother that she received for her wedding.

The veranda bed exists for afternoon naps.

So the sequence could become: eat excellent coastal food, discuss how I was definitely becoming serious about my health, and then lie down.

It was an extremely efficient system for postponing transformation.

But I want to be fair to Zena because food in friendship is not sabotage simply because the person receiving it has a goal. Zena feeds people because feeding people is one of the ways she loves them. At the coast, food is rarely just food. It is welcome, generosity, belonging, and sometimes an expression of concern that needs no

explanation.

That same instinct would later become profoundly important to me during a season when my family needed care more than anybody needed a lecture about eating windows.

I had to learn the difference between blaming people for offering love in the language they knew and taking responsibility for what I chose to do with the offer.

That distinction mattered.

It allowed me to remain grateful without surrendering my decisions. It reminded me that other people's kindness did not have to become my excuse. Equally, my commitment to health did not require me to reject every gesture of affection.

The hardest thing to remove from your environment is sometimes not food.

It is commentary.

As I became serious about changing my habits, I became more aware of the voices around me.

Some people told me I had not lost any weight.

Some believed being big was genetic in my family and that I would never become smaller.

Some told me, "As an old woman, what are you looking for by losing weight?"

Others assured me, “Pain on your knees is for old people. After fifty years nothing can reverse your years.”

Then there was this one: “Staying thin is not African. That’s a white man’s thing.”

Apparently everybody had been appointed to my personal wellness committee.

What fascinated me was how confidently people expressed opinions about a body that belonged to me. They spoke as though my health decisions required a public hearing and their approval before I could proceed.

Of course, some of the comments came from genuine concern. Others came from affection expressed clumsily. Some came from cultural beliefs about ageing, body size, and what a woman should look like at a particular stage of life.

But concern does not automatically make advice correct.

And familiarity does not automatically make an opinion authoritative.

Later, when the weight loss became obvious, the commentary did not disappear. It simply changed direction.

“You must be having a lot of issues. That’s why you have lost weight this much.”

“You are sick.”

“You must have used Ozempic injections.”

Apparently a woman's body can be public property at every size.

When I was heavier, people had opinions. When I lost weight, people had opinions. Had I waited for a version of my body that produced universal approval, I would still be waiting.

That realisation was liberating.

There is a particular exhaustion that comes from trying to make personal decisions in anticipation of everybody else's reaction. You begin to adjust yourself before anyone has even spoken. You imagine the questions, prepare the explanations, and rehearse the answers. Eventually, the opinions of others occupy more space in your mind than your own intentions.

I had to stop living that way.

For a while, I reduced time with people and in settings that made my new habits harder. That decision can sound severe when written in one sentence. In practice, it was temporary protection.

I was learning a new way to live. I did not need to place it immediately in the middle of every old pressure and prove its strength.

There is a temptation, when beginning a major change, to believe that discipline means exposing yourself to every possible challenge and conquering it. Sometimes we even turn this into a test of character. If I cannot sit beside a table full of food without eating everything, we conclude that I am weak. If I avoid the table, we conclude that I lack discipline.

I have come to see things differently.

Wisdom is not always about testing your strength. Sometimes it is about knowing when strength is still developing.

A person recovering from an injury does not begin by running a marathon to prove that they are healed. They allow the body time to regain its capacity. New habits deserve the same consideration.

Protecting a journey does not always mean ending relationships. Sometimes it means changing access. Sometimes it means not explaining. Sometimes it means smiling and changing the subject. Sometimes it means going home before the third round of food arrives.

It may mean choosing where to eat, how long to stay, or what to bring with you. It may mean telling a friend, kindly and without apology, that you are working on something important and would appreciate their support.

It may even mean learning to say no without turning the moment into a courtroom.

I discovered that I did not have to defend every decision I made. I did not have to convince people that losing weight was necessary. I did not have to produce medical reports, photographs, or a detailed account of my eating habits before being permitted to care about myself.

My responsibility was not to win an argument.

It was to live differently.

And sometimes it means understanding that the person discouraging you may be speaking from their own fear, habits, culture, or discomfort with change.

People often resist change in others because it reminds them of changes they have not made themselves. Your decision to become healthier can unintentionally make someone else uncomfortable with their own choices. Your discipline may expose their excuses. Your confidence may challenge their assumptions.

That does not mean they are bad people.

It means that not everybody will understand what you are doing, and not everybody needs to.

I did not need to make everybody a villain.

I simply needed to stop making everybody my authority.

There is a difference between listening to people and surrendering your judgement to them. There is a difference between respecting the wisdom of those around you and allowing their fears to determine your future.

I learned to ask myself a simple question whenever an opinion about my body or my choices unsettled me:

Is this person offering me wisdom, or are they simply offering me their own discomfort?

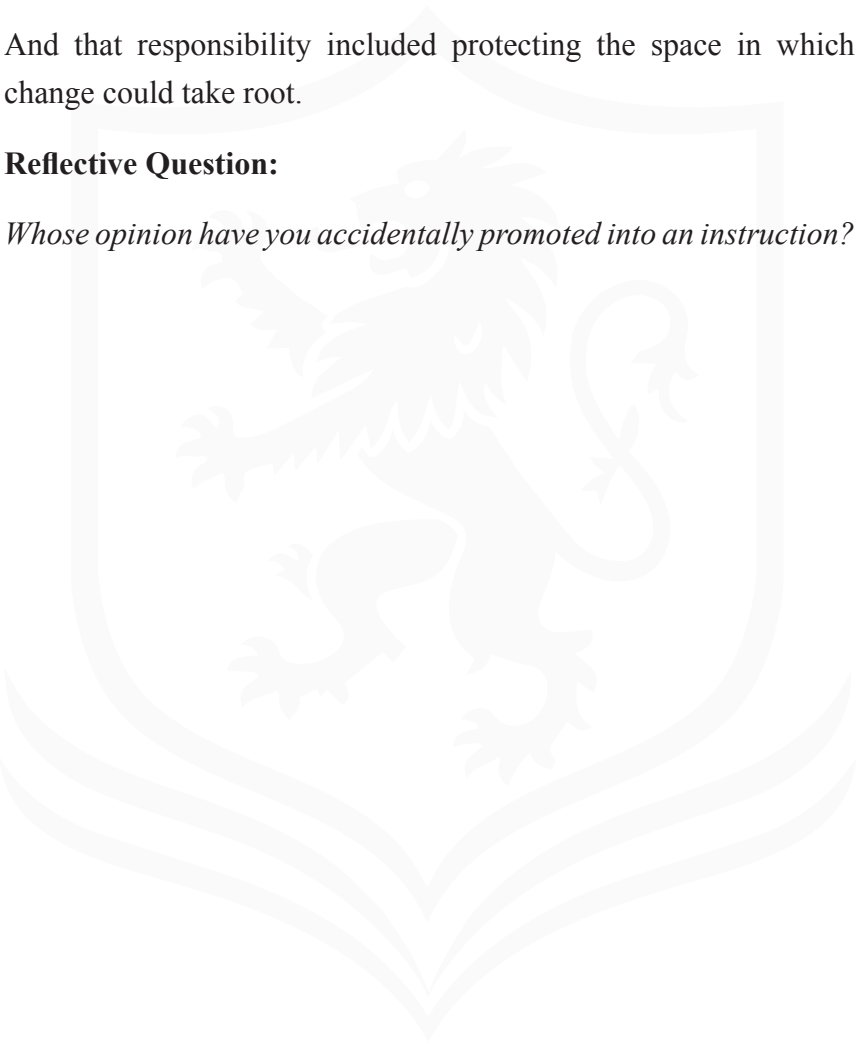
The answer was not always obvious. But asking the question gave me back something important: the right to decide.

My journey required protection, not because I was better than anyone else, but because I was finally taking responsibility for myself.

And that responsibility included protecting the space in which change could take root.

Reflective Question:

Whose opinion have you accidentally promoted into an instruction?



CHAPTER ELEVEN

Bofa Road

Eventually, movement stopped feeling like something I was doing to lose weight and became something I did because I liked my life better when I moved.

My first walks were not nine or ten kilometres.

They were negotiations.

My knees hurt, my legs hurt, and talking while walking could feel like an unnecessary luxury. There were days I skipped. There were days I thought, I cannot do this.

So I made the distance small enough that my mind could accept it.

I would walk for fifteen minutes away from home. That was all I asked of myself.

There was one useful trick hidden inside that plan: after walking fifteen minutes away, I still had to come back.

Thirty minutes completed.

After about a week, I could walk thirty minutes out. Returning made an hour. Eventually I could walk an hour in one direction and an hour back. Later, a walk of an hour and a half or even two hours one way no longer sounded impossible.

My motivation was wonderfully practical: if I walked away from my house, I had to return to it.

There is a Swahili saying, *Haba na haba hujaza kibaba* —little by little fills the measure. I did not need the proverb to know I was living it. Fifteen minutes became thirty. Thirty became sixty. The body I had thought was failing me began answering effort with capacity.

Walking became central to my mornings.

Along Bofa Road in Kilifi, I began walking from around six in the morning until eight. As my fitness improved, I covered roughly nine to ten kilometres, often around twelve to thirteen thousand steps.

Numbers are useful, but they do not explain why I kept going.

The road became an appointment with myself.

In the early morning, before the day filled with other people's needs, I could think. I could pray. I could notice the coastal air, the birds, the changing light, the people beginning their own days. Some mornings I solved problems. Some mornings I did not try to solve anything.

Bofa Road helped.

Kilifi has a pace that can feel like permission. The mornings are green and breezy, especially near the coast. My home is close enough to the beach that the air moves through differently. Along the road there are residents, other walkers, occasional tourists,

greetings, birds, and enough quiet to hear your own thoughts.

People say hello.

That sounds insignificant until you have spent years moving through days that feel like tasks. A greeting can return you to the fact that you are in a place, in a body, on a morning that will never happen again.

There was also a practical reassurance: if I truly overestimated myself, there were tuk-tuks around. I was building endurance, not auditioning for martyrdom.

Over time the road became familiar in the way a good ritual becomes familiar. I knew the light. I knew the air. I knew approximately where my body would begin negotiating and where it would settle into rhythm. The walk became prayer without always needing words.

For six months, I walked alone.

I did not mind.

Then Anita joined me.

Anita did not join because I recruited her. One evening she came to my house and asked if she could walk with me.

I loved that.

For months I had simply been doing something for myself, quietly enough that I could have assumed nobody cared. Then somebody knocked on my door because she had noticed.

Later Winnie joined us.

Later there were mornings when four or five people might be walking. The group could change. The road remained.

What had been one woman walking became three women talking, laughing, encouraging one another, and covering kilometres before much of the day had begun.

That development delighted me because I had not recruited them with a speech.

I had simply kept walking.

There is a kind of influence that comes from consistency. It is quieter than persuasion. People see what you are doing long enough to become curious.

“Can I come?”

Of course.

Walking also changed the story I was telling myself about my body. For a long time, I had experienced my body mainly through discomfort: the knees, the weight, the tiredness, the clothes that did not fit as I wanted.

On the road, my body became capable again.

It could carry me.

Then it could carry me farther.

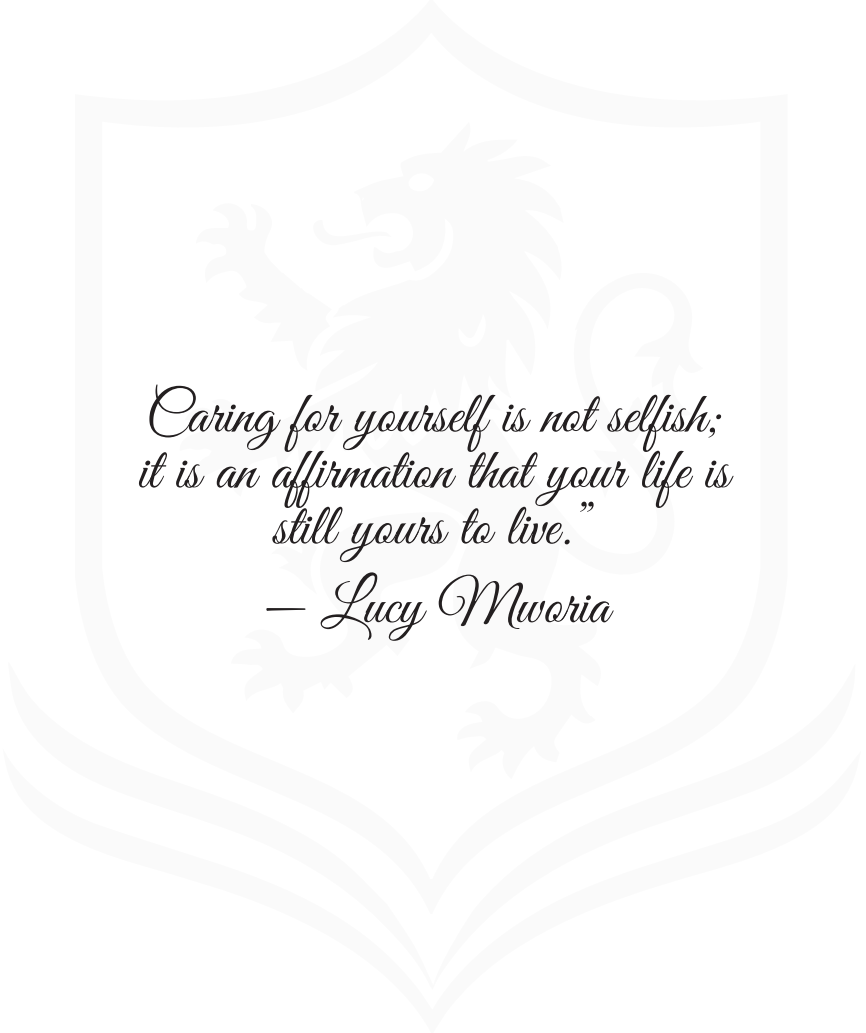
That mattered.

I was not trying to become an athlete. I was learning to enjoy inhabiting myself.

Reflective Question:

What form of movement makes you feel more alive rather than more punished?





*Caring for yourself is not selfish;
it is an affirmation that your life is
still yours to live.”*

— Lucy Mworira

CHAPTER TWELVE

I Danced My Way Back

I have always loved dancing.

Perhaps that is because, for many of us, dancing is not something we learn. It is something that lives somewhere deep inside us, waiting for the right rhythm to wake it up.

There is something about African music that can call to your spirit before you have even decided to move. The beat begins, the rhythm settles into your body, and somehow your feet know what to do. Your shoulders answer. Your hips find their own conversation with the music. The body begins to follow a flow that feels almost instinctive.

You do not always dance because you have decided to exercise.

Sometimes you dance because the music has found you.

And African music has a way of doing that.

The songs tell stories. They speak of heartbreak and unrequited love, of longing, betrayal, celebration, foolishness, hope, and the complicated business of being human. Some songs can make you want to cry. Others can make you laugh at yourself. And some make you wonder how the person who wrote them knew exactly what you were feeling when you had not even told anybody.

Sammy Kasule could get me moving without asking permission.

Then there was Nakei Nairobi by Mbiliabel, a song that seemed almost designed for one particular purpose: to make you move your waist. It was not asking politely.

Your waist had work to do.

And once the rhythm took over, you could forget that you were exercising. You were simply dancing.

Tabu Ley had a different effect. His music could be soulful and searching, the kind that made you pause even while your body kept moving. There was something about those lyrics that seemed to reach beyond the beat and ask questions of the heart.

Then came Joseph Kamaru, one of the most influential musician and artist in Kenya with a large music output of over 1,000 songs. His engagement with the music for more than fifty seventy years encompassed topical issues, social commentary, political satire and deep Cultural (Gikuyu) traditions.

Kamaru could have you laughing until you forgot that you were actually working out. There was humour in the songs, but the message stayed with you long after the last note. That was one of the beautiful things about that music; it put rhythm under your feet and entertained you while quietly teaching you something of value.

And then there were Miriam Makeba and Yvonne Chaka Chaka, both from South Africa, whose music carried its own kind of power. Their voices crossed borders, generations and moods. You could

listen, move, remember, and feel connected to something larger than yourself.

This was not punishment.

This was life.

Music could make me break a sweat and still leave me fulfilled.

I could dance for an hour or more. Sometimes longer. I did not have to convince myself that joy counted only if it happened inside a gym.

That was important to me because exercise is often discussed in the language of punishment. We burn off what we ate. We work off the weekend. We correct ourselves. We try to earn our way back into good standing with our bodies.

I did not want that relationship with movement.

I wanted movement to become part of living rather than a sentence imposed on me.

Dancing reminded me that a body can move because music is good and life is still happening.

There is a freedom in dancing when nobody has assigned you a number of calories to burn. You are not watching the clock and calculating how many minutes remain. You are not bargaining with a machine. You are responding to rhythm.

Sometimes you are smiling.

Sometimes you are laughing.

Sometimes you are sweating so much that you know you have done some serious work, even though it never felt like punishment.

That was the kind of movement I wanted to welcome back into my life.

As I grew stronger, I added more deliberate exercise and weights. At first, strength training seemed like something belonging to younger people or serious gym enthusiasts. I had the impression that weights came with a certain look, a certain age, and perhaps a certain level of confidence that I did not yet possess.

Then I discovered how satisfying it was to feel physically stronger.

The weights were not glamorous. Neither was repeating an exercise when I would rather stop. There were moments when I wondered who had convinced me that voluntarily making my muscles complain was a sensible way to spend my time.

But strength has a way of becoming visible in ordinary life.

Things feel easier.

Posture changes.

Confidence changes.

You begin to trust what your body can do.

That last part mattered to me.

For a long time, I had thought about my body mainly in terms of

what I disliked about it. Strength training gradually introduced a different way of looking at myself. Instead of asking only, “How do I look?” I began asking, “What can I do?”

Can I lift this?

Can I walk farther?

Can I move more easily?

Can I keep going?

Those are different questions.

They shift your attention from appearance to capability.

And capability has a way of changing how you carry yourself.

Posting was its own form of rebellion because I had spent years disliking photographs and videos of myself.

The strange thing is that I had never truly stopped being visible.

Public life had kept cameras around me. I could dislike the photograph and still attend the next event. I could know that I would inspect an image later with disappointment and still stand where the work required me to stand.

The camera had always been there.

What had changed was the way I saw myself in it.

When I began posting my wellness journey, the camera changed roles. I was no longer merely tolerating being documented because

I happened to be at an event. I was choosing to be seen while I was still becoming.

That was uncomfortable.

Very uncomfortable.

We are generally much kinder to the woman we hope to become than to the woman standing in front of us today. We tell ourselves that we will take the photograph when we have lost the weight, when our clothes fit better, when our faces look slimmer, when we feel more confident.

Then one day we realise that we have spent years postponing our own visibility.

I did not want to do that anymore.

I did not wait until I had the after photograph to permit the before woman onto the internet.

She deserved to be seen too.

I also posted my journey online.

Almost everything.

Walking. Dancing. Exercise. Progress.

Some people enjoyed it. Some were inspired. Some quietly watched.

And some apparently thought I had lost my mind.

One dancing video attracted a comment saying how ugly I looked and that I needed to go to the gym.

I was annoyed.

I was not spiritually evolved enough to float above it and send blessings into the universe.

I was annoyed.

But I kept going.

That may sound like a small victory, but it was not.

I had spent years allowing other people's opinions to influence how I felt about myself. One negative comment could easily become evidence for every insecurity I had already collected. It could remind me of photographs I disliked, clothes I avoided, mirrors I passed quickly, and all the other ways I had learned to make myself smaller long before my body actually became smaller.

This time, however, I had something different.

I had momentum.

I was changing, and I was beginning to understand that change did not require everybody to applaud.

Six months into OMAD, after losing about twenty-two kilograms, I put on the same dress and made another dancing video.

I knew exactly what I was doing.

I was not trying to prove that the people who had criticised me were wrong. I was not making the video so someone could finally give me permission to feel beautiful.

I danced because I wanted to dance.

Then I watched the video.

This time, I looked at myself and thought:

I look gorgeous.

So I posted it.

There was something deeply satisfying about that moment. Not because the number on the scale had changed, although twenty-two kilograms was significant. Not because I had suddenly become a different human being.

It was because I could finally look at myself without immediately searching for what needed to be corrected.

I could see myself.

And I liked what I saw.

The people who had been negative before did not return to announce that they had revised their position.

Human beings are interesting.

Nobody came to say, “You know what, Lucy, we were wrong.”

There was no formal apology. No committee meeting. No public announcement that my dancing had finally received the required certification.

There was simply silence.

That silence taught me something valuable.

If I had done the work for their approval, I would have been waiting for a payment that never arrived.

Fortunately, by then I had already been paid in a currency of much higher value.

I liked myself.

And liking myself was not the final destination.

It was the beginning of something even better.

I began to respect myself.

I respected the woman who had decided to start. I respected the woman who kept going when the results were still too small to impress anybody. I respected the woman who danced before she thought she looked good enough to dance. I respected the woman who went back to the weights, went for the walks, changed her eating habits, and kept showing up.

The weight loss was visible.

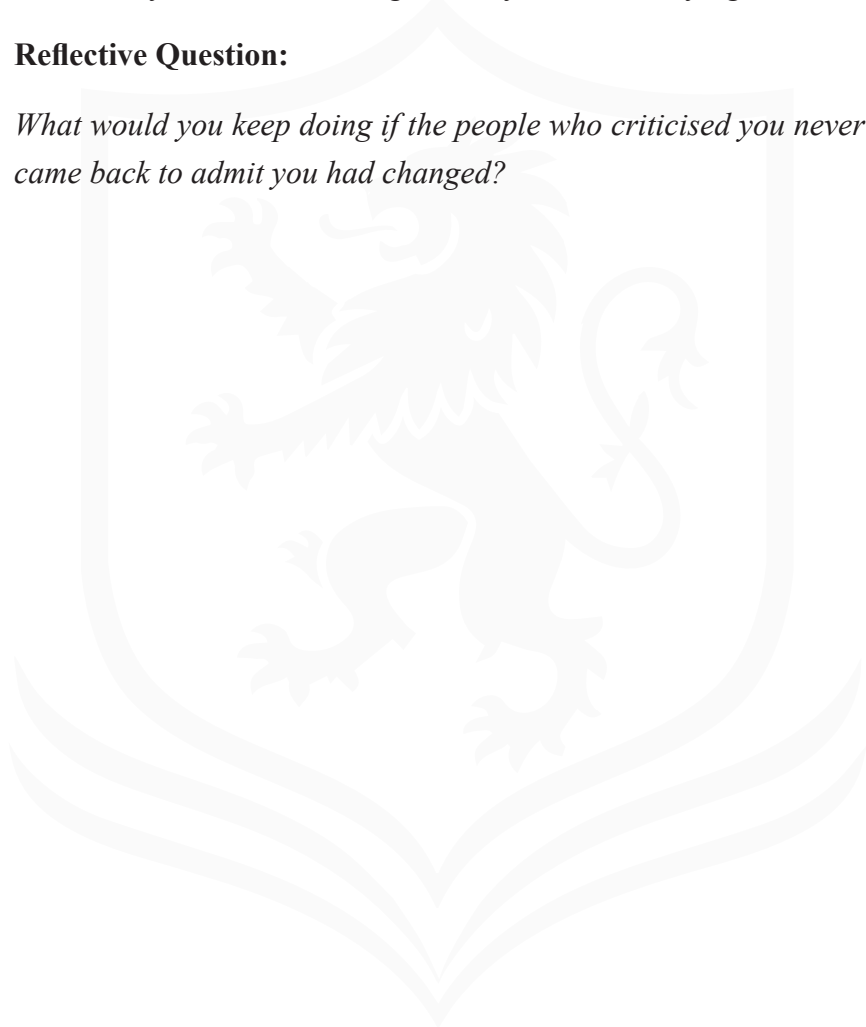
But the deeper change was not something a photograph could fully capture.

I was no longer waiting for my body to become worthy of celebration.

I had finally started celebrating the body that was carrying me there.

Reflective Question:

What would you keep doing if the people who criticised you never came back to admit you had changed?



CHAPTER THIRTEEN

The Photograph on My Screen

There was a particular photograph of myself from days gone by. I was wearing a size 12 or 14. I looked gorgeous, even if I said so myself. I remember looking at that photograph and wondering, what if I could look like that again?

I decided to place it on my phone and on my laptop screen, in places where I would see it often enough for it to become part of my thinking. I did not want it tucked away in an old album where I might occasionally come across it and wonder where that woman had gone. I wanted to see her often. More importantly, I wanted to believe that she was still possible.

By then, I was wearing size 18 and 20 clothes. The difference was not only in the labels. I remembered feeling lighter and more comfortable in my body, more interested in clothes and more willing to be photographed. I remembered the ease of getting dressed without first wondering what I needed to hide. The photograph reminded me that I had once felt at home in my body, and perhaps I could find that feeling again.

It became a quiet form of motivation. On difficult days, when the scale was stubborn or progress seemed slow, I would see the photograph and remember what I was working towards.

Looking back, I realise that this was more than motivation. I was beginning to practise visualisation without knowing its name.

Change often begins with the ability to see something before it becomes visible in your life. We do this naturally. A traveller looks at a map before reaching the destination. An architect sees the finished building before laying the foundation. A farmer plants a seed while already holding some picture of what it may become.

The destination does not make the obstacle disappear, but it changes the way we look at it.

I think about the familiar story of Napoleon crossing the Alps. The mountains were real, steep and formidable, but they were not the destination. Italy lay beyond them. He had to keep his eyes on what was on the other side rather than allow the mountain to become the whole story.

That resonated with me. There were days when the scale did not move, when my clothes still felt tight, and when I could not yet see the change I was hoping for. Those moments were real, but they were not the destination either.

A mother in labour knows something about this. The pain is immediate, but her mind is already reaching beyond it to the baby she will hold. She does not deny what she is experiencing. She simply knows that there is something beyond it.

I was learning to do the same. I did not have to enjoy every difficult day. I had to remember that the difficult day was part of the process, not the end of the story.

The photograph helped me do that. It could not make me lose weight, remove temptation or make the difficult days disappear. What it could do was keep the possibility in front of me. Each time I saw it, I was reminded not only of how I had once looked, but of how I wanted to feel again.

At first, however, I thought I was trying to go backwards. I thought the destination was an earlier Lucy. There is nothing wrong with wanting to return to a body size in which you once felt comfortable, provided you do not turn that size into a measure of your worth. The woman wearing size 18 or 20 was not less deserving of love than the woman in the photograph. She was the woman doing the work, and she deserved kindness too.

What I could not yet see was that I was not really going backwards. I was moving forward into a version of myself I had never met.

The woman in the photograph knew how she looked. The woman I was becoming was learning who she was. The journey was teaching me discipline without punishment, gratitude without complacency, and self-respect without conditions.

That is when visualisation began to mean something more to me. It was no longer simply about seeing a smaller body or fitting into a particular dress size. It was about imagining the life I wanted to live in that body. I pictured myself moving more easily, dressing without hesitation, enjoying photographs instead of avoiding them, and feeling at home in myself again.

The photograph gave me something concrete to look at, but the real picture was becoming much larger.

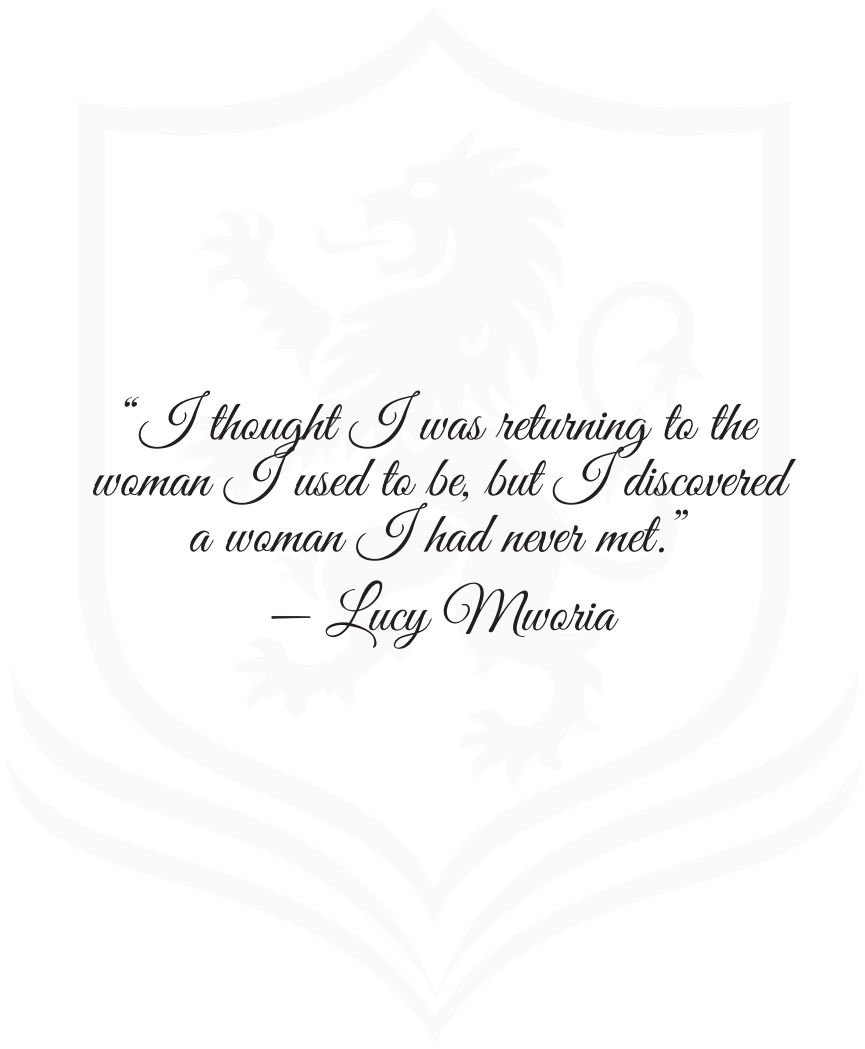
I was not simply trying to recover an old appearance.

I was imagining a new way of living.

The photograph gave me a destination I could see, but the journey was taking me somewhere I had never been. I thought I was trying to find the old Lucy. Instead, I was beginning to discover a new one.

Reflective Question:

What picture of the person you want to become are you holding onto, and how can you remind yourself that your present struggles are part of the journey not the end of your story?



*“I thought I was returning to the
woman I used to be, but I discovered
a woman I had never met.”*

— Lucy Mworira

PART THREE
THE WOMAN I FOUND

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

The Weight I Really Lost

People often notice the kilograms first. I understand. Thirty kilograms is visible. It changes a face, a waistline, the way clothes fit and the way a person moves. It is the kind of change that can be measured, photographed and discussed.

But when I think about what changed most, I do not begin with the scale. I lost the belief that age had already decided what was possible for me. I lost some of my fear of being seen, and I became less willing to allow every opinion to become an instruction. I also let go of excuses that had once sounded so reasonable that I mistook them for facts.

What I gained was just as important. I gained discipline, energy and a renewed joy in movement. I developed a better relationship with food and found the courage to post the dancing video even after someone had been cruel. I rediscovered the pleasure of putting on a dress simply because I wanted to enjoy wearing it. And, perhaps most importantly, I gained confidence.

For years, I had thought confidence was connected mainly to appearance. Appearance mattered to me, and I will not pretend otherwise. I love beautiful clothes. I still appreciate a good dress and, yes, I still love my heels.

But this journey taught me that the most durable confidence comes from somewhere deeper. It comes from keeping promises to yourself.

Every time I completed a walk I had said I would take, followed through on a decision when nobody was watching, or returned after a difficult day instead of deciding I had failed, I was collecting evidence. I was proving to myself, quietly and repeatedly, that I could trust my own word.

That, I think, may be the real centre of this book.

I had depended on myself in many ways before. I had crossed countries, raised children, worked, studied, campaigned, started again after losses, and carried responsibilities that required courage. I was not discovering competence for the first time after sixty. What changed was much more intimate. I began trusting myself in the small, private agreements that nobody applauds.

When I said I would walk, I usually walked. When I said I would return to my routine after an indulgent meal, I returned. When I told myself that somebody else's comment did not get to decide my next action, I practised proving that true. Those small acts accumulated, and with them came a growing sense that I could rely on myself.

My body had been speaking before I was ready to listen carefully. The pain, the poor sleep, the fatigue, the changing relationship with clothes and the reluctance around photographs had not arrived as one dramatic announcement. They had accumulated quietly. That is

how many forms of neglect work. There is rarely a single morning when a woman wakes up and says, Today I will disappear from my own priorities.

Instead, she adjusts. She accommodates. She buys the next size. She sits down sooner. She stops wearing the shoes that hurt. She tells herself she is too busy. She begins to regard discomfort as normal because normal feels easier than change. I had done many of those things without recognising that they were telling a story.

The difference now was that I had started listening.

Public achievement can give you confidence in what you can do. Private follow-through gives you confidence in what you will do when nobody is looking. I needed both, because one tells you that you are capable and the other teaches you that you can count on yourself.

That also changed the way I understood self-love.

Self-love is not always soft or indulgent. Sometimes it is drinking the water when you would rather have something else. Sometimes it is going to bed instead of staying up for one more episode. Sometimes it is declining an invitation because you are protecting a habit that is still taking root. Sometimes it is refusing to participate in a conversation about your own body. Sometimes it means doing something uncomfortable because the woman you are becoming deserves the benefit of what you are willing to do today.

I had spent years being responsible in many areas of my life. I had looked after other people, met obligations, solved problems and kept going when circumstances required it. This journey taught me to include myself among my responsibilities.

That sounds simple, but it was not. For a long time, I could justify putting myself last because there was always somebody or something that appeared to need me first. Learning to care for myself without apology required a different kind of courage. I had to stop treating my wellbeing as a luxury that could be postponed until everything else was taken care of.

Everything else is rarely taken care of.

There is always another responsibility, another meeting, another demand, another person who needs something. At some point, you have to decide that your own life belongs on the list too.

Looking back, I realise that one of the greatest changes was not simply learning what to eat or how to move. It was learning to take myself seriously. My choices mattered. My comfort mattered. My health mattered. The promises I made to myself mattered, even when nobody else knew I had made them.

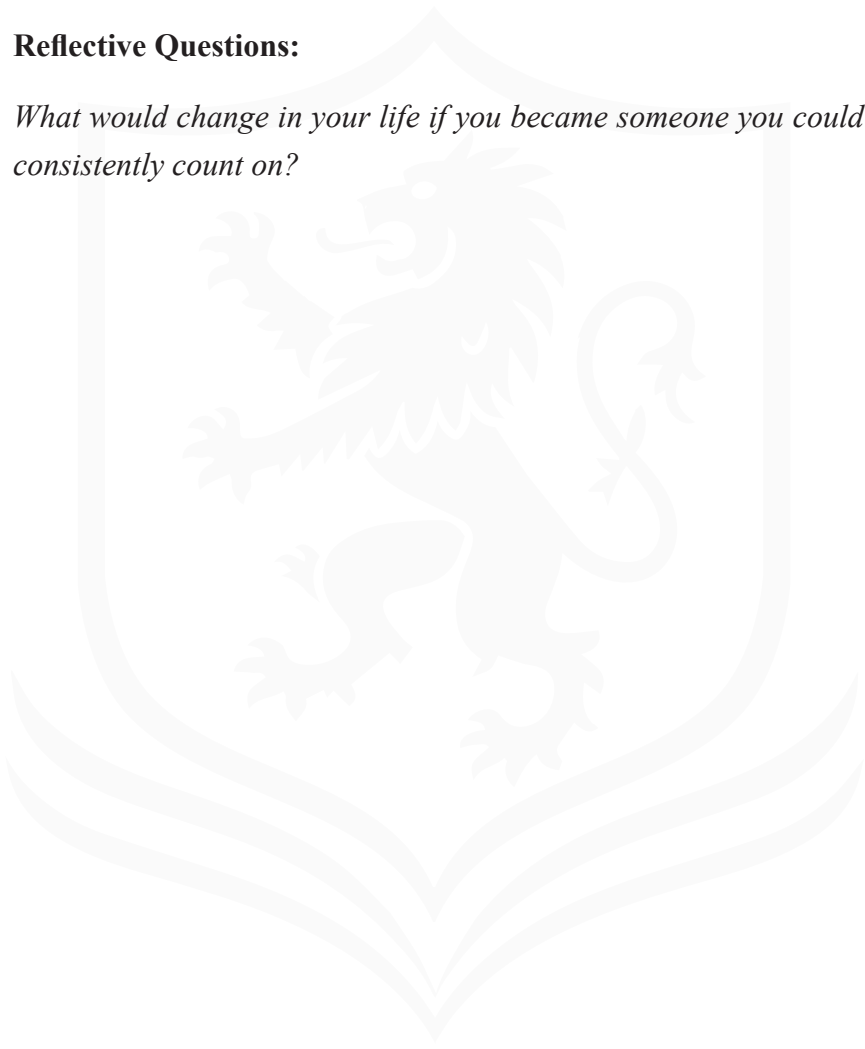
That is what built the confidence I have now. Not perfection, and certainly not getting everything right every day, but returning again and again to what I had decided mattered to me.

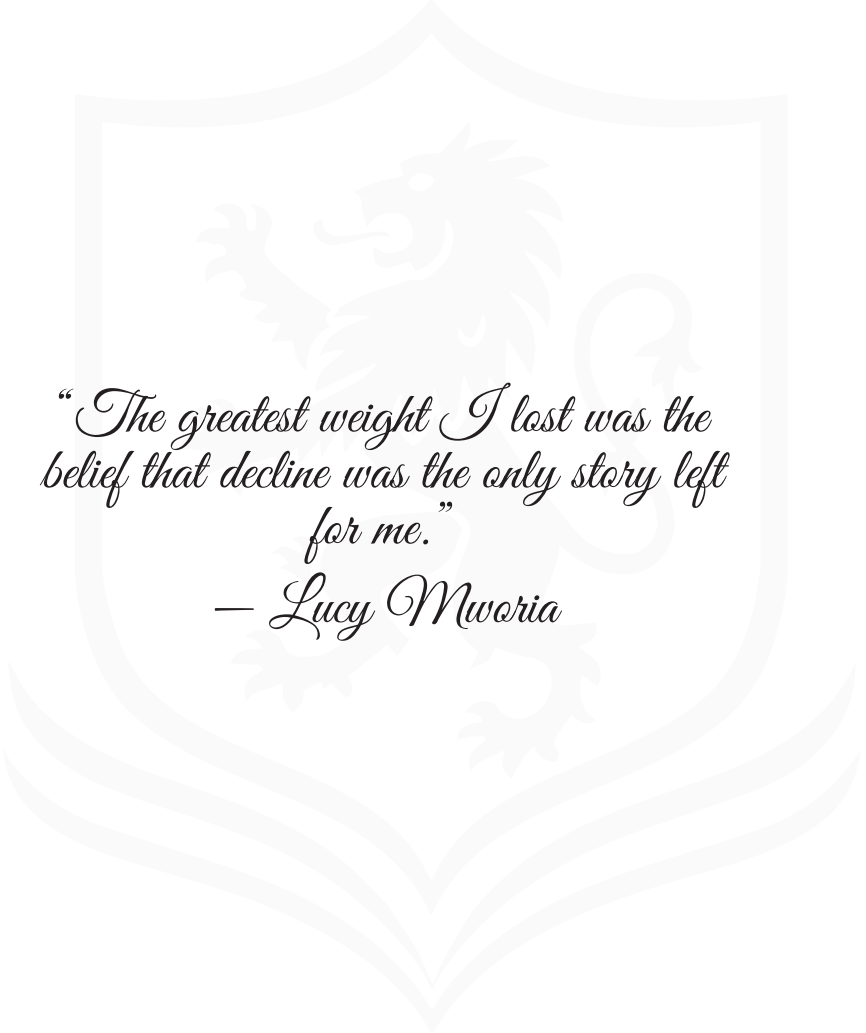
I had spent years being dependable for other people. This journey taught me the value of becoming dependable to myself.

And perhaps that is where real self-trust begins: not in making one grand promise, but in keeping the small ones often enough that you begin to believe yourself.

Reflective Questions:

What would change in your life if you became someone you could consistently count on?





*“The greatest weight I lost was the
belief that decline was the only story left
for me.”*

— Lucy Mworira

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

Taking Myself With Me

A wellness routine that only works inside your own kitchen is not yet a life.

Eventually, I had to learn how to travel without treating travel as either a prison or an excuse. At home, routine is easier. You know what food is available, where you can walk, when you are likely to sleep and what the day will demand of you. Travel rearranges all of it. There are different meals, different times, unfamiliar places, invitations, unexpected delays and the simple pleasure of being somewhere other than home.

The old version of discipline in my mind might have said, control everything.

The version I live now says, take yourself with you.

That was not always easy to understand. I used to think that staying on track meant protecting my routine from disruption. I gradually realised that a routine that collapses the moment life changes is too fragile to carry very far. Real life will always interrupt you. There will be holidays, funerals, celebrations, family visits, long journeys, late nights and days when the plan simply does not survive contact with reality.

The question is not whether the routine will be interrupted.

The question is whether you know how to come back.

I learned some of this on a trip to Diani. I cooked some meals at home so that I knew I would have healthy options available. I stayed away from sugary cocktails and alcohol. I moved. I walked on the beach. I kept some of the habits that mattered to me while allowing myself to enjoy being away.

I also went out.

That particular trip came during a tender season for our family, about a week after my son Murithi's funeral. My daughter and I needed time together. We did not arrive at the coast because grief had ended. We arrived carrying it with us.

I am wary of stories that make grief behave too neatly. Sorrow does not wait politely outside while you have a good afternoon. Neither does laughter ask grief for permission before it appears. You can miss someone terribly and still find yourself laughing. You can feel the weight of loss in the morning and enjoy an ordinary conversation in the afternoon. These things do not cancel each other out.

So we walked. We ate. We talked. We went out. We laughed harder than I expected to laugh. I missed my son. All of that was true at once.

There was something healing, though, about allowing ourselves to continue living without pretending that continuing meant

forgetting. The beach was beautiful. The air was different. There were meals to enjoy, conversations to have and moments when, for a little while, grief loosened its grip. I learned that taking care of myself did not mean putting sorrow aside. It meant making room for both sorrow and life.

My daughter has since informed me that she has creative control over the Diani stories. This is what happens when you allow your child to help with a book. Apparently, some family members become editors without ever being formally appointed.

One evening at Tandoori, my daughter became hungry after my eating window had closed. I was explaining, quite correctly, that late-night eating was not a good idea. Kendi's nutritional philosophy on holiday was apparently, "I'm in Kenya. If the kitchen is open, so is my mouth."

I disagreed with this philosophy and explained why.

The lecture would have been considerably more impressive if I had maintained it.

Then I became hungry.

My daughter noticed the collapse of my argument immediately. Children are very attentive when a parent's principles become inconvenient.

Before long, I was asking for the chef.

But if we were going to break the rule, I was not going to waste the occasion on badly prepared food. If we were going to eat, I wanted the kienyeji chicken prepared properly. There needed to be onions. A great many onions.

The eating window was closed, but apparently the kitchen consultation window remained available.

Kendi, who had just been lectured by me, watched as I summoned the chef himself and began giving instructions. She was enjoying this reversal far too much. There are moments when your children know they have won before you are willing to admit it.

We ate.

And the next day, life continued.

That part matters to me because the real lesson was not whether I had kept a perfect eating window that particular evening. The lesson was what happened afterwards. I did not wake up and announce that I had failed. I did not turn one late meal into a week of abandoning myself. I did not punish my body for having enjoyed food with my daughter.

I simply returned to my routine.

That ability to return became increasingly important to me because I began to understand that one imperfect decision does not have to become an identity. There is a difference between saying, “I made a choice that was outside my usual routine,” and saying, “I have blown everything, so I may as well continue.”

The second thought is where trouble begins.

Travel taught me that health cannot depend on perfect conditions. Sometimes you will make the better choice. Sometimes you will make the more enjoyable choice. Sometimes you will make a choice that, with hindsight, you might have made differently. None of those moments has to determine what happens next.

The train journey back to Nairobi offered another demonstration of my flexibility.

Zena had made the samosas herself. This detail matters because refusing a random samosa and refusing Zena's samosa are two very different levels of discipline.

On the train back to Nairobi, my friend Zena had samosas and mandazi. I said I did not want any. For a while, I meant it.

A short time later, I had placed a samosa inside a mandazi because apparently choosing between them had become an unnecessary limitation.

I had not merely changed my mind. I had created a fusion.

My daughter copied me.

Kendi looked at what I had done, decided this was genius rather than evidence against me, and made one too. We laughed about it for much of the journey.

This is wellness too.

Not the samosa inside the mandazi specifically. I am not presenting that as nutritional innovation.

But the laughter was part of it. So was the absence of guilt. So was knowing that we could enjoy a completely imperfect moment without turning it into a declaration that all our efforts had been wasted.

This became especially important because the old all-or-nothing way of thinking can make one enjoyable evening feel dangerous. If one meal means failure, then pleasure becomes threatening. If travel means losing control, then health begins to shrink your life instead of expanding it.

I did not want that.

I wanted to be able to go to Diani, spend time with my daughter, laugh at myself, walk on the beach, swim, meet people, order fish, supervise an unsuspecting chef, eat a samosa on a train, and still recognise myself when I got home.

That required a different kind of discipline from simple refusal. It required flexibility without becoming careless and enjoyment without losing sight of what mattered to me. Most of all, it required trust. I had to trust that one meal was not going to undo months of work and that returning to my routine mattered more than maintaining a perfect record.

Perhaps that is what sustainable wellness looks like. Not a life in which nothing ever goes wrong, but a life in which you know how to find your way back when it does.

I did not find myself by becoming perfect. I found myself by learning how to return to myself. And that may be one of the greatest freedoms this journey has given me. I no longer have to choose between living fully and taking care of myself. I can do both.

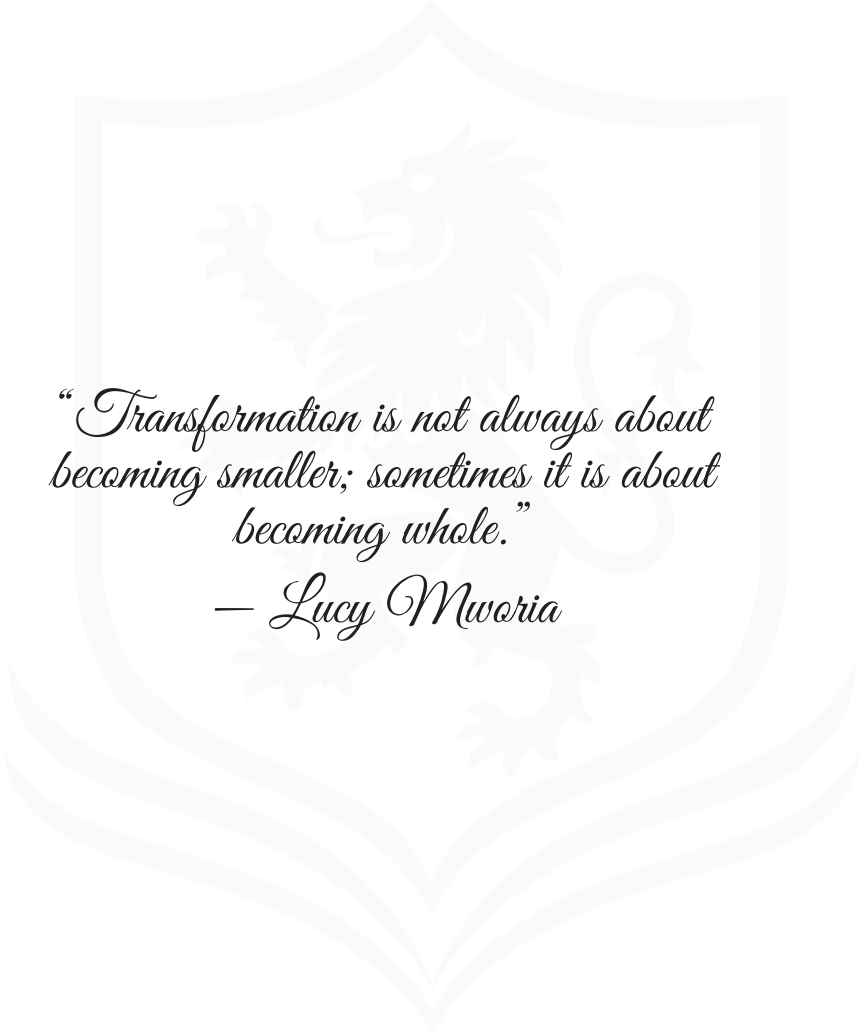
The routine can bend.

Life can happen.

And I can still come home to myself.

Reflective Question

When life disrupts your routine, do you know how to return to yourself without shame?



*“Transformation is not always about
becoming smaller; sometimes it is about
becoming whole.”*

— Lucy Mworira

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

A Hat, A Boat And A Jump Rope

Diani reminded me of another truth: when movement becomes part of your life, you stop needing it to look like exercise.

On the second day, we met Captain Alfie, who was trying to sell us a boat ride and snorkeling trip. Somehow, as conversations with strangers sometimes do, ours expanded. Before long he had been around much of the day, and at some point we were discussing a six o'clock morning beach workout.

Dancing helped correct an idea I had absorbed without noticing: that improving your body should feel like punishment. I had spent enough of life carrying serious responsibilities. I did not need wellness to become another serious responsibility with no joy in it. Music gave me another way to experience effort. I could sweat and laugh at the same time. I could become tired because I had been enjoying myself. That mattered. A routine built entirely on deprivation may produce results, but I wanted a life I would actually agree to keep living.

Captain Alfie had been trying to sell us a boat ride and somehow ended up spending enough time around us that by evening he was at Tandoori too. Somewhere between tourism and friendship, he and I decided a six o'clock beach workout was an excellent idea.

The return of clothes was not superficial to me. I had always enjoyed style. Dresses, makeup and shoes were part of how I played with presentation. When that pleasure disappeared, I noticed the absence even when I pretended not to care. Trying on clothes again was therefore not simply proof of weight loss. It was a return of curiosity. What would this look like? How do I feel in this? Which shoes? There was delight in asking those questions again. I had missed the woman who enjoyed getting ready even when nobody important was waiting.

Kendi did not share our enthusiasm.

My daughter declined the invitation with remarkable commitment.

She says she was protecting her peace. I believe she wanted to sleep.

I went.

We also went snorkeling.

My daughter looked at my sun-protection preparations as though I had imported sunscreen into Kenya personally.

I arrived prepared for the sun in a large hat, a light scarf, and enough sunscreen to suggest I had personally been assigned responsibility for the ozone layer.

I was protecting my skin.

Then I got into the water.

There are photographs that show weight and photographs that show life.

Kendi later told me that what she remembers most is how happy I looked. I like that she noticed.

The image I care about from that day is not a number. It is happiness.

The old me might have thought of exercise as something that had to be scheduled and completed. By Diani, I had become the sort of woman who could accidentally acquire an exercise companion while walking to nowhere in particular.

Another day, while walking on the beach, I met a young woman named Mary. Before I knew it, we were jumping rope together on the sand.

Captain Alfie took us to Sir William's Grilled Seafoods Restaurant after we met him on the beach. It was the sort of little place where the food mattered more than polished presentation. I wanted the tafi fresh, and I wanted the salad the way I wanted it.

Sir William was also the chef, which meant he became the latest person to discover that feeding Lucy can include consultation. I asked questions about the fish. I gave directions about the salad. Then fresh avocado had to be found next door because apparently I had introduced a procurement component to lunch.

When the plate finally arrived, fresh cabbage and greens were placed directly in front of me. Kendi and I looked at them.

I cannot prove what Sir William was thinking, but the expression seemed to say: Madam, after everything we have been through over this salad, here are some vegetables.

Fair enough. I chose not to interrogate the meaning of the cabbage. I ate it.

I did not need Bofa Road to be healthy. I loved Bofa Road, but the commitment was not to a road. It was to myself.

Joy became one of my measures of health. Not constant happiness—life does not offer that—but access to pleasure. Could I dance? Could I laugh at myself? Could I travel and enjoy the day instead of spending the whole day policing myself? Could I put on a dress because I liked it? Could I move without every movement becoming a reminder of discomfort? Those questions helped me understand why the journey mattered beyond a number on the scale.

Fair enough.

A sustainable life has to leave room for personality. I was not going to become healthy by becoming somebody else.

I was still Lucy—the woman who likes her food prepared properly, talks to strangers, makes plans, laughs loudly, and may turn a beach walk into a skipping session.

That was the point.

Reflective Question:

Does your idea of wellness make your life larger—or has it made your life smaller?

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

Food, Culture And The Right To Decide

Food is never only food.

Especially in our homes and communities, food can mean welcome, celebration, respect, generosity, comfort, memory, and love.

That makes changing how you eat more complicated than a list of carbohydrates and proteins.

A plate can carry a relationship.

A host may have prepared something because you are important to them. A relative may insist you have eaten too little because feeding you is part of caring for you. A gathering may have foods connected to family, place, childhood, or celebration.

Zena taught me this in more ways than one.

During my wellness journey, her cooking could be the thing I was trying to navigate. After Murithi died, that same cooking became care.

She came to Isiolo and stayed with me for roughly two weeks. In the period around a funeral in Kenya, the house can fill with people before the burial and continue filling afterward. People come to sit with you, pray, talk, remember, organise, and simply be present. Presence also has to be fed.

Changing food was emotionally more complicated than cleaning a pantry suggested. Food had been woven into routine, reward, stress, hospitality and companionship. I was not only changing ingredients. I was interrupting habits that had become automatic. There were hours of the day when eating seemed to happen because that was what the hour meant. There were social situations in which refusing food felt almost like refusing affection. There were moments when I was not physically hungry but wanted the comfort of doing something familiar. Learning to notice those differences required attention I had not previously given to eating.

Zena cooked.

Breakfast. Lunch. Dinner. Tea. Mandazi. Bread. Chapati. Stew. Food for the people coming through the house and food for a family whose attention was elsewhere.

There are seasons when a plate is not a temptation. It is somebody saying, I am here. You do not have to think about this part.

That is why I cannot tell my food story honestly if I turn food into a villain. The same samosas can be indulgence on a train, temptation during a new routine, celebration at a gathering, and love in a grieving house.

This may be one of the reasons rigid wellness advice has never interested me for long. Human beings do not eat nutrients in laboratories. We eat at tables. We eat after funerals. We eat on trains. We eat when an auntie has cooked all morning. We eat because we are celebrating, because somebody loves us, because we are

stressed, because we are hungry, and sometimes because a samosa is sitting next to a mandazi and curiosity wins.

I also had to stop making food morally dramatic. A samosa is not a character flaw. A piece of cake is not evidence that a woman lacks discipline. The question for me became what pattern I wanted most of my days to create. When I understood that, an individual meal became less powerful. Early in the journey I needed more structure because my habits were fragile. Later I could hold structure and flexibility together. That is a much more peaceful way to live. I can enjoy something and return to my routine without holding a court hearing in my own head.

The work is not to remove humanity from eating.

The work, for me, was to stop disappearing inside it.

Context matters.

I had to learn that intentional eating did not require me to become afraid of food or hostile to hospitality.

It required me to decide.

Sometimes I said no.

Sometimes I adjusted my eating window.

Sometimes I ate what was available and returned to my routine later.

Sometimes, as already established, I put a samosa inside a mandazi.

The principle was not purity.

It was ownership.

Before my journey, food often made the decision because it was present, because I was stressed, because it was late, because everybody else was eating, or because eating was what I did next.

Afterward, I became more conscious of the question: What do I actually want to do here?

That small pause changed my relationship with food.

It also protected me from a different kind of obsession. I did not want wellness to become another way of being controlled—this time by rules I had created myself.

A healthy life should be lived.

It should survive weddings, travel, family tables, unexpected plans, and the occasional decision that the chef needs to hear directly from you about onions.

What would it mean to make food choices intentionally without making food the centre of your entire life?

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

Purpose Without Disappearing Again

Service has always mattered to me.

My professional and community life has often involved advocating for other people, organising, leading, and trying to improve the conditions around me. I know what it means to be needed.

Many women do.

We are mothers, daughters, wives, sisters, professionals, caregivers, leaders, neighbours, organisers, and the person everybody calls because they know we will handle it.

There is dignity in that.

There can also be danger if usefulness becomes the only way we know our value.

My wellness journey did not teach me to care less about other people.

It taught me that I could not continue treating care for myself as though it were a betrayal of everybody else.

There is another change I notice now that has very little to do with kilograms.

For many years, I knew how to show up for other people. I could stand before a room, advocate for something I believed in, work, lead, and keep going even when things were difficult. Because I was still functioning, it was easy to tell myself that I was fine.

Purpose can be generous and still become dangerous when a woman believes she must disappear inside it. I had spent years thinking about service, leadership and the dignity of other people. Those commitments remain part of me. Wellness did not make me less interested in the world. It made me question why I had sometimes treated my own care as though it were in competition with service. I do not believe that anymore. A woman does not become selfish because she includes herself among the human beings whose wellbeing matters.

But being strong does not mean you do not need care.

I understand that better now.

I can still serve my community. I can still show up for my family. I can still work, lead, and pursue the things that matter to me. But I no longer believe that doing those things requires me to disappear from my own life.

Choosing myself does not mean choosing myself instead of everyone else.

It means remembering that I am one of the people I am responsible for caring for.

That may be the kind of confidence I value most now—not looking strong for the world, but being honest enough to take care of myself too.

One of the people who encouraged me without trying to manage me was my son Murithi.

At that time, he was the one of my children who was physically in Kenya; his sisters were living in the United States. That meant his support often had a practical shape.

When I did not have a car, he gave me rides. When he had his shamba and I was short of food, he brought me vegetables. Once he brought so much that I shared with my neighbours.

Murithi had a way of making difficult things feel less final. Elections, disappointments, whatever I was carrying—he could make it seem manageable. Nothing had to become the end of the world simply because it had gone badly.

When I began losing weight, he was excited for me. I could call and announce that I had gone down a dress size, and he celebrated it. When I told him I was writing a book, he encouraged me: “Keep going, Mum.”

I did not know then how precious ordinary encouragement would become in memory.

At the time, it was simply my son being my son. I am grateful I knew him that way before I had to know what it meant to miss him.

As my health improved, people began asking me questions.

What are you doing?

How did you stay disciplined?

Can you help me?

At first, I answered casually. Then I realised my private journey was encouraging other people.

Anita and Winnie joining my morning walks had already shown me this. The women following my videos showed me again. People do not only listen to what we say. They watch what we permit ourselves to become.

That gave my experience another layer of purpose.

But I am careful with the word purpose now.

Purpose does not always mean a new organisation, a new title, or another responsibility.

Sometimes purpose is simply living your own life awake.

It is using what you have learned.

It is becoming an example without making yourself responsible for everybody else's outcome.

I can encourage another woman.

I cannot choose for her.

Dr Maryam planted a seed in me, but I had to decide.

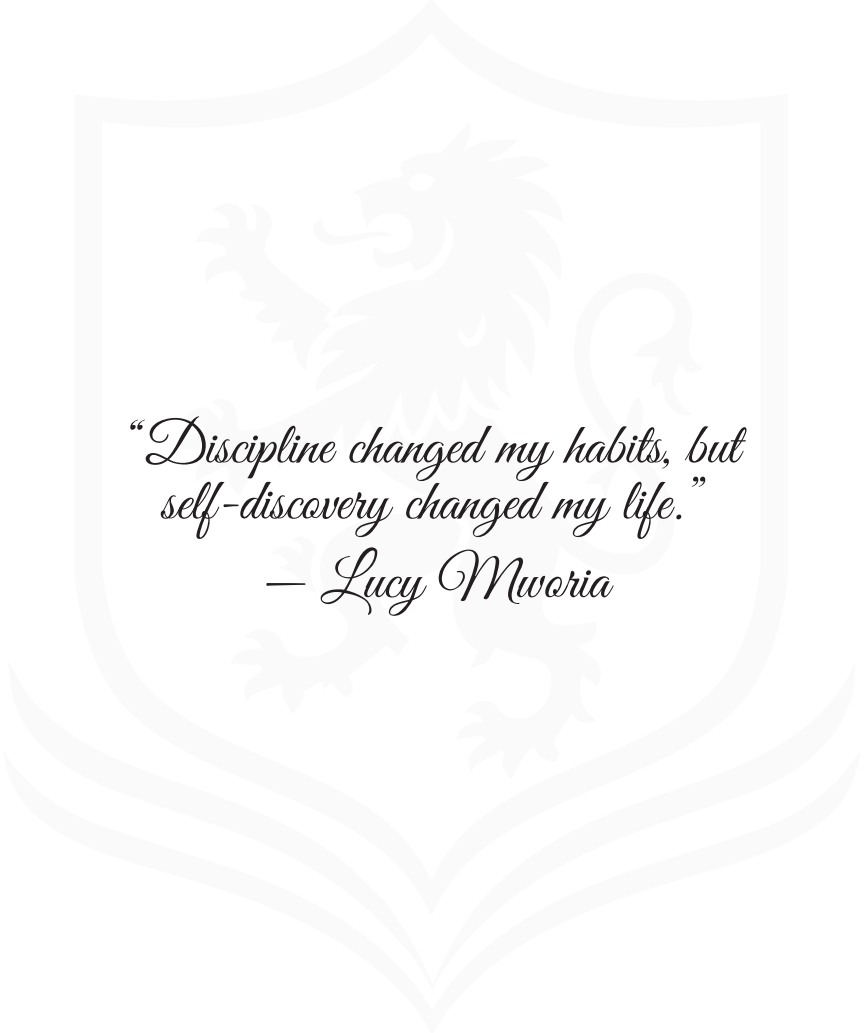
I can plant a seed in someone else.

She will still have to decide.

That boundary matters to me because I do not want to rediscover myself only to lose myself again in the work of helping everybody else.

Reflective Question:

What would purpose look like if it included you rather than requiring you to disappear?



*“Discipline changed my habits, but
self-discovery changed my life.”*

— Lucy Mwarira

CHAPTER NINETEEN

Choose yourself

If there is one idea I want you to carry from my story, it is this:

When I first began saying those words, they were tied closely to my health. Choose the walk. Choose the meal. Choose the sleep. Choose not to postpone the body that has to carry you into tomorrow.

Over time the words grew larger.

Choosing yourself can mean allowing yourself to want a life that feels like yours. It can mean noticing when being capable has become an excuse for everybody, including you, to assume you need nothing. It can mean deciding that care is not something you only distribute outward.

Age is real. I am not interested in pretending that a sixty-year-old body is identical to a twenty-year-old body. The years bring changes, history, sometimes illness, sometimes loss, and certainly a different relationship with time. But age is not a complete diagnosis of what is possible. I had allowed the phrase at my age to close questions before I had asked them. What would happen if I slept better? What would happen if I walked? What would happen if I changed how I ate? What would happen if I became stronger? Curiosity reopened doors that resignation had quietly closed.

It can also mean accepting that you will disappoint somebody occasionally.

Women are often praised for being endlessly available and then quietly exhausted by the same quality. We are called strong when we carry too much, generous when we give past our limits, dependable when we never say no. Those qualities can be beautiful. They can also become hiding places if we never ask what they are costing us.

I also became more careful about the stories women tell one another. Sometimes we think we are comforting a friend when we are actually lowering the ceiling over her life. Do not worry, everybody gains weight now. Knees hurt when you are older. Why are you trying so hard? What are you looking for? These comments may come with affection, humour or cultural familiarity. They can still become limiting if we accept them as instructions. I learned to hear an opinion without automatically turning it into my future.

I am still generous. I still serve. I still care deeply about other people.

I simply no longer believe love requires my absence from my own life.

Choose yourself.

I know how easily those words can become a slogan, so let me tell you what I mean.

For many women, especially women of my generation, putting ourselves anywhere near the top of the list can feel selfish. We

have spent years learning how to be useful. We know how to show up when somebody needs us. We know how to postpone our rest, our appointments, our dreams, our health, and sometimes even our happiness because something else seems more urgent.

Getting older has also made me less interested in performing misery to prove maturity. I like beautiful clothes. I like dancing. I like travelling. I like laughing. I like feeling strong. None of those pleasures belong only to young women. I do not need to become invisible in order to age with dignity. If anything, I want age to make me more deliberate about the life I still have. Time becomes more valuable when you understand that it is not endless.

We can become so good at being needed that we forget we are also someone worth caring for.

Choosing yourself does not mean choosing yourself instead of your children.

It does not mean abandoning your family.

It does not mean becoming self-absorbed.

It means accepting responsibility for the one life that is unquestionably yours to live.

I chose myself when I listened to Dr Maryam instead of accepting that pain was simply my age.

I chose myself when I emptied my kitchen of foods that no longer supported what I wanted.

I chose myself when I walked even when nobody was watching.

I chose myself when people laughed.

I chose myself when people said losing weight was not African.

I chose myself when people decided I must be sick.

I chose myself when I danced.

I chose myself when I rested.

I chose myself when I allowed joy back into my wardrobe.

And I chose myself when I ate something outside my routine and returned without shame.

None of those decisions required me to stop loving anybody else.

They required me to stop abandoning myself.

Your version may look nothing like mine.

Perhaps choosing yourself means finally making the medical appointment you have postponed. Perhaps it means going back to school, leaving a situation that has diminished you, asking for help, starting a business, setting a boundary, taking the trip, resting without apologising, returning to something you loved, or simply taking a walk before the rest of the house wakes up.

I cannot tell you what your choice should be.

I can tell you that you are allowed to ask the question.

What would it look like to include myself in my own life?

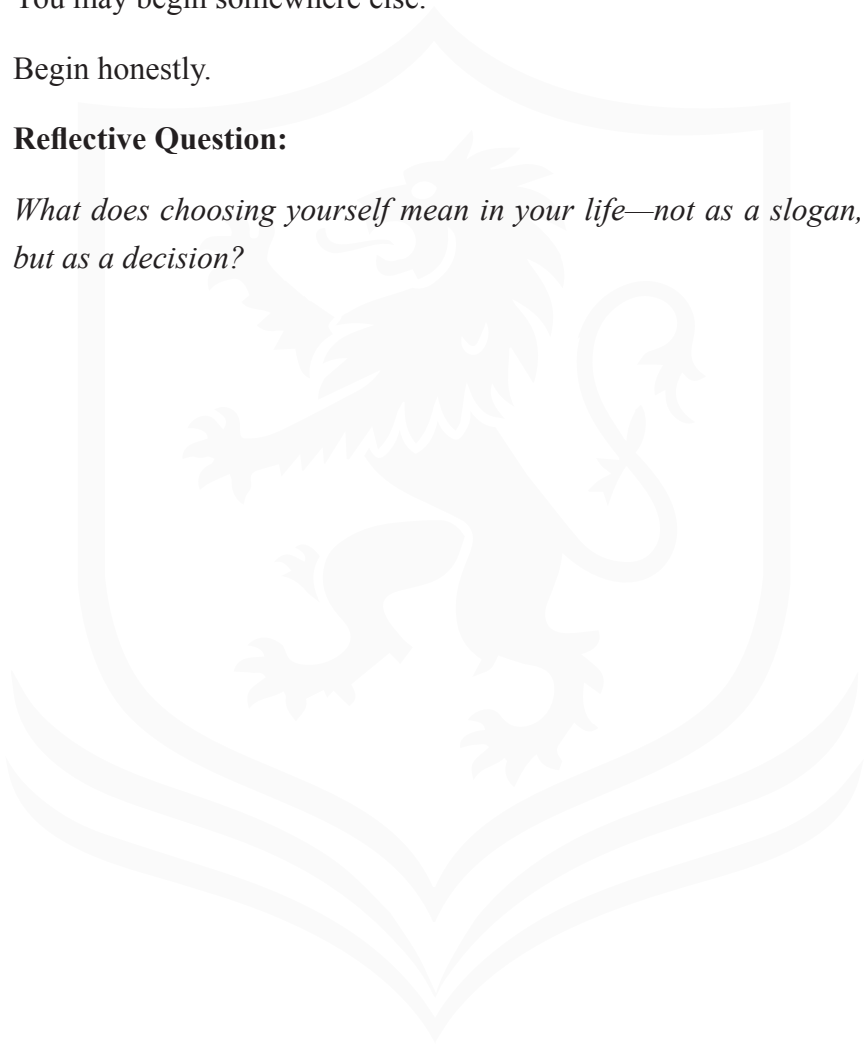
I began with food and weight because that was where my life needed my attention.

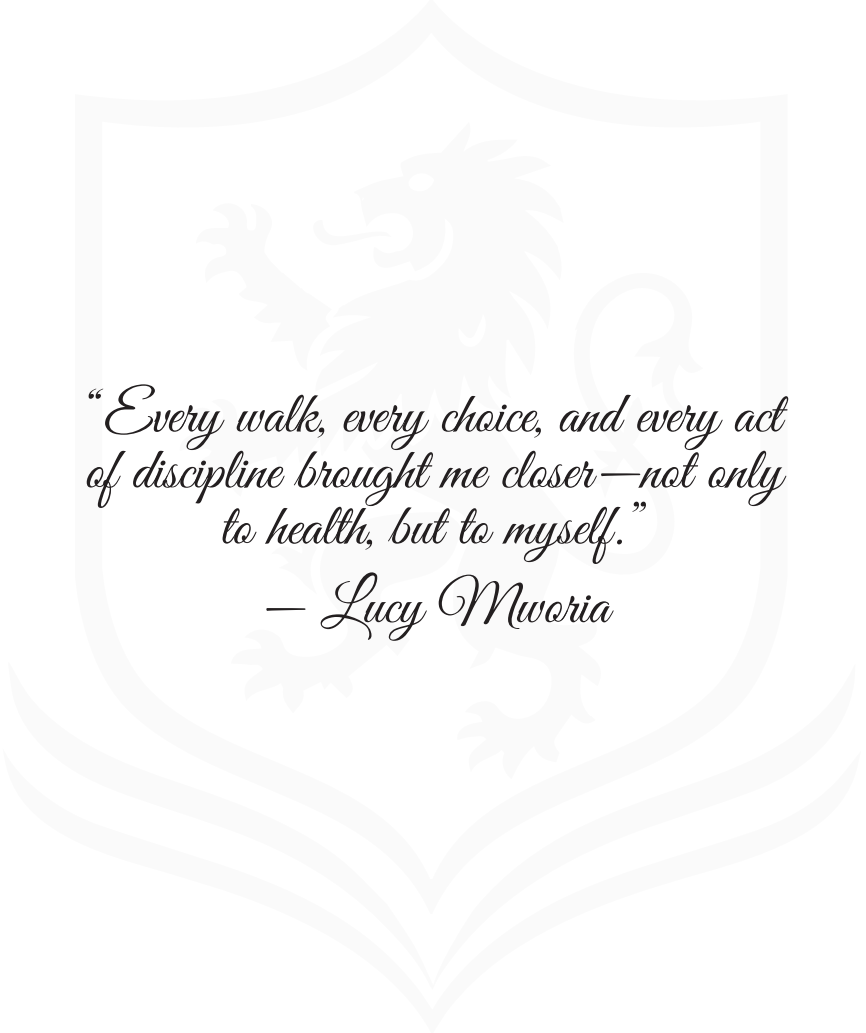
You may begin somewhere else.

Begin honestly.

Reflective Question:

What does choosing yourself mean in your life—not as a slogan, but as a decision?





*“Every walk, every choice, and every act
of discipline brought me closer—not only
to health, but to myself.”*

— Lucy Mworira

CHAPTER TWENTY

The Woman I Found

I thought I was trying to get the old Lucy back.

I was not going backwards at all.

When I began, I wanted the woman in the photograph.

I wanted the smaller clothes.

I wanted my heels.

I wanted movement without fear.

I wanted to enjoy photographs and videos.

I wanted to look in the mirror and recognise myself.

I found those things.

But they were not the greatest discovery.

The woman I found is more peaceful than the woman I was chasing.

She is happier.

More appreciative.

More grateful.

More contented with what she has.

More loving.

She understands her body better, but she also understands herself better.

She knows that discipline can be an act of care.

She knows that other people's opinions are information, not authority.

She knows that age is real, but so is possibility.

She knows that health is not guaranteed and that no lifestyle makes us invincible. What we can do is participate in our own wellbeing with intention, appropriate professional guidance, and respect for the body we have.

Most importantly, she knows that choosing herself does not make her selfish.

I spent years directing strength outward.

I knew how to advocate.

I knew how to lead.

I knew how to carry responsibility.

After sixty, I learned another form of strength: turning some of that care toward myself.

I still have goals.

I am still becoming.

There are still days when life is difficult, because transformation does not exempt us from being human.

There are losses that no morning walk solves. There are days when grief and gratitude occupy the same body. There are seasons when caring for yourself does not make the hard thing disappear; it simply gives you a way to remain present inside your own life while you carry it.

The most useful skill I developed was not perfect discipline. It was returning. Perfection is fragile because one mistake can destroy it. Returning is durable. It assumes that travel will happen, celebrations will happen, grief will happen, somebody will make excellent food, sleep will be interrupted, motivation will disappear and life will occasionally laugh at your schedule. The question is not whether any of that happens. The question is what you do next.

I know that more deeply now.

My son Murithi used to read my writing and tell me, “Keep going, Mum.” Those words belong to me differently now. I do not need to turn loss into a lesson to understand the tenderness of continuing.

There is a strange tenderness in dates now. Murithi’s funeral took place on my birthday. The launch of this book is planned for his birthday.

I do not need to force meaning onto that symmetry. Some things are meaningful simply because love makes us notice them.

A day can hold more than one story. A birthday can become a day of unbearable loss. Another birthday can become a day when something a person encouraged you to finish enters the world.

That does not balance anything. It does not replace anything.

It simply reminds me that love continues to occupy the calendar.

Sometimes continuing is enough.

I am no longer waiting to become the woman in an old photograph.

I am grateful for her.

I am grateful she reminded me of what I missed.

And then I let her go.

The woman I wanted to find could never have been on my phone screen.

I had not met her yet.

Now I have.

Her name is Lucy.

Reflective Question:

What if you stopped trying to become who you were and embraced who you are becoming?

A Letter To The Woman Who Has Almost Given Up

My dear friend,

If you have reached this page feeling tired, discouraged, or late to your own life, I want to leave you with something simpler than a plan.

Do not confuse being needed with being fully alive.

Do not assume that because you have carried responsibilities for many years, your own needs must always come last.

Do not let age become an explanation for everything before you have asked what is actually possible.

And please do not wait for everybody to understand the change you need to make.

People may question you. They questioned me.

Some may tell you that you are too old. Some may tell you that the change you want is unnecessary. Some may prefer the version of you who required less adjustment from them.

You do not need to fight all of them.

You do not need to convince all of them.

You need to become clear enough about your own life that every opinion does not become a vote.

If your journey is about health, seek good professional guidance and begin where you are. If it is about something else, begin there.

Do not wait until you can do it perfectly.

I did not.

I ate outside my eating window. I travelled. I laughed. I had difficult days. I wanted things I had decided not to eat. I listened to comments that annoyed me. I had mornings when discipline mattered more than enthusiasm.

The journey continued because I returned.

That is one of the most important things I can tell you.

You do not have to become a woman who never wanders from the plan.

Become a woman who knows how to come home to herself.

I began at 115 kilograms believing I needed to lose weight.

I did lose weight.

But I also learned to trust myself. I learned that my body was not my enemy. I learned that joy can be part of discipline. I learned that a woman can be serious about her health and still put a samosa inside a mandazi on a train and laugh with her daughter.

Earlier in my life, one imperfect choice could easily become permission for several more. If I had already broken the plan, why not continue? That thinking made a single moment unnecessarily powerful. Now I try to make the next decision on its own merits. I can eat something I enjoy and drink water later. I can miss a walk today and walk tomorrow. I can travel and come home. I can have a difficult week without turning it into a difficult year. Returning removes drama from the process, and that has made consistency much easier.

I learned that growing older is not the same as becoming finished.

Most of all, I learned that choosing yourself is not a rejection of the people you love.

It is an acknowledgement that you are one of them.

With love,

Lucy



*“I went looking for change and found
the courage to live fully again.”*

— Lucy Mwarira

My Personal Wellness Framework

This is not a prescription. It is the framework that helped me, shared so you can understand what my journey looked like in practice.

1. I changed my food environment first

I removed foods from my home that made my goals harder and built meals around foods that felt nourishing and satisfying to me: eggs, fish and lean meat, beans and lentils, vegetables and traditional greens, salads, yoghurt or fermented milk, avocado, and water.

I reduced added sugar, sweetened drinks, highly processed foods, and many refined carbohydrates.

2. I worked on hydration and sleep

I aimed for roughly two to three litres of water a day and moved from periods of four or five hours of sleep toward a more consistent seven to eight hours. These were part of my overall routine, not magic solutions.

3. I used OMAD

One Meal a Day gave me structure and reduced constant decisions about food. It suited me. It will not suit everyone. Fasting can be inappropriate for some people and may interact with health conditions, medications, nutritional needs, pregnancy, or a history of disordered eating.

Please seek qualified professional guidance before adopting a restrictive eating pattern.

4. I walked

Walking became my most consistent movement. At my established routine, I often walked approximately nine to ten kilometres in the morning, around twelve to thirteen thousand steps. I built up to this; it was not my starting requirement.

5. I danced and added strength work

Dancing made movement joyful. Strength work helped me feel capable. I learned that exercise did not have to be punishment.

6. I protected new habits

At the beginning, I sometimes avoided social situations that made it difficult to maintain the changes I was trying to establish. Later, I learned more flexibility.

7. I stopped treating one imperfect choice as failure

Travel, celebrations, family, and ordinary life happen. One meal outside my plan did not erase months of work. My most useful skill became returning.

8. I measured more than weight

I noticed sleep, energy, knee comfort, movement, clothes, strength, mood, confidence, and whether I was keeping promises to myself.

9. I kept three sentences close

I love myself.

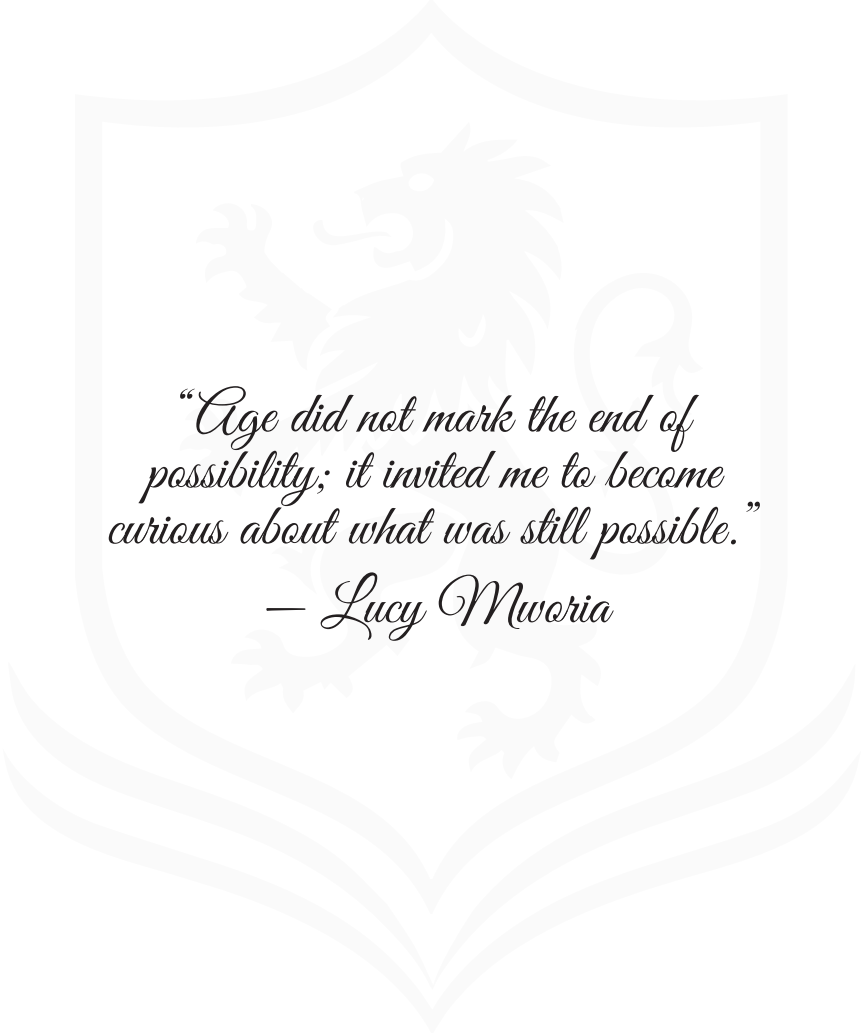
I am doing this for me.

I am responsible for my actions.

10. I let the journey remain mine

11. Other people had opinions before I lost weight and opinions after I lost weight.

12. I learned to listen selectively and to keep appropriate professional advice separate from casual commentary.



*“Age did not mark the end of
possibility; it invited me to become
curious about what was still possible.”*

— Lucy Mwarira

The Choose Yourself Pledge

Today, I include myself in the life I am caring for.

I will not demand perfection from myself before I allow myself to begin.

I will seek appropriate help when I need it.

I will pay attention to what strengthens me and what repeatedly pulls me away from the life I want.

I will remember that one difficult day is not a failed life.

If I wander, I will return.

If I become discouraged, I will remember why I began.

I will not hand every opinion authority over my choices.

I will care for my body without making my body the measure of my worth.

I will make room for discipline and joy.

I will make room for rest.

I will make room for change.

I will make room for myself.

Today, I choose myself.

This book is an offering to every person who feels stuck, discouraged, or believes it is too late to change. I hope my story reminds you that one decision, made with determination and followed by consistent action, has the power to transform your life.

There comes a defining moment in life when you realize that the greatest transformation begins from within. It is the moment you stop waiting for change and decide to become the change.

For me, that moment came when I looked honestly at my health, my lifestyle, and my future. I knew I had a choice: continue down a path that was compromising my well-being or take responsibility for my life—one decision, one meal, one walk, and one day at a time.

I did not write these pages as a doctor, a nutritionist, or a fitness expert. I wrote them as a woman who refused to give up on herself. I wrote them as someone who discovered that lasting transformation is not built on perfection but on consistency, discipline, and self-belief.

My wellness journey has taught me that losing weight is only part of the transformation. The greatest change happens in the mind and the heart. As I embraced healthier habits, I also rediscovered my confidence, my purpose, and my love for myself. I learned that every small step matters and that every setback can become a stepping stone toward success.

This book is especially for women who feel that age, past failures, or life's responsibilities have stolen their opportunity to live healthier

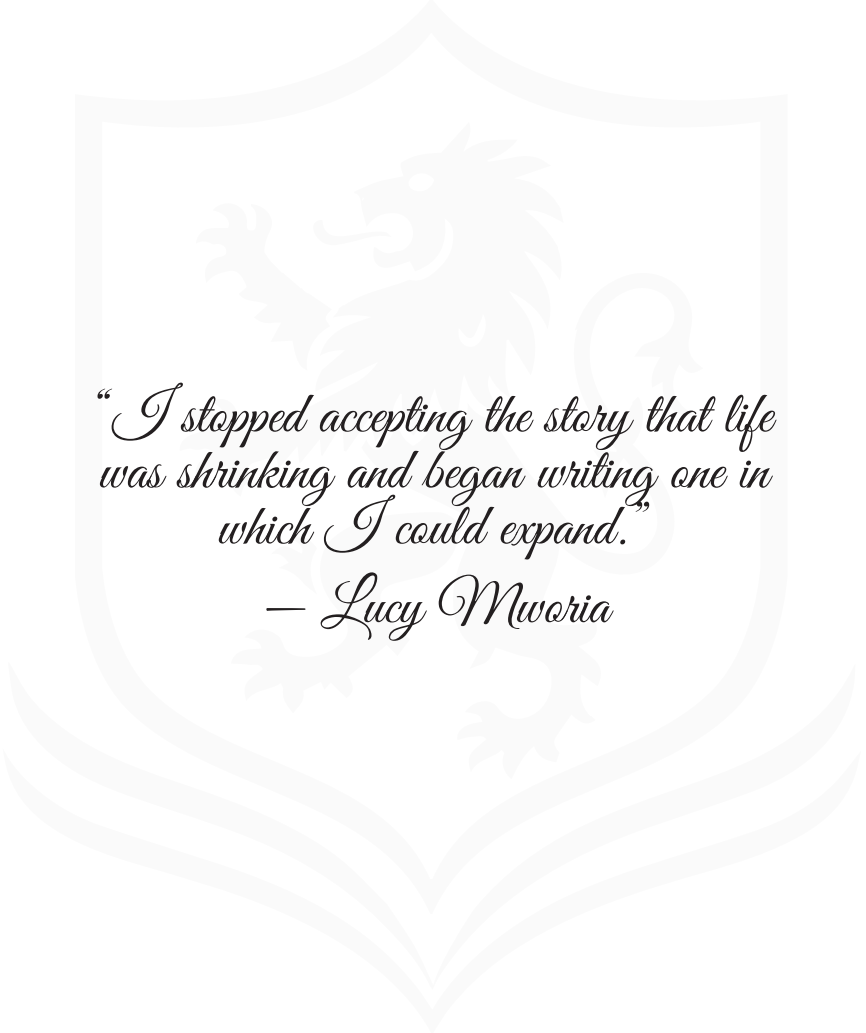
lives. I want you to know that it is never too late to choose yourself. It is never too late to reclaim your health, your confidence, and your dreams.

Within these pages, I share my personal experiences, the lessons I learned, the habits that transformed my life, and the mindset that kept me moving forward even when the journey became difficult. My hope is not simply that you will lose weight, but that you will discover the strength that has always existed within you.

If this book inspires even one person to take that first step toward a healthier, happier life, then sharing my story will have been worthwhile.

No that you have finished reading it, I invite you to keep an open heart and an open mind. Walk this journey with me. Celebrate the victories, learn from the challenges, and remember that meaningful change happens one choice at a time.

Welcome to my wellness journey. It is an honour to share it with you, and I sincerely hope it inspires you to begin—or continue—your own.



*“I stopped accepting the story that life
was shrinking and began writing one in
which I could expand.”*

— Lucy Mworira

Notes I Want to Remember

The most useful skill I developed was not perfect discipline. It was returning. Perfection is fragile because one mistake can destroy it. Returning is durable. It assumes that travel will happen, celebrations will happen, grief will happen, somebody will make excellent food, sleep will be interrupted, motivation will disappear and life will occasionally laugh at your schedule. The question is not whether any of that happens. The question is what you do next.

Earlier in my life, one imperfect choice could easily become permission for several more. If I had already broken the plan, why not continue? That thinking made a single moment unnecessarily powerful. Now I try to make the next decision on its own merits. I can eat something I enjoy and drink water later. I can miss a walk and walk tomorrow. I can travel and come home. I can have a difficult week without turning it into a difficult year. Returning removes drama from the process, and that has made consistency much easier.

This is why I no longer define discipline as severity. Discipline is remembering what matters after the exciting beginning has passed. It is also knowing how to begin again without insulting yourself. Shame has never been my most reliable coach. Responsibility is better. I can tell myself the truth, accept the choice I made and make another one. That is a relationship with myself I can sustain.

Age is real. I am not interested in pretending that a sixty-year-old body is identical to a twenty-year-old body. The years bring changes, history, sometimes illness, sometimes loss, and certainly a different relationship with time. But age is not a complete diagnosis of what is possible. I had allowed the phrase at my age to close questions before I had asked them. What would happen if I slept better? What would happen if I walked? What would happen if I changed how I ate? What would happen if I became stronger? Curiosity reopened doors that resignation had quietly closed.

I also became more careful about the stories women tell one another. Sometimes we think we are comforting a friend when we are actually lowering the ceiling over her life. Do not worry, everybody gains weight now. Knees hurt when you are older. Why are you trying so hard? What are you looking for? These comments may come with affection, humour or cultural familiarity. They can still become limiting if we accept them as instructions. I learned to hear an opinion without automatically turning it into my future.

Getting older has also made me less interested in performing misery to prove maturity. I like beautiful clothes. I like dancing. I like travelling. I like laughing. I like feeling strong. None of those pleasures belong only to young women. I do not need to become invisible in order to age with dignity. If anything, I want age to make me more deliberate about the life I still have. Time becomes more valuable when you understand that it is not endless.

Purpose can be generous and still become dangerous when a woman believes she must disappear inside it. I had spent years thinking

about service, leadership and the dignity of other people. Those commitments remain part of me. Wellness did not make me less interested in the world. It made me question why I had sometimes treated my own care as though it were in competition with service. I do not believe that anymore. A woman does not become selfish because she includes herself among the human beings whose wellbeing matters.

This is particularly important for women who are praised for being strong. Strength can become an assignment nobody remembers to end. Because you handled the last crisis, people bring you the next one. Because you rarely complain, they assume the weight is light. Because you know how to lead, they imagine you do not need support. Eventually you can participate in the same misunderstanding. You look at your own competence and use it as evidence that you are fine. I had to learn that capability and need can exist in the same woman.

I still want to contribute. I still want my work to matter. I still care about older people, communities, family and the responsibilities that come with being part of other people's lives. The difference is that I no longer admire my own disappearance. I want a form of purpose that allows me to remain present in the life I am working so hard to improve. That may be one of the most important meanings of choosing myself: I am not withdrawing love from the world. I am refusing to remove myself from the circle of people I love.

Changing food was emotionally more complicated than cleaning a pantry suggested. Food had been woven into routine, reward, stress, hospitality and companionship. I was not only changing ingredients. I was interrupting habits that had become automatic. There were hours of the day when eating seemed to happen because that was what the hour meant. There were social situations in which refusing food felt almost like refusing affection. There were moments when I was not physically hungry but wanted the comfort of doing something familiar. Learning to notice those differences required attention I had not previously given to eating.

I also had to stop making food morally dramatic. As I already stated, samosa is not a character flaw. A piece of cake is not evidence that a woman lacks discipline. The question for me became what pattern I wanted most of my days to create. When I understood that, an individual meal became less powerful. Early in the journey I needed more structure because my habits were fragile. Later I could hold structure and flexibility together. That is a much more peaceful way to live. I can enjoy something and return to my routine without holding a court hearing in my own head.

Food is especially complicated in a culture where feeding people is one of the languages of love. The person offering you another serving may not be trying to sabotage you. She may be saying, You are welcome here. I prepared this because you matter. That understanding helped me become less defensive. I could appreciate the love without surrendering every decision about my body. Sometimes I ate. Sometimes I declined. Sometimes I negotiated.

Sometimes, as Zena would happily remind me, I could always start tomorrow. Friendship survived my choices, and eventually my choices became easier to carry into friendship.

Walking changed because I stopped measuring it only as exercise. At first distance was the achievement. Fifteen minutes out meant fifteen minutes back. Then thirty became possible. Then an hour. The mathematics were simple, but something else was happening inside those kilometres. I was spending time with myself without a meeting, an audience or a problem to solve for somebody else. My mind had room to move while my body moved. Some mornings I prayed. Some mornings I thought. Some mornings I simply noticed that I was outside and capable of continuing.

There is humility in building endurance slowly. The body does not care how impressive your intentions are. It responds to what you repeatedly ask it to do. I could not negotiate my way into fitness with enthusiasm. I had to walk the distance. On difficult mornings that was irritating. Later it became comforting. The work was honest. If I went fifteen minutes away from home, I had created the return journey for myself. My motivation was simple: when I walk, I must come back. That small strategy carried me farther than many grand plans had.

Bofa Road became a place where progress was visible without a scale. A familiar point that once felt far became ordinary. A walk that once required concentration became conversation. My breathing changed. My legs changed. My confidence changed. Eventually other women joined me, but for months I walked alone.

I am glad for that period. It taught me that companionship is beautiful but cannot be the condition for keeping a promise to yourself. Some parts of a transformation must be able to survive when nobody else is awake.

Dancing helped correct an idea I had absorbed without noticing: that improving your body should feel like punishment. I had spent enough of life carrying serious responsibilities. I did not need wellness to become another serious responsibility with no joy in it. Music gave me another way to experience effort. I could sweat and laugh at the same time. I could become tired because I had been enjoying myself. That mattered. A routine built entirely on deprivation may produce results, but I wanted a life I would actually agree to keep living.

The return of clothes was not superficial to me. I had always enjoyed style. Dresses, makeup and shoes were part of how I played with presentation. When that pleasure disappeared, I noticed the absence even when I pretended not to care. Trying on clothes again was therefore not simply proof of weight loss. It was a return of curiosity. What would this look like? How do I feel in this? Which shoes? There was delight in asking those questions again. I had missed the woman who enjoyed getting ready even when nobody important was waiting.

Joy became one of my measures of health. Not constant happiness—life does not offer that—but access to pleasure. Could I dance? Could I laugh at myself? Could I travel and enjoy the day instead of spending the whole day policing myself? Could I put on a dress

because I liked it? Could I move without every movement becoming a reminder of discomfort? Those questions helped me understand why the journey mattered beyond a number on the scale.

The decision sounds dramatic when I tell the story now, but most decisions become real through very ordinary actions. A declaration does not clean a kitchen. It does not fill a water bottle. It does not put you to bed earlier. It does not walk the first thirty minutes. I had made promises to myself before. The difference this time was that I began to connect the words with behaviour. That connection was small at first, but it became one of the most important changes in my life. Every time I did what I had said I would do, I collected evidence that my own word could be trusted.

I used to think confidence came first and action followed. My experience reversed that order. I acted while uncertain, uncomfortable and sometimes annoyed. Then confidence grew because I could look backward and see proof. I had survived the hungry hour. I had walked when I wanted to stay home. I had returned after an imperfect day. I had chosen water. I had gone to sleep. None of these actions looked impressive enough to deserve applause, but together they changed the way I regarded myself. I was no longer waiting to feel like a disciplined woman. I was becoming one through repetition.

Tomorrow is attractive because tomorrow has never disappointed us yet. Tomorrow is rested, organised and completely free of today's cravings. Tomorrow will wake up early, drink water, make the sensible meal and walk without complaint.

I had spent enough time making arrangements with that imaginary woman. Eventually I understood that the only Lucy who could change my life was the one standing in today's kitchen. She did not need to be perfect. She simply needed to make the next decision before tomorrow arrived and inherited another promise.

My body had been speaking before I was ready to listen carefully. Pain, poor sleep, fatigue, the changing relationship with clothes, the reluctance around photographs—none of these arrived as one dramatic announcement. They accumulated. That is how many forms of neglect work. There is no single morning when a woman wakes up and says, Today I will disappear from my own priorities. She adjusts. She accommodates. She buys the next size. She sits down sooner. She stops wearing the shoes that hurt. She tells herself she is busy. She calls discomfort normal because normal feels easier than change. I did many of those things without thinking of them as a story.

Age gave me an explanation that was convenient because it required nothing from me. If this was simply what happened after fifty or sixty, then there was no decision to make. Menopause could explain it. Family history could explain it. Stress could explain it. All of those things can matter, and I do not dismiss them. What changed for me was the discovery that explanation and surrender are not the same thing. I could acknowledge the realities of my age and still ask what was within my control. That question became much more useful than arguing with myself about what should or should not have happened to my body.

I want to be careful when I write about the woman I was at 115 kilograms. I do not want to speak about her cruelly. She was not lazy, foolish or less deserving of love. She was carrying a great deal. She had survived disappointments, rebuilt plans and continued serving. My transformation did not make that woman worthy. It helped me care for a worthy woman I had been neglecting. That distinction matters to me because self-improvement can easily become self-rejection. I did not need hatred to change. I needed honesty, responsibility and eventually a great deal of patience.

Being seen is complicated when your work is public. I did not have the luxury of disappearing completely simply because I disliked a photograph. I still attended meetings. I still stood in rooms. I still had responsibilities. That created a strange division: the public woman could function while the private woman avoided looking too closely. I could post a photograph and dislike it. I could speak confidently and still feel uncomfortable in my body. I could advocate for dignity while privately accepting less care for myself than I would have encouraged for somebody else.

The photograph mattered because it interrupted that arrangement. It did not reveal me to people who had never seen me. I was already visible. It revealed something to me that I had become skilled at negotiating around. There are moments when an image becomes difficult not because the camera is cruel but because it removes the explanations we use while moving through a day. I could not argue with the feeling I had when I looked at myself. The feeling was not hatred. It was recognition that I wanted something to change.

Later, posting videos while I was still changing became its own kind of practice. I did not wait for a perfect after-picture before allowing myself to be visible. That was important because transformation can create another trap: I will live when I arrive. I will wear the dress when I arrive. I will take the photograph when I arrive. I will be confident when I arrive. I had already spent enough years postponing myself. I wanted progress to happen inside a life that was already being lived.

For a long time I thought courage was mostly visible: the speech, the campaign, the move, the decision other people could point to. I understand it differently now. Some of the most consequential courage in a life is almost invisible. It is admitting that the future you announced confidently may not arrive in the form you expected. It is waking up after disappointment and deciding that embarrassment will not become your permanent address. It is allowing a plan to fail without deciding that you have failed with it. Returning to Kenya taught me that home can welcome you and still ask you to become somebody new. I had come back with certainty. Life slowly replaced some of that certainty with humility, and I am grateful for both.

When I remember those years, I resist the temptation to organise them too neatly. Memory likes to create a straight road after we have already reached the destination. Real life was not straight. I could be hopeful in the morning and discouraged by evening. I could believe completely in the work I wanted to do and still wonder whether I had made a terrible mistake. I could laugh with

friends while carrying financial worry. None of those feelings cancelled the others. They simply lived together. That is one reason I no longer judge a difficult season only by how I felt inside it. Sometimes we are building a life before we have the language to recognise what is being built.

I had spent many years proving that I could handle responsibility. That ability served me well, but it also made it easy to keep moving without asking what the movement was costing me. Competence can become a kind of camouflage. People see the woman who arrived, spoke, organised, solved the problem, wore the right clothes and kept the day moving. They do not necessarily see what happens when she closes the door behind her. I did not always see it either. I had become so accustomed to being capable that I sometimes treated my own exhaustion as an inconvenience rather than information.

Grief does not arrive politely after all the other lessons have been completed. It enters the life you are already living. By the time Murithi died, I had routines that supported me, but I do not describe those routines as protection from grief. Nothing turns the death of a child into a manageable wellness challenge. What changed was that I had learned ways of caring for myself while pain existed. I could walk and grieve. I could eat and grieve. I could laugh for a moment and still be grieving when the laughter ended.

I have become suspicious of the idea that every painful experience must immediately become a lesson. Some experiences are painful because they are painful.

Love creates the possibility of grief because the person mattered. I do not need to make that loss useful in order to honour my son. What I can say is that life continued to ask ordinary things of me. People came to the house. Tea was made. Food was cooked. Family gathered. Bodies still needed sleep and nourishment even when hearts were broken. Care became very practical.

Diani came soon after the funeral, and that timing is part of why the memories matter. Kendi and I could carry sorrow to the coast and still find moments that were funny. One emotion did not betray the other. I could miss my son and laugh about onions. I could be exhausted and still go near the ocean. I could remember him and enjoy a meal. Grief did not require me to prove love by refusing every remaining pleasure. That is something I understand more gently now than I might have before.

Reflection & Practice — Choosing Yourself in Your Own Life

My story is mine. Your circumstances, health, responsibilities, culture and body may be very different. These reflections are not a programme and they are not medical instructions. They are invitations to notice your own life more honestly. You do not need to answer every question. Begin with the one that makes you pause.

1. Notice where “later” has settled

Think about the things you repeatedly tell yourself you will deal with later. Some may be practical. Some may be emotional. Some may involve health, rest, money, friendship, creativity or a decision you have postponed. Write down three. Then ask what “later” has

cost you so far. The purpose is not to shame yourself. It is to make the invisible visible. A postponed need can become normal simply because it has been postponed for a long time. Choose one small action that belongs to today rather than to the imaginary woman who will have more time tomorrow.

Write: What is true for me here? What is one thing I can change? What would a kind but responsible next step look like?

2. Separate strength from neglect

List the areas of life in which people depend on you. Then list the ways you care for the person doing all that work—you. If the second list is much shorter, do not use the first list as proof that you are fine. Competence and depletion can exist together. Ask what care would look like if it were treated as maintenance rather than reward. It may be sleep, a medical appointment, movement, quiet, help, food, boundaries or simply an hour that does not belong to another person.

Write: What is true for me here? What is one thing I can change? What would a kind but responsible next step look like?

3. Find the promise you can keep

Do not begin with the most impressive promise. Begin with the one you are willing to keep repeatedly. A ten-minute walk kept is more useful than a two-hour plan abandoned. A glass of water actually drunk is more useful than an elaborate routine saved on your phone. Self-trust grows through evidence. Choose one promise small enough that excuses become slightly embarrassing.

Keep it for a week and notice how it feels to become a person who can rely on her own word.

Write: What is true for me here? What is one thing I can change? What would a kind but responsible next step look like?

4. Look at your environment

Willpower is easier when your surroundings are not constantly arguing with your intention. Look at the places where your habits happen: kitchen, bedroom, desk, car, calendar, social routine. What makes the choice you want easier? What makes it harder? You do not need to redesign your whole life. Remove one obstacle and add one support. The goal is not a perfect environment. It is to stop requiring heroic discipline for every ordinary decision.

Write: What is true for me here? What is one thing I can change? What would a kind but responsible next step look like?

5. Learn your different hungers

Physical hunger is only one reason human beings eat. We also eat because it is time, because food is present, because we are celebrating, because we are lonely, because we are tired, because somebody cooked, because refusing feels rude, because the day was difficult, or because the food is simply excellent. None of these observations makes you bad. Notice them. Curiosity gives you more choices than judgment. Before eating outside your intended routine, ask: What am I hungry for right now? Sometimes the answer will still be food. Sometimes it will not.

Write: What is true for me here? What is one thing I can change?
What would a kind but responsible next step look like?

6. Decide what food means in your family

Food can be nutrition and love at the same time. Think about the meals that mean home to you. Who cooked them? What memories do they carry? Which foods appear when people celebrate, mourn, visit or care for one another? A sustainable wellness life should understand those meanings rather than pretending they do not exist. Consider how you can participate in your food culture while still making decisions that support your wellbeing. The answer may be portion, timing, frequency, preparation, or simply choosing consciously instead of automatically.

Write: What is true for me here? What is one thing I can change?
What would a kind but responsible next step look like?

7. Build movement from where you are

Do not compare your beginning with somebody else's established routine. Choose a distance or amount of movement that is realistic now. If walking is appropriate for you, your first goal may be minutes rather than kilometres. If another form of movement suits you better, begin there. The useful question is not, What would impress people? It is, What can I repeat? Progress becomes easier to recognise when you record what once felt difficult and notice when it becomes ordinary.

Write: What is true for me here? What is one thing I can change?
What would a kind but responsible next step look like?

8. Put joy back into movement

Make a list of ways you enjoyed moving before exercise became a duty. Dancing, swimming, gardening, walking with a friend, playing with children, stretching, hiking, cycling—your list may look completely different from mine. Choose one form of movement that contains pleasure. Health does not require you to hate every minute. A routine you enjoy has a different chance of surviving than one you experience only as punishment.

Write: What is true for me here? What is one thing I can change? What would a kind but responsible next step look like?

9. Examine the stories you inherited about age

Write down the sentences you have heard about what women should stop doing, wearing, wanting or attempting after a certain age. Do not decide immediately whether they are true. Simply notice them. Then ask which statements are medical realities, which are cultural expectations, which are somebody else's fears, and which have become habits of thought. Age deserves respect, not surrender. Where appropriate, seek qualified professional advice rather than allowing casual commentary to make decisions for your body.

Write: What is true for me here? What is one thing I can change? What would a kind but responsible next step look like?

10. Notice how you speak to your body

Would you speak to a friend the way you speak to yourself in a mirror? Change does not require cruelty. You can be dissatisfied

with a condition and still respect the person experiencing it. Try describing your body without insult. What is uncomfortable? What is strong? What needs attention? What has carried you through? Honest language is more useful than punishment because it allows responsibility without turning the self into an enemy.

Write: What is true for me here? What is one thing I can change? What would a kind but responsible next step look like?

11. Make room for being seen now

Is there something you are postponing until you look different, feel more confident or reach a goal? A photograph, a trip, a dress, a social event, a creative project? Consider whether you can participate in some version of it now. Transformation should not require disappearing until the after-picture. Your current life is not a waiting room. You are allowed to be visible while becoming.

Write: What is true for me here? What is one thing I can change? What would a kind but responsible next step look like?

12. Define progress beyond the scale

If weight is part of your goal, the scale can provide information, but it cannot describe an entire life. Make a second list of measures that matter: sleep, energy, comfort, strength, endurance, mood, laboratory values discussed with your clinician, confidence, clothing, mobility, consistency, or the ability to recover after disruption. Progress becomes more resilient when one number is not responsible for proving that all your effort matters.

Write: What is true for me here? What is one thing I can change?
What would a kind but responsible next step look like?

13. Plan for the imperfect day

Instead of designing a routine that assumes life will cooperate, decide in advance what returning looks like. What will you do after a celebration? After travel? After a poor night's sleep? After missing several walks? After eating differently than planned? A return plan might be as simple as the next meal, the next bedtime or the next morning. You are not planning to fail. You are refusing to let ordinary life turn one deviation into abandonment.

Write: What is true for me here? What is one thing I can change?
What would a kind but responsible next step look like?

14. Protect the beginning without building a prison

New habits are fragile. It can be reasonable to protect them by declining certain situations or simplifying choices for a while. But protection is not the final destination. Ask how your habits can eventually travel with you into restaurants, holidays, family gatherings and unpredictable weeks. The goal is not to control every environment. It is to become increasingly capable of making choices inside different environments.

Write: What is true for me here? What is one thing I can change?
What would a kind but responsible next step look like?

15. Let friendship support rather than police you

Who are the people who make change easier because you feel respected around them? Who turns every choice into commentary? Who feeds you because feeding is love? Who walks with you? Who laughs with you when the plan becomes ridiculous? You do not need a committee supervising your body. You do need relationships in which your decisions can exist without constant defence. Consider what support you actually want and whether you have communicated it clearly.

Write: What is true for me here? What is one thing I can change? What would a kind but responsible next step look like?

16. Ask what you miss about yourself

When you think about an earlier version of yourself, try not to reduce her to appearance. What qualities do you miss? Curiosity? Ease? Style? Courage? Playfulness? Energy? Creativity? Social connection? The goal may not be to become that woman again. It may be to recover something she represented and bring it into the woman you are now. The future does not have to be a restoration project. It can be an evolution.

Write: What is true for me here? What is one thing I can change? What would a kind but responsible next step look like?

17. Name what grief and difficulty require

There are seasons when wellness language can become too cheerful for reality. Loss, illness, caregiving, financial stress and grief may change what is possible. In those seasons, ask what care looks like now, not what it looked like during an easier month. Sometimes care is movement. Sometimes it is rest. Sometimes it is accepting food somebody cooked. Sometimes it is making an appointment. Sometimes it is allowing yourself to laugh without interpreting laughter as betrayal of what hurts.

Write: What is true for me here? What is one thing I can change?
What would a kind but responsible next step look like?

18. Redefine discipline

If your definition of discipline requires perfection, replace it. Consider discipline as remembering what matters and returning to it repeatedly. This definition leaves room for a human life. It also places responsibility where it belongs. You do not have to punish yourself for yesterday in order to make a useful decision today. Write one sentence describing the kind of discipline you want to practise—firm enough to guide you, humane enough to survive reality.

Write: What is true for me here? What is one thing I can change?
What would a kind but responsible next step look like?

19. Include yourself in your purpose

Think about the people, causes and responsibilities that receive your best energy. Now imagine your own wellbeing written on the same list. What changes? Choosing yourself does not require choosing against everybody else. It may simply mean refusing to build a meaningful life that depends on your disappearance. Ask where service and self-care can support each other rather than compete.

Write: What is true for me here? What is one thing I can change? What would a kind but responsible next step look like?

20. Write your own “woman I found” paragraph

Finish these sentences without trying to sound impressive: I thought I needed to... I discovered I was really looking for... I have stopped believing... I am learning... I want the next decade of my life to feel... Then write a final sentence beginning, The woman I am becoming... Keep it somewhere you can find it. You do not need to know every step between here and there. You only need enough honesty to recognise the direction.

Write: What is true for me here? What is one thing I can change? What would a kind but responsible next step look like?

More Questions for the Life Beyond the Scale

21. What did success cost?

Think about an achievement you are proud of and then ask a second question: what did it cost you while you were pursuing it? The answer does not cancel the achievement.

It simply makes the story honest. Ambition can be beautiful and expensive at the same time. My years of public work taught me that I could be deeply committed to a purpose while allowing sleep, food, movement and private wellbeing to become secondary. The lesson is not to become less ambitious. It is to notice the price early enough to decide whether it is one you still want to pay. Where could you pursue the same meaningful goal without making your body or peace the invisible funding source?

Write: What would this look like in one ordinary week of my real life?

22. Who are you when nobody needs anything?

Women who are useful can become so accustomed to responding that an empty hour feels strange. Imagine an afternoon in which nobody needs a ride, a meal, an answer, a report, money, advice or emotional support from you. What would you choose? The answer may be surprisingly difficult. That difficulty is information. A life organised around usefulness can leave very little practice in desire. Start small. What music do you want to hear? Where do you want to walk? What would you cook for yourself? What would you wear if the only audience were you? Choosing yourself often begins by remembering that preference is not selfishness.

Write: What would this look like in one ordinary week of my real life?

23. What are you calling normal?

Make a list of the things you have stopped questioning because they have been present for a long time: poor sleep, constant fatigue, pain, clutter, resentment, a schedule with no margin, eating without attention, never moving, never resting, never asking for help. Some may have medical or practical causes that require professional support. Others may simply have become familiar. Familiarity is powerful because it can make a problem feel like personality. Ask of each item: Is this truly inevitable, or have I simply adapted to it? You do not need an immediate solution. The first act may be allowing the question to exist again.

Write: What would this look like in one ordinary week of my real life?

24. What would care look like without punishment?

Many wellness plans begin with anger at the body. The rules become a sentence: no joy, no flexibility, no ordinary life until the body has paid for becoming unacceptable. I did not want to live that way. Ask what your routine would look like if its purpose were care rather than correction. You might still make demanding choices. Care is not the same as indulgence. It can require discipline, medical appointments, earlier bedtimes, saying no, preparing food, moving when you would rather sit, or stopping when rest is wiser. The difference is the relationship underneath the action. Punishment says, I am doing this because I dislike you. Care says, I am doing this because you have to carry me through the rest of my life.

Write: What would this look like in one ordinary week of my real life?

25. Where does humour save you?

Think about a difficult season that also contains one story that makes you laugh. Do not erase the seriousness in order to enjoy the ridiculous part. Mama Safi and I had campaign moments that were financially stressful and objectively inconvenient, yet some of them are funny to me now. Zanzibar gave me an embarrassing moment that became one of my favourite stories to tell. Humour does not prove that something did not hurt. Sometimes it is simply evidence that the difficult thing did not get to own every inch of the memory. What story have you been telling only solemnly that may also contain something wonderfully human?

Write: What would this look like in one ordinary week of my real life?

26. What does your wardrobe remember?

Clothes can hold more than measurements. They can remember jobs, weddings, confidence, hiding, celebration, grief, seasons of change and versions of ourselves we are not ready to throw away. I carried beautiful clothes and shoes back across an ocean because style had always been part of my pleasure. Later, the same wardrobe quietly recorded changes in my body and my relationship with being seen. Look at your own clothes without using them as weapons against yourself. Which pieces make you feel most like yourself? Which belong to a life you no longer want? Which are

waiting for an occasion that may never deserve them as much as an ordinary Tuesday does?

Write: What would this look like in one ordinary week of my real life?

27. What is your Bofa Road?

Bofa Road is a real place in my story, but the principle can travel. What is the place, practice or repeated route where you can meet yourself consistently? It might be a neighborhood walk, a chair by a window, a swimming pool, a notebook, a garden, a place of prayer, a gym or a quiet drive. The important quality is repetition. Transformation needs somewhere ordinary to happen. Grand moments are memorable; repeated places change us. Choose a place where you can return often enough that progress has a landscape.

Write: What would this look like in one ordinary week of my real life?

28. Can you let progress be boring?

The first week of a new plan has energy. The thirty-seventh ordinary day usually does not. That is where a great deal of change is made. Ask whether you are willing to repeat useful actions after they stop feeling like a fresh beginning. There may be no applause for drinking water, going to bed, preparing vegetables or walking the same road again. Boredom is not proof that a habit has stopped working. Sometimes it is proof that the habit is becoming normal. The goal is not to remain inspired by every choice. It is to create a life in which many helpful choices no longer require a speech.

Write: What would this look like in one ordinary week of my real life?

29. What opinions are you carrying?

Write down the comments other people have made about your age, body, ambition, health, relationships, appearance or choices that still echo in your mind. Beside each one, write: Is this expertise, concern, culture, affection, projection, humour, fear or simply an opinion? Not every voice deserves equal authority. One of the freedoms I gained was learning that other people could have opinions without those opinions becoming instructions. You can listen respectfully and still decide selectively. Where health is concerned, give appropriate professional guidance more weight than casual certainty.

Write: What would this look like in one ordinary week of my real life?

30. What would you do if nobody complimented you?

External encouragement can be wonderful. Compliments can make a difficult journey feel visible. But ask which parts of your goal would still matter if nobody noticed. Would you still want better sleep? More comfortable movement? Greater strength? A calmer relationship with food? More energy? The ability to keep a promise to yourself? Those answers are useful because appearance eventually becomes familiar to the people around us. A sustainable reason has to survive after the applause becomes ordinary.

Write: What would this look like in one ordinary week of my real life?

31. What are you protecting at the beginning?

Early change sometimes requires temporary simplicity. You may need fewer temptations, fewer negotiations or clearer boundaries while a habit is becoming established. Name what is genuinely difficult for you right now. Then decide what protection would be proportionate. It may be keeping certain foods out of the house, scheduling movement before other obligations, declining one event, asking family not to comment, or preparing before travel. Protection should support a life, not shrink it permanently. Set a future point when you will reassess whether the boundary still serves you.

Write: What would this look like in one ordinary week of my real life?

32. What is your return sentence?

Create one sentence you can use after an imperfect day. It should be short, calm and free of drama. Mine could be: I return with the next decision. Yours might be: One meal is one meal. Or: Tomorrow morning I walk again. The sentence is not permission to ignore patterns that need attention. It is a tool for preventing shame from turning one choice into a week of choices. Write it somewhere visible. You are designing a bridge back to yourself before you need it.

Write: What would this look like in one ordinary week of my real life?

33. What does rest have to prove?

If you only permit rest after exhaustion, rest becomes emergency care. Consider whether sleep and quiet can become ordinary maintenance instead. My own poor sleep had become part of the background of life until I began treating it as something worth improving. Rest will look different in different seasons and bodies, and persistent sleep problems deserve appropriate professional attention. The reflection here is simpler: do you believe rest must be earned? If so, who taught you that? What would change if rest were one of the things that allowed you to do meaningful work rather than the prize you received after nearly breaking yourself?

Write: What would this look like in one ordinary week of my real life?

34. What do you want your next decade to contain?

Do not answer only with achievements. Think in textures. How do you want mornings to feel? What do you want your body to be able to do, as far as circumstances allow? Who do you want around your table? What kind of work matters? What do you want to wear, learn, visit, create, release or enjoy? A future can become easier to care for when it contains something attractive beyond avoiding illness or fixing a problem. I did not sustain change only because I feared what might happen. I began to enjoy the life that was happening.

Write: What would this look like in one ordinary week of my real life?

35. Where have you confused visibility with vanity?

Women are sometimes taught to apologise for enjoying their appearance, especially as they grow older. I reject the idea that caring about a dress, a photograph or a pair of shoes makes a serious woman less serious. Ask whether there is pleasure you have abandoned because you fear it will look vain. Presentation is not everybody's language, but if it is one of yours, you are allowed to speak it. The deeper question is whether you are dressing to disappear, dressing for approval, or dressing because you enjoy the person in the clothes.

Write: What would this look like in one ordinary week of my real life?

36. Who gets to define ageing for you?

There are medical realities associated with ageing, and there are cultural scripts that are merely repeated until they sound medical. Learn the difference. Seek qualified guidance for health questions. Then examine the rest. Are you too old to dance, or have people simply stopped expecting older women to dance? Too old for strength, or in need of an appropriate programme? Too old for colour, travel, romance, ambition, new friendships or a different career? A number can inform a decision without making every decision for you.

Write: What would this look like in one ordinary week of my real life?

37. What does your body make possible today?

When a body is uncomfortable, it is easy to notice only limitation. Try a second inventory. What does your body allow today? Perhaps it walks, hugs, cooks, works, dances, rests, carries groceries, holds a grandchild, swims, breathes through a difficult conversation or simply gets you out of bed. Gratitude is not denial of pain. You can seek improvement and appreciate function at the same time. That combination helped me move away from treating my body as a disappointing object and toward treating it as the place where my life happens.

Write: What would this look like in one ordinary week of my real life?

38. What is still allowed to be fun?

A serious goal does not require a serious face every day. Identify what makes you laugh inside the life you are building. For me, some of the best memories involve plans becoming ridiculous: food negotiations, travel, friends, a boat, a hat, a jump rope, a daughter who has no intention of attending a six o'clock workout. Fun is not a distraction from wellbeing. It can be part of wellbeing. If your plan has removed every pleasure, ask whether the plan needs imagination rather than more discipline.

Write: What would this look like in one ordinary week of my real life?

39. What support do you need to ask for directly?

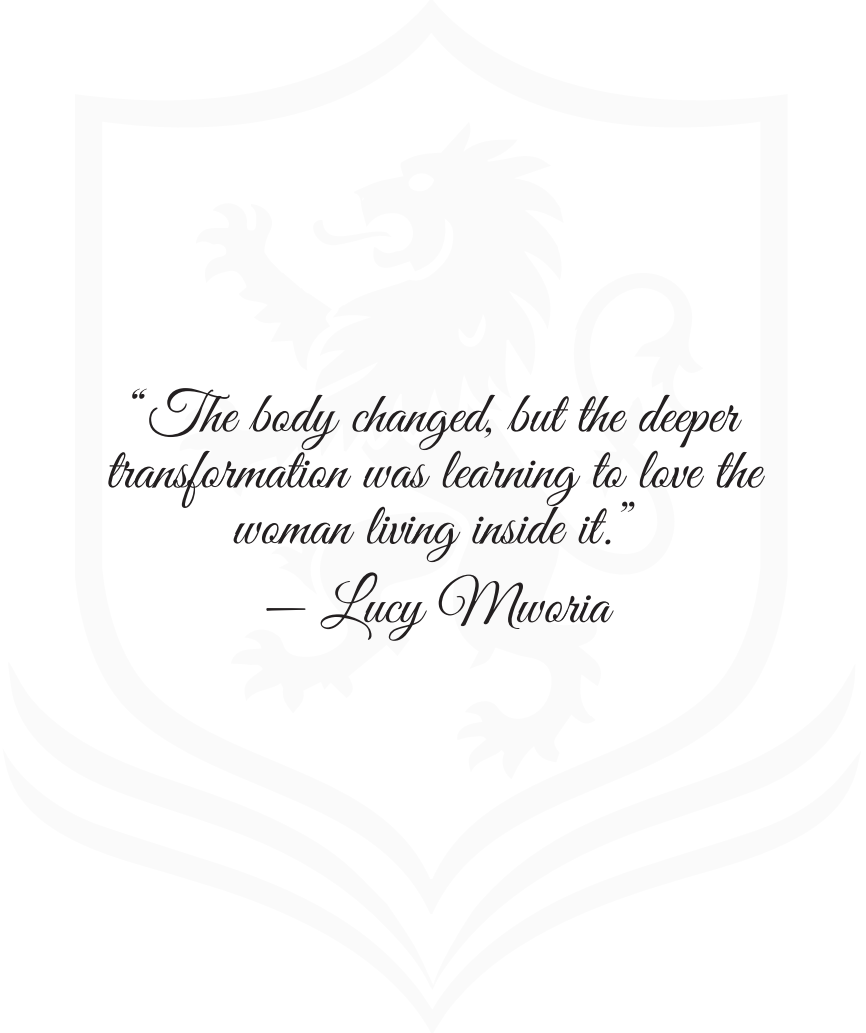
People cannot always infer the kind of support that helps. One person wants encouragement; another wants privacy. One wants a walking partner; another needs an hour alone. One wants family to stop bringing certain foods; another simply wants them to stop commenting. Write down one specific request that would make your current goal easier. Then consider asking for it without turning the request into an accusation. Support becomes more useful when it has a shape.

Write: What would this look like in one ordinary week of my real life?

40. What does choosing yourself mean now?

Return to the phrase after reading the whole story. Choosing yourself may have meant something different at the beginning. Perhaps it sounded selfish, dramatic or impossible. Define it now in one paragraph. Include what it does not mean. It does not have to mean abandoning people, refusing responsibility or making yourself the centre of every room. It may mean becoming a participant in your own care. It may mean telling the truth sooner. It may mean protecting your health, making room for joy, asking for help, or refusing to postpone a necessary decision. Let the definition belong to your actual life.

Write: What would this look like in one ordinary week of my real life?



“The body changed, but the deeper transformation was learning to love the woman living inside it.”

— Lucy Mworira

Eight Things I Know Now

1. Information is not the same as transformation.

I knew many sensible things about health before I changed. Most adults do. We know vegetables are useful, sleep matters, water matters and movement matters. Knowledge can sit comfortably beside behaviour for years. My change began when information became personal responsibility. That is why I am cautious about offering another perfect list. Lists are easy to admire. A life changes when a person begins doing something with what she already knows. The question that helped me was not, What else do I need to learn? It was, What am I willing to practise consistently? That question made the journey smaller and more demanding at the same time. I could no longer hide behind research, plans or the fantasy of a future start date. I had to act inside the day I already had.

2. Self-trust is built privately

Nobody can clap loudly enough to create self-trust for you. Encouragement helps, but the deeper confidence comes from private evidence. You said you would walk and you walked. You said you would return and you returned. You said the difficult day would not become a difficult month and then you behaved accordingly. These moments are often invisible to everyone else. That is precisely why they matter. You know whether you kept the promise.

Over time I began to value that private record more than the changing comments around me. People can praise you one week and criticize you the next. Your relationship with your own word is more stable ground.

3. Culture deserves respect, not surrender

I love the generosity built into Kenyan food culture. A visitor is fed. A grieving family is fed. A celebration is fed. Friendship can arrive carrying chapati. Love can look like a plate somebody insists is too small. I did not want wellness to make me suspicious of all of that. I wanted to remain part of my culture while becoming more deliberate about my choices. That required nuance. Sometimes I ate what was offered. Sometimes I chose differently. Sometimes I laughed and negotiated. Sometimes I enjoyed the meal and returned later. A sustainable life has to be able to sit at a real table with real people.

4. The body is not a before photograph

Before-and-after photographs can be satisfying because they compress time. They show contrast. They do not show the woman waking up on all the mornings between the pictures. They do not show disappointment, ordinary meals, missed walks, laughter, grief, travel, boredom or the changing conversation in her head. I enjoy my photographs now, but I do not want the image to become the whole meaning of the journey. My body was never simply a problem to solve. It was the body carrying every part of the story. I wanted to care for it better, not turn it into evidence that one version of Lucy deserved more respect than another.

5. Joy is serious evidence

When I began enjoying clothes again, dancing again, walking farther, travelling with more confidence and laughing at myself, those changes mattered to me. They were not side effects too frivolous to mention beside health. Quality of life is part of why health matters. I want years, but I also want life inside the years. That is one reason my work with older people has shaped the way I think about wellness. Longevity without dignity, participation, pleasure or connection is an incomplete ambition. I cannot control everything that ageing may bring, but I can take seriously the things that help me remain engaged with my own life.

6. Grief and living can occupy the same day

After Murithi died, I learned again that human beings are not emotionally tidy. A day can contain tears and appetite. It can contain exhaustion and laughter. It can contain a memory that breaks your heart and a ridiculous conversation five minutes later. I do not believe laughter means the grief has ended, and I do not believe grief requires the refusal of every ordinary pleasure. Love is large enough to make room for both remembrance and continued living. I carry my son with me. I also continue to inhabit the life in which I carry him.

7. Returning is more powerful than restarting

Restarting can make every disruption feel like the end of an era. Monday becomes a ceremony. The first of the month becomes a ceremony.

We wait for a clean beginning because we want the new effort to be uncontaminated by the old mistake. Returning is less dramatic. It can happen at lunch. It can happen tomorrow morning. It can happen after a holiday without a speech. That is why I prefer it. I do not need a new identity every time life interrupts my routine. I only need the next useful decision. This has made my wellness life much more forgiving and, paradoxically, much more consistent.

8. The woman I found is still becoming

A title can make transformation sound finished. It is not. I found a woman who trusts herself more, cares for herself more deliberately, enjoys her body differently and understands that age has not ended possibility. She is still human. She still has days when she is tired, hungry, grieving, busy or not interested in behaving like the inspirational woman in a book. I am grateful for that. I do not want to become a symbol who has to perform perfection. I want to remain Lucy. The woman I found is not a finished product. She is a woman who knows how to come home to herself again.

I used to think transformation would feel like becoming somebody else. Instead, much of it felt like removing noise. I became less interested in explaining every choice, less willing to postpone ordinary care, and more able to recognise when an excuse was simply an excuse. The result was not a new personality. It was a clearer relationship with the one I already had.

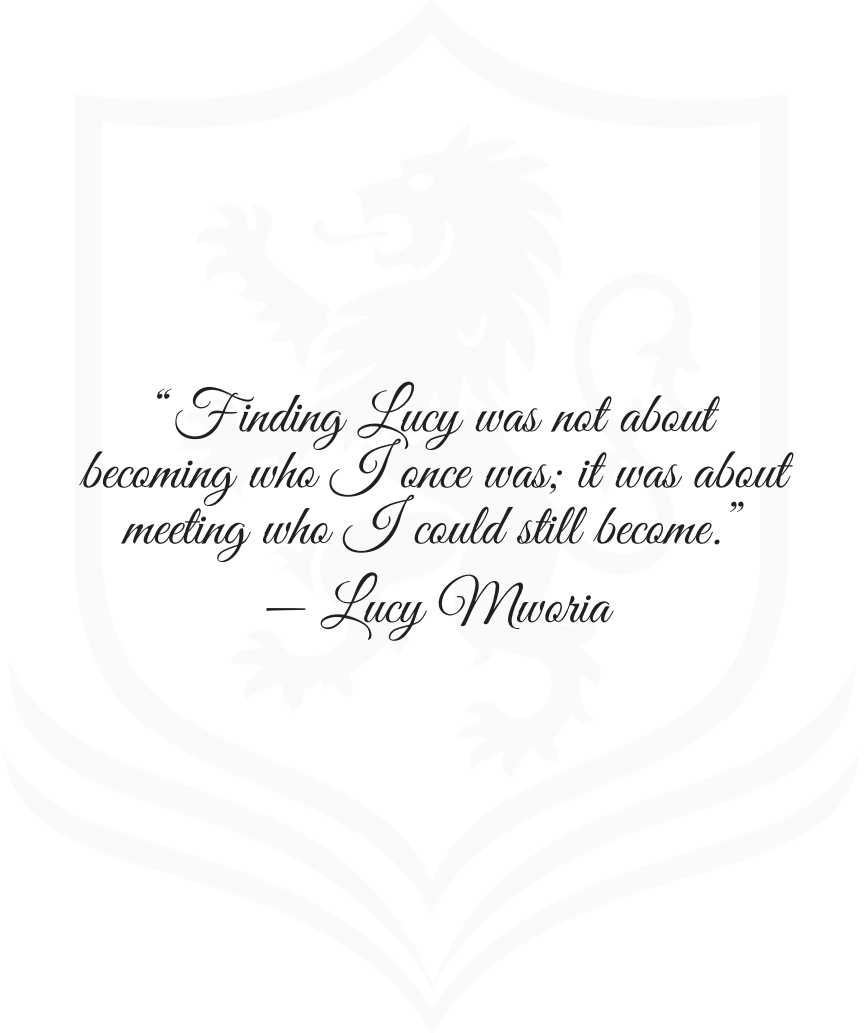
The body changes slowly enough that the mind sometimes misses what is happening. Then one day a familiar walk feels easier, a dress closes differently, sleep improves, or a photograph surprises you.

Those moments are useful, but they are not the whole story. The quieter evidence is repetition: another morning, another decision, another return. A life is built from ordinary days long before it looks transformed from the outside.

I remain grateful that Dr Maryam did not speak to me as though age had ended the conversation. She gave me information and responsibility in the same moment. I could not control every factor affecting my body, but I could participate in what happened next. That idea has stayed with me far beyond the original appointment.

I also remain grateful for the people who made the journey human. Zena with food and friendship. Mama Safi with campaign memories that still make me laugh. The women who eventually walked with me. My children. My family. Murithi, whose encouragement remains part of these pages. Transformation may require personal responsibility, but personal responsibility does not mean isolation.

If this book leaves you with anything, I hope it is permission to become curious again. Not desperate. Not ashamed. Curious. What is still possible? What would improve if you cared for yourself consistently for six months? What have you accepted because everybody around you accepted it too? What might change if you stopped waiting to feel completely ready? Curiosity is a gentler beginning than self-disgust, and in my life it proved much more useful.



“Finding Lucy was not about becoming who I once was; it was about meeting who I could still become.”

— Lucy Mworira

A Thirty-Day Return Practice

This is not a diet plan or a medical programme. It is a month of attention. Adapt every physical or nutritional choice to your own circumstances and professional guidance. The purpose is to practise returning to yourself in ordinary life, one day at a time.

Day 1 — Tell the truth kindly

Write down what brought you to this page. Describe what is working in your life and what is not. Do not exaggerate either side. You are not building a case against yourself. You are establishing a starting point. End with one sentence: The thing I most want to feel different about my life is...

Reflection: What did I notice today? What helped? What will I carry into tomorrow?

Day 2 — Drink attention

Notice how often you move through the day without checking what your body needs. Hydration is one example from my own journey, but the deeper practice is attention. Set a simple reminder to pause several times today. Ask whether you need water, food, movement, rest, medication as prescribed, quiet, or help. Respond to one need deliberately.

Reflection: What did I notice today? What helped? What will I carry into tomorrow?

Day 3 — Walk away and come back

If walking is appropriate for you, choose a short amount of time and walk away from your starting point, remembering that the return is part of the distance. If walking is not appropriate, choose another safe form of movement. The lesson is not distance. It is making a promise small enough to complete and then completing it.

Reflection: What did I notice today? What helped? What will I carry into tomorrow?

Day 4 — Clear one obstacle

Choose one small part of your environment that makes your desired habit harder. It may be a kitchen shelf, a cluttered chair, an overfull calendar, a missing pair of walking shoes, or a bedtime interrupted by your phone. Change one thing. Do not redesign the whole house. Make tomorrow slightly easier than today.

Reflection: What did I notice today? What helped? What will I carry into tomorrow?

Day 5 — Eat without a courtroom

At one meal today, pay attention without judging yourself. Notice hunger, taste, pace, satisfaction and emotion. If the meal is different from what you planned, resist the urge to turn it into evidence about your character. Information is useful. Shame is noisy. Ask what you learned and let the meal end when the meal ends.

Reflection: What did I notice today? What helped? What will I carry into tomorrow?

Day 6 — Wear something you like

Choose clothing because it gives you pleasure now, not because you are waiting for another body or occasion. This is not about buying anything. It is about refusing to make your current self live entirely in temporary clothes. Notice what changes when getting dressed becomes an act of participation rather than camouflage.

Reflection: What did I notice today? What helped? What will I carry into tomorrow?

Day 7 — Review without grading

Look back at the week and avoid giving yourself a score. What did you repeat? What was difficult? What surprised you? Where did the plan collide with real life? Choose one thing to continue and one thing to simplify. A review should make the next week wiser, not make the previous week guilty.

Reflection: What did I notice today? What helped? What will I carry into tomorrow?

Day 8 — Protect your sleep

Look at the hour before bed. What is within your control? Create one small cue that tells your body the day is ending. Persistent sleep problems can require professional care; this practice is simply about treating rest as worthy of preparation rather than as whatever remains after everything else is finished.

Reflection: What did I notice today? What helped? What will I carry into tomorrow?

Day 9 — Notice an inherited sentence

Catch one sentence about age, weight, womanhood or health that you repeat automatically. Write it down. Then ask where it came from and whether it deserves authority. Replace it with a question. Instead of, At my age this is impossible, try, What is safely possible for me now?

Reflection: What did I notice today? What helped? What will I carry into tomorrow?

Day 10 — Move for pleasure

Choose movement you enjoy if it is appropriate for you. Put on music. Stretch. Dance. Walk somewhere beautiful. The point is to remind yourself that movement can belong to life rather than punishment. Notice whether enjoyment changes your willingness to continue longer than obligation would have.

Reflection: What did I notice today? What helped? What will I carry into tomorrow?

Day 11 — Make one direct request

Ask somebody for one form of support you actually need. Be specific. Please walk with me. Please do not comment on my plate. Can you handle this task tonight so I can rest? Support is easier to give when it is not a guessing game.

Reflection: What did I notice today? What helped? What will I carry into tomorrow?

Day 12 — Find your hungry hour

Notice the time of day when your intentions become hardest to maintain. What else is happening then? Fatigue? Stress? Habit? Social routine? Actual hunger? Do not rush to solve it. Observe the pattern first. A pattern becomes easier to work with once it has a name.

Reflection: What did I notice today? What helped? What will I carry into tomorrow?

Day 13 — Take the photograph

If you have been avoiding photographs because you are waiting to change, consider taking one today. You do not have to post it. Let it be evidence that you were present in your own life on this date. A photograph is not a verdict. It is a moment.

Reflection: What did I notice today? What helped? What will I carry into tomorrow?

Day 14 — Practise the return

Choose one thing that did not go as planned this week and return without ceremony. Do the next useful thing. No punishment, no dramatic restart, no promise that Monday will be a different species of day. Practise making return ordinary.

Reflection: What did I notice today? What helped? What will I carry into tomorrow?

Day 15 — Remember what you miss

Think about an earlier version of yourself you sometimes miss. Write five qualities that have nothing to do with weight or age. Perhaps she was playful, social, stylish, brave, curious or rested. Choose one quality and express it today in the life you have now.

Reflection: What did I notice today? What helped? What will I carry into tomorrow?

Day 16 — Make food easier

Prepare or arrange one nourishing option that makes a future choice simpler. The exact food will depend on your needs, culture and preferences. The practice is preparation. We often ask willpower to solve problems that planning could have solved earlier.

Reflection: What did I notice today? What helped? What will I carry into tomorrow?

Day 17 — Sit with enough

Notice the moment when something is enough today: enough food, enough work, enough scrolling, enough explaining, enough responsibility for one evening. Stop one thing when it reaches enough. This is a boundary practice, not merely a food practice.

Reflection: What did I notice today? What helped? What will I carry into tomorrow?

Day 18 — Laugh at something

Find one ridiculous thing in your current season and allow it to be funny. Seriousness is not the only evidence that you care. Humour can make room around difficulty. Write the story the way you would tell it to a friend who knows you well.

Reflection: What did I notice today? What helped? What will I carry into tomorrow?

Day 19 — Check your private life

Ask whether the woman people see publicly is receiving the same care privately. You may be functioning beautifully. That is not the same question as whether you are well supported. Name one private need that competence has been hiding.

Reflection: What did I notice today? What helped? What will I carry into tomorrow?

Day 20 — Do the boring thing

Repeat one useful action that no longer feels exciting. This is a day for ordinary discipline. The boring action may be the walk, water, bedtime, food preparation, medication as prescribed, stretching, or another routine. Let repetition be enough.

Reflection: What did I notice today? What helped? What will I carry into tomorrow?

Day 21 — Let somebody care for you

Accept one appropriate act of care without immediately repaying it. A meal, a ride, a phone call, help with a task, company on a walk. Receiving can feel uncomfortable for people accustomed to giving. Notice the discomfort without obeying it.

Reflection: What did I notice today? What helped? What will I carry into tomorrow?

Day 22 — Revisit your reason

Write why your wellbeing matters without using appearance. Then write why appearance matters to you, if it does, without apologising. Both answers are allowed. The purpose is honesty. A sustainable journey can contain health, pleasure, style, confidence, mobility and many other motives at once.

Reflection: What did I notice today? What helped? What will I carry into tomorrow?

Day 23 — Make space for culture

Choose a food, ritual or social practice connected to your culture and think about how it fits into the life you want. Avoid the false choice between belonging and wellbeing. What would conscious participation look like? Sometimes the answer is simply enjoying the thing fully and returning afterward.

Reflection: What did I notice today? What helped? What will I carry into tomorrow?

Day 24 — Notice progress you cannot photograph

List five changes that would never appear in a before-and-after picture: sleeping better, keeping promises, asking for help, walking farther, feeling calmer around food, speaking more kindly to yourself, recovering faster after disruption. These are part of the transformation too.

Reflection: What did I notice today? What helped? What will I carry into tomorrow?

Day 25 — Say no once

Choose one request you can reasonably decline or renegotiate. Notice what feelings appear. Guilt does not automatically mean the boundary is wrong. Sometimes guilt is simply the feeling of doing something unfamiliar.

Reflection: What did I notice today? What helped? What will I carry into tomorrow?

Day 26 — Say yes once

Choose one pleasure, opportunity or invitation you have been denying yourself for no good reason. Say yes if it is safe and appropriate. Choosing yourself is not only restriction. It is also participation.

Reflection: What did I notice today? What helped? What will I carry into tomorrow?

Day 27 — Ask an expert, not the crowd

Identify one health question you have been answering through friends, relatives or social media. Write it down for an appropriate qualified professional. Casual opinions can be loud. Expertise deserves a different category.

Reflection: What did I notice today? What helped? What will I carry into tomorrow?

Day 28 — Prepare for disruption

Think about the next predictable interruption: travel, a celebration, work pressure, visitors, a holiday. Decide what matters most to carry with you and what can flex. A plan that anticipates life is stronger than one that resents life for happening.

Reflection: What did I notice today? What helped? What will I carry into tomorrow?

Day 29 — Write to your future self

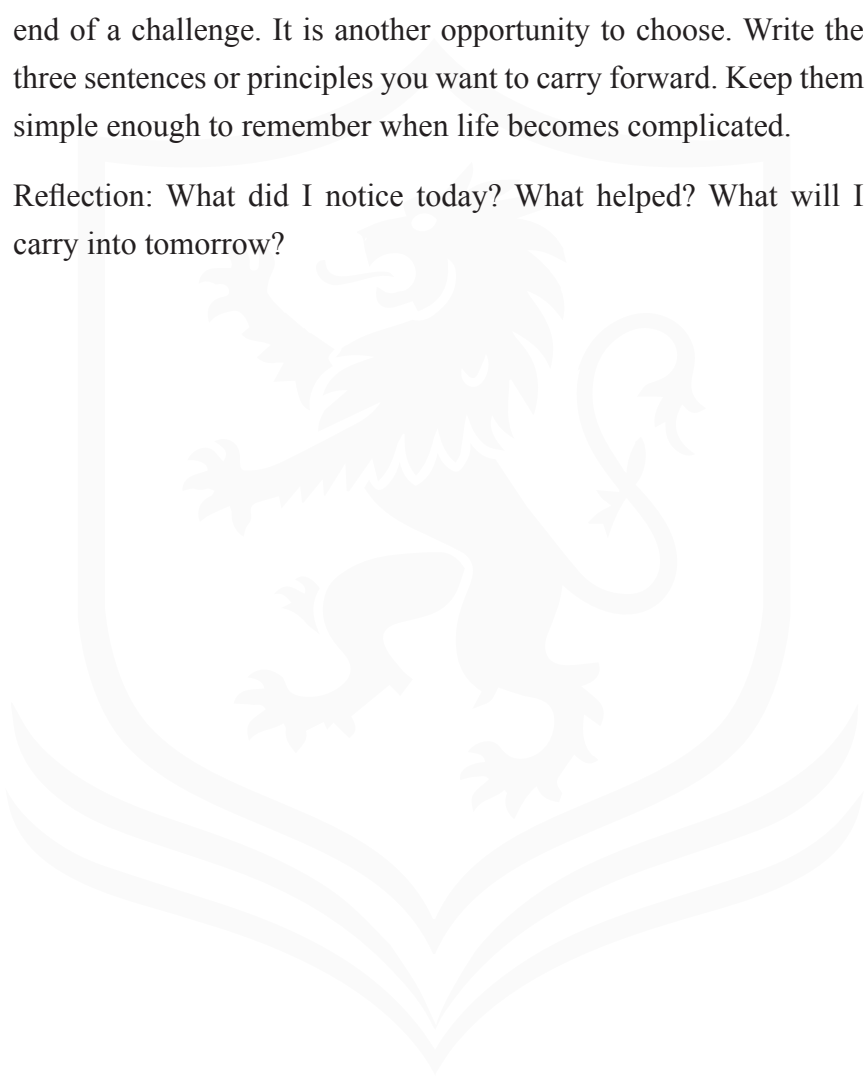
Write a short note to yourself one year from now. Do not demand a number on a scale. Describe the relationship you hope she has with herself. What does she trust? What does she enjoy? What has she stopped postponing? What does she thank you for beginning?

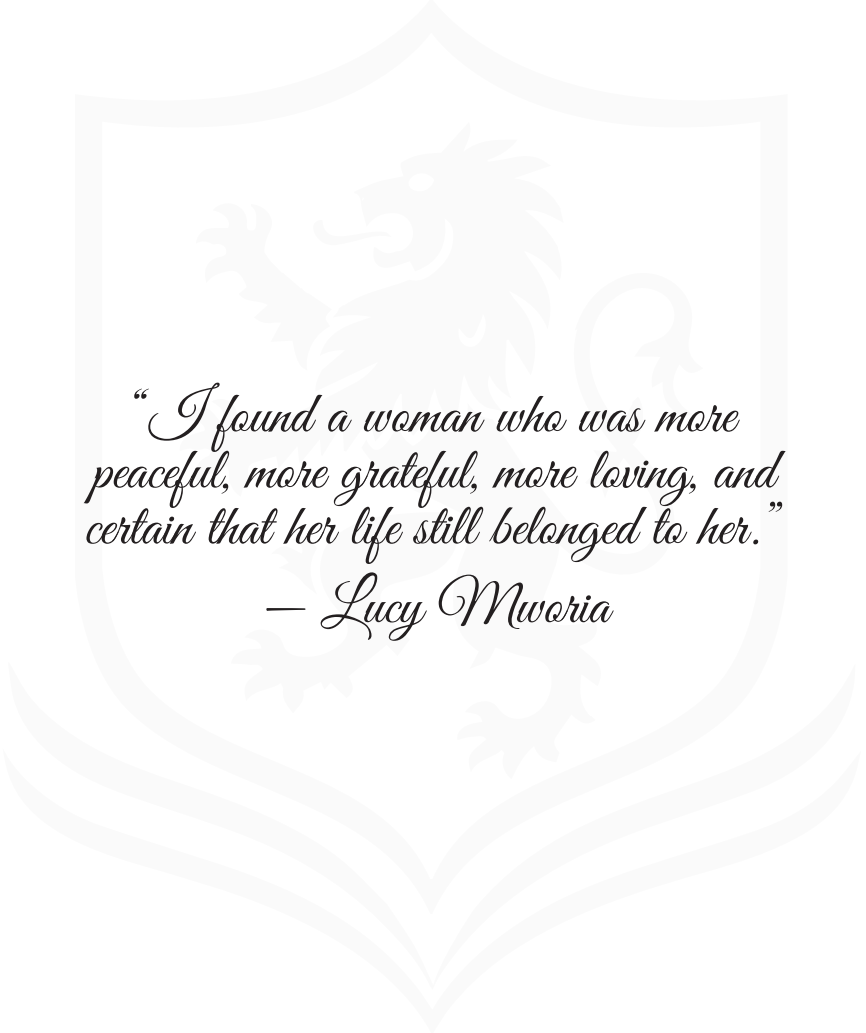
Reflection: What did I notice today? What helped? What will I carry into tomorrow?

Day 30 — Choose again

There is no graduation from caring for yourself. Today is not the end of a challenge. It is another opportunity to choose. Write the three sentences or principles you want to carry forward. Keep them simple enough to remember when life becomes complicated.

Reflection: What did I notice today? What helped? What will I carry into tomorrow?





“I found a woman who was more peaceful, more grateful, more loving, and certain that her life still belonged to her.”

— Lucy Mworira

Closing Reflection — A Life You Can Return To

The purpose of these thirty days is not to create thirty perfect days. If you missed one, the practice has already offered its lesson: return. If you completed every day, the same lesson remains. There will be another month in which life is less cooperative. The skill is not maintaining a flawless record. The skill is knowing the road back.

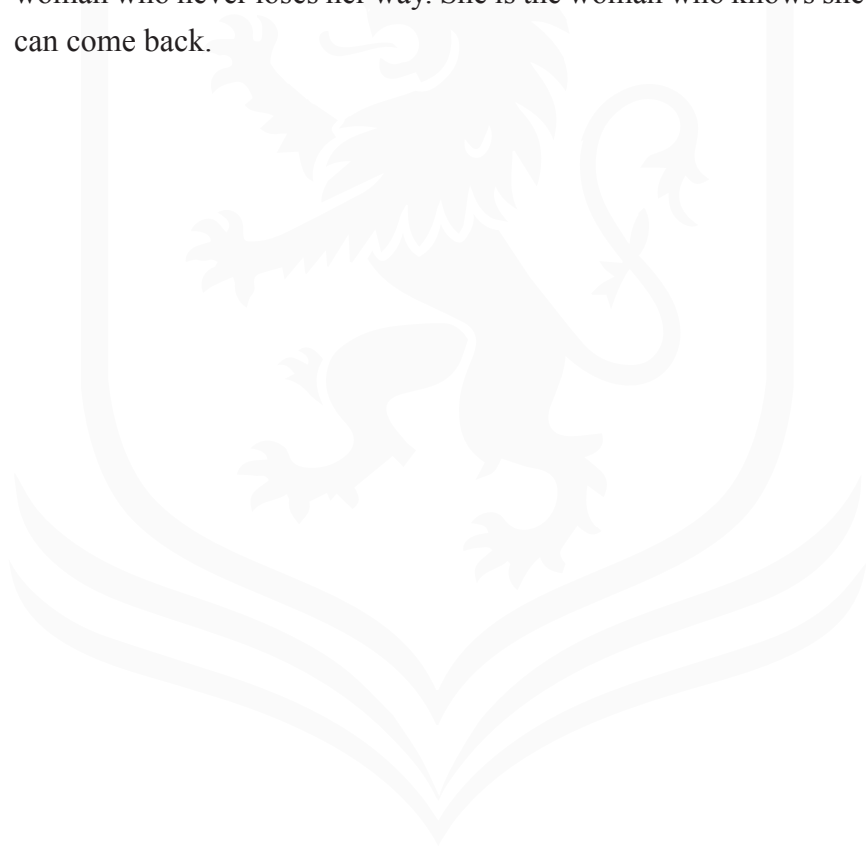
I began my own journey with a body that was asking for attention and a mind that had become very good at postponement. I did not know that the practical changes would eventually alter the way I thought about confidence, purpose, grief, ageing and self-respect. That is why I resist reducing the story to a method. Methods can be useful. Meaning is larger.

There are still foods I enjoy, days I rest, journeys that interrupt routine, people who have opinions, responsibilities that demand more than expected and moments when I do not feel particularly inspirational. I am glad. I wanted a life, not a permanent wellness retreat. The practices have to live here, among all of it.

When I say choose yourself, I do not mean choose yourself once. I mean notice when you have disappeared again. Notice when later has returned. Notice when everybody else's needs have quietly become the entire calendar.

Notice when one imperfect choice is trying to become permission to abandon yourself. Then choose again.

The woman I found is not waiting at a finish line. She is present in that choosing. She is in the kitchen, on the road, in the dress, at the meeting, beside the ocean, in grief, in laughter, in work, in rest and in the ordinary morning after an imperfect day. She is not the woman who never loses her way. She is the woman who knows she can come back.



Thirty Journal Invitations

1. The life I keep postponing

Describe one part of life you keep placing after the next deadline, child's need, work demand, financial milestone or body change. What are you waiting to become before you allow yourself to participate? Write what a smaller version of that life could look like this month.

Stay with the question long enough to move past the first polished answer. Write the answer you would give if nobody were going to read it. Then underline one sentence that feels more true than comfortable. You do not have to act on it immediately. The purpose of reflection is not to create another list of obligations. It is to become harder to hide from yourself in your own life.

2. The strong woman story

Write the compliments people give you about being strong, dependable or capable. Which ones feel true? Which ones have become obligations? Where do you need permission to be supported rather than impressive?

Stay with the question long enough to move past the first polished answer. Write the answer you would give if nobody were going to read it. Then underline one sentence that feels more true than comfortable. You do not have to act on it immediately.

The purpose of reflection is not to create another list of obligations. It is to become harder to hide from yourself in your own life.

3. My body before judgment

Describe your body today using only neutral observations and gratitude for function. Then name what you would like to improve. Notice whether honesty becomes clearer when insult is removed.

Stay with the question long enough to move past the first polished answer. Write the answer you would give if nobody were going to read it. Then underline one sentence that feels more true than comfortable. You do not have to act on it immediately. The purpose of reflection is not to create another list of obligations. It is to become harder to hide from yourself in your own life.

4. The sentence I inherited

Write a sentence about ageing or womanhood that you heard so often it began to sound like fact. Who said it? What might have been true in their life? What is actually true in yours?

Stay with the question long enough to move past the first polished answer. Write the answer you would give if nobody were going to read it. Then underline one sentence that feels more true than comfortable. You do not have to act on it immediately. The purpose of reflection is not to create another list of obligations. It is to become harder to hide from yourself in your own life.

5. The promise I break most often

Name one promise you repeatedly make to yourself and postpone. Make it smaller until you are willing to keep it for seven days. Write the smaller promise in plain language.

Stay with the question long enough to move past the first polished answer. Write the answer you would give if nobody were going to read it. Then underline one sentence that feels more true than comfortable. You do not have to act on it immediately. The purpose of reflection is not to create another list of obligations. It is to become harder to hide from yourself in your own life.

6. What food means here

Describe a meal that means home. Who prepares it? Who sits nearby? What emotion does it carry? Then write how you can honour that meaning without making every cultural meal an automatic decision.

Stay with the question long enough to move past the first polished answer. Write the answer you would give if nobody were going to read it. Then underline one sentence that feels more true than comfortable. You do not have to act on it immediately. The purpose of reflection is not to create another list of obligations. It is to become harder to hide from yourself in your own life.

7. The photograph I avoid

Write about a photograph you dislike or a camera you avoided. What did you think the image said about you?

What might it say if you looked at it as documentation rather than judgment?

Stay with the question long enough to move past the first polished answer. Write the answer you would give if nobody were going to read it. Then underline one sentence that feels more true than comfortable. You do not have to act on it immediately. The purpose of reflection is not to create another list of obligations. It is to become harder to hide from yourself in your own life.

8. My ordinary road

Describe the place where you could repeat a helpful practice. Make it specific enough to imagine returning there when motivation is low. What would make the place feel familiar rather than heroic?

Stay with the question long enough to move past the first polished answer. Write the answer you would give if nobody were going to read it. Then underline one sentence that feels more true than comfortable. You do not have to act on it immediately. The purpose of reflection is not to create another list of obligations. It is to become harder to hide from yourself in your own life.

9. The hour I disappear

Which hour of the day is most likely to undo your intentions? Describe what usually happens before, during and after it. What need might be hiding inside the pattern?

Stay with the question long enough to move past the first polished answer. Write the answer you would give if nobody were going

to read it. Then underline one sentence that feels more true than comfortable. You do not have to act on it immediately. The purpose of reflection is not to create another list of obligations. It is to become harder to hide from yourself in your own life.

10. The opinion I can return

Choose one opinion about your choices that you have been carrying as though it belongs to you. Write it down. Then write: This is information, concern, culture, projection or opinion. I decide what authority it has.

Stay with the question long enough to move past the first polished answer. Write the answer you would give if nobody were going to read it. Then underline one sentence that feels more true than comfortable. You do not have to act on it immediately. The purpose of reflection is not to create another list of obligations. It is to become harder to hide from yourself in your own life.

11. What I want from age

Instead of listing what you fear about ageing, list what you want from the next decade: strength, peace, friendship, contribution, adventure, style, rest, learning, family, faith, laughter. Which desire deserves action now?

Stay with the question long enough to move past the first polished answer. Write the answer you would give if nobody were going to read it. Then underline one sentence that feels more true than comfortable.

You do not have to act on it immediately. The purpose of reflection is not to create another list of obligations. It is to become harder to hide from yourself in your own life.

12. My definition of enough

Finish the sentences: I have worked enough when... I have given enough when... I have eaten enough when... I have explained enough when... I have rested enough when... Notice which sentence is hardest.

Stay with the question long enough to move past the first polished answer. Write the answer you would give if nobody were going to read it. Then underline one sentence that feels more true than comfortable. You do not have to act on it immediately. The purpose of reflection is not to create another list of obligations. It is to become harder to hide from yourself in your own life.

13. A day without performance

Imagine a day in which nobody is evaluating your productivity, appearance or usefulness. What would you keep doing anyway? Those answers may point toward the parts of your life that are genuinely yours.

Stay with the question long enough to move past the first polished answer. Write the answer you would give if nobody were going to read it. Then underline one sentence that feels more true than comfortable. You do not have to act on it immediately. The purpose of reflection is not to create another list of obligations. It is to become harder to hide from yourself in your own life.

14. The clothes that know me

Choose three items in your wardrobe with emotional history. Write the story each one carries. Then decide whether you are keeping the garment, the memory, or both.

Stay with the question long enough to move past the first polished answer. Write the answer you would give if nobody were going to read it. Then underline one sentence that feels more true than comfortable. You do not have to act on it immediately. The purpose of reflection is not to create another list of obligations. It is to become harder to hide from yourself in your own life.

15. What movement gave me

Write about a time movement made you feel alive rather than corrected. It may have happened years ago. What conditions made it enjoyable? Which of those conditions could you recreate now?

Stay with the question long enough to move past the first polished answer. Write the answer you would give if nobody were going to read it. Then underline one sentence that feels more true than comfortable. You do not have to act on it immediately. The purpose of reflection is not to create another list of obligations. It is to become harder to hide from yourself in your own life.

16. The return after travel

Think about the last trip, holiday or busy week that disrupted your routine. What would a gentler return have looked like? Write a three-step return plan for the next disruption.

Stay with the question long enough to move past the first polished answer. Write the answer you would give if nobody were going to read it. Then underline one sentence that feels more true than comfortable. You do not have to act on it immediately. The purpose of reflection is not to create another list of obligations. It is to become harder to hide from yourself in your own life.

17. Receiving care

Describe how you react when somebody offers practical care. Do you accept, minimize, repay immediately or refuse? What would it mean to receive without turning the moment into debt?

Stay with the question long enough to move past the first polished answer. Write the answer you would give if nobody were going to read it. Then underline one sentence that feels more true than comfortable. You do not have to act on it immediately. The purpose of reflection is not to create another list of obligations. It is to become harder to hide from yourself in your own life.

18. The funny version

Take one stressful memory and write the version you tell when you want somebody you love to laugh. Keep the facts honest. Notice what humour reveals that solemnity sometimes hides.

Stay with the question long enough to move past the first polished answer. Write the answer you would give if nobody were going to read it. Then underline one sentence that feels more true than comfortable. You do not have to act on it immediately. The purpose

of reflection is not to create another list of obligations. It is to become harder to hide from yourself in your own life.

19. The private evidence

List five promises you have kept that nobody else knows about. Let them be small. What do they tell you about your ability to trust yourself?

Stay with the question long enough to move past the first polished answer. Write the answer you would give if nobody were going to read it. Then underline one sentence that feels more true than comfortable. You do not have to act on it immediately. The purpose of reflection is not to create another list of obligations. It is to become harder to hide from yourself in your own life.

20. The public woman and the private woman

Describe how you appear when you are functioning well in public. Then describe what only the people closest to you—or perhaps nobody—see. Where do those two women need to become more honest with each other?

Stay with the question long enough to move past the first polished answer. Write the answer you would give if nobody were going to read it. Then underline one sentence that feels more true than comfortable. You do not have to act on it immediately. The purpose of reflection is not to create another list of obligations. It is to become harder to hide from yourself in your own life.

21. The meal after grief

Write about a time somebody fed you during difficulty. What did the food communicate beyond nutrition? How does that memory complicate simple rules about food being good or bad?

Stay with the question long enough to move past the first polished answer. Write the answer you would give if nobody were going to read it. Then underline one sentence that feels more true than comfortable. You do not have to act on it immediately. The purpose of reflection is not to create another list of obligations. It is to become harder to hide from yourself in your own life.

22. The joy I called vanity

Name something you enjoy about appearance, beauty, style or being seen that you have minimized because it seemed superficial. What if pleasure is allowed to be pleasure without defending itself?

Stay with the question long enough to move past the first polished answer. Write the answer you would give if nobody were going to read it. Then underline one sentence that feels more true than comfortable. You do not have to act on it immediately. The purpose of reflection is not to create another list of obligations. It is to become harder to hide from yourself in your own life.

23. My useful boundary

Write one boundary that would protect a new habit without isolating you from life. Include when you will review it so temporary protection does not become permanent fear.

Stay with the question long enough to move past the first polished answer. Write the answer you would give if nobody were going to read it. Then underline one sentence that feels more true than comfortable. You do not have to act on it immediately. The purpose of reflection is not to create another list of obligations. It is to become harder to hide from yourself in your own life.

24. What the scale cannot know

List ten things about your wellbeing that a scale cannot measure. Circle the three that matter most to the life you want. How could you notice progress in those areas?

Stay with the question long enough to move past the first polished answer. Write the answer you would give if nobody were going to read it. Then underline one sentence that feels more true than comfortable. You do not have to act on it immediately. The purpose of reflection is not to create another list of obligations. It is to become harder to hide from yourself in your own life.

25. The woman in the old photograph

If you have an old photograph you love, write what you admire about that woman beyond her body. Then write what the present version of you knows that she did not know yet.

Stay with the question long enough to move past the first polished answer. Write the answer you would give if nobody were going to read it. Then underline one sentence that feels more true than comfortable. You do not have to act on it immediately.

The purpose of reflection is not to create another list of obligations. It is to become harder to hide from yourself in your own life.

26. My relationship with tomorrow

Write the promises you tend to send to tomorrow. Choose one and complete a five-minute version today. Record how it feels to interrupt postponement.

Stay with the question long enough to move past the first polished answer. Write the answer you would give if nobody were going to read it. Then underline one sentence that feels more true than comfortable. You do not have to act on it immediately. The purpose of reflection is not to create another list of obligations. It is to become harder to hide from yourself in your own life.

27. The people at my table

List the people who influence your habits simply because you share life with them. What support could you request? What responsibility remains yours even if they do not change?

Stay with the question long enough to move past the first polished answer. Write the answer you would give if nobody were going to read it. Then underline one sentence that feels more true than comfortable. You do not have to act on it immediately. The purpose of reflection is not to create another list of obligations. It is to become harder to hide from yourself in your own life.

28. The purpose that includes me

Describe a cause, job, family role or responsibility you care about deeply. Now write yourself into the picture as a person whose wellbeing supports that purpose rather than competes with it.

Stay with the question long enough to move past the first polished answer. Write the answer you would give if nobody were going to read it. Then underline one sentence that feels more true than comfortable. You do not have to act on it immediately. The purpose of reflection is not to create another list of obligations. It is to become harder to hide from yourself in your own life.

29. What grief does not have to teach

Write about something painful without searching for a lesson. What happened? What do you miss? What do you need? Allow the page to hold experience without converting it immediately into growth.

Stay with the question long enough to move past the first polished answer. Write the answer you would give if nobody were going to read it. Then underline one sentence that feels more true than comfortable. You do not have to act on it immediately. The purpose of reflection is not to create another list of obligations. It is to become harder to hide from yourself in your own life.

30. The woman I am meeting now

Write one page beginning: I thought I was trying to get back to... Then continue: But the woman I am meeting now... Let the second woman surprise you.

Stay with the question long enough to move past the first polished answer. Write the answer you would give if nobody were going to read it. Then underline one sentence that feels more true than comfortable. You do not have to act on it immediately. The purpose of reflection is not to create another list of obligations. It is to become harder to hide from yourself in your own life.



Twelve Reminders for the Woman Who Keeps Going

You do not have to hate the woman you are to care for the woman you are becoming.

Change built on contempt asks you to fight yourself every day. Responsibility can be firm without becoming cruel. Tell the truth about what needs attention, then make the next decision from care.

Keep this reminder if it helps. Rewrite it if your own words are stronger. The point is not to borrow my language forever. The point is to recognise the truth in your own.

Being needed is not the same as being nourished.

A full calendar can prove that you are useful while saying nothing about whether your own life has room to breathe. Usefulness is meaningful, but it is not the only measure of a woman.

An ordinary habit can carry an extraordinary life.

The walk, the water, the bedtime, the meal, the repeated choice—none looks dramatic alone. Their power comes from accumulation. Haba na haba hujaza kibaba: little by little fills the measure.

You are allowed to enjoy being seen.

Visibility is not automatically vanity. A photograph, a beautiful dress, makeup, heels or a video can simply be ways of participating in your own life. You do not have to apologise for pleasure.

Keep this reminder if it helps. Rewrite it if your own words are stronger. The point is not to borrow my language forever. The point is to recognise the truth in your own.

Your culture is not the enemy of your wellbeing.

Food, hospitality and community can remain sources of belonging. The work is learning to make choices inside culture rather than imagining health requires exile from it.

A difficult season does not cancel every good habit.

Sometimes the goal becomes smaller. Sometimes care looks different. Grief, travel and responsibility may change the routine without erasing the person who built it.

The crowd does not get a vote on every private decision.

People will have opinions when you change and opinions when you do not. Listen where wisdom exists. Seek expertise where expertise is needed. Let the rest remain commentary.

Strength is not proof that you need nothing.

The woman who can handle a great deal may still need sleep, help, food, medical care, tenderness, quiet and a day without solving anything. Capability does not disqualify need.

You can be disciplined and still have a life.

A sustainable routine must eventually survive restaurants, celebrations, family, travel and unexpected days. Discipline that cannot tolerate reality becomes another form of fragility.

The next decision is often more useful than the last mistake.

Review patterns honestly, but do not spend so long prosecuting yesterday that you abandon today. Return is a skill. Practise it until it becomes less dramatic.

Age deserves curiosity.

Respect the realities of your body and seek appropriate guidance, but do not let a birthday answer every question before you ask it. Some possibilities close with time. Others remain open far longer than we assume.

You are still allowed to become.

There is no age at which a woman must stop surprising herself. The future may not look like the one you imagined earlier. That does not make it empty. There are versions of you that can only be met after everything you have already lived.

Coda — Keep Going

When Murithi read my writing, his words were simple: Keep going, Mum. I return to them now because they contain more wisdom than they first appear to. Keep going does not mean rush. It does not mean deny pain. It does not mean pretend every day is good. It means the story is still moving.

There were years when I believed progress would arrive through a large public victory. I understand progress differently now. Sometimes it is the courage to return home. Sometimes it is surviving a loss and rebuilding. Sometimes it is a doctor's sentence that changes the direction of your attention. Sometimes it is fifteen minutes away from home and fifteen minutes back.

Sometimes it is choosing the dress. Sometimes it is choosing the water. Sometimes it is eating the samosa inside the mandazi and laughing with your daughter on a train, then returning to your ordinary life without shame. Sometimes it is standing beside the ocean with grief still present and discovering that joy has not become disrespectful.

I do not know what choosing yourself will require from you. I know only what it required from me: honesty, repetition, humour, boundaries, flexibility, faith, care, and the willingness to begin again without making beginning again a humiliation.

I once looked at an old photograph and thought I was searching for a woman I had lost. I know better now. The woman I wanted to find could never have been contained on my phone screen. I had not met her yet. Now I have. Her name is Lucy.

A Note on Maintenance — After the Transformation Story

There is a moment in many transformation stories when the photographs are taken, the number is announced and the reader is invited to imagine that the difficult part has ended. Real life is less cinematic. After change comes maintenance, and maintenance has its own psychology. There is no longer the same novelty. People become accustomed to how you look. Compliments become less frequent because the new appearance becomes familiar. The scale may move less dramatically. The work becomes quieter. This is where I learned that my reasons had to be larger than applause. I still wanted comfortable movement. I still wanted energy. I still wanted the confidence that came from keeping promises. I still wanted to enjoy my clothes, my walks, my work and my life. Those reasons did not disappear when the dramatic part of the story became ordinary.

Maintenance also required me to become less frightened of flexibility. At the beginning, structure protected me. Later, a life built entirely around avoiding disruption would have become another kind of limitation. I wanted to travel. I wanted to eat with people I love. I wanted to attend celebrations and enjoy Kenya. I wanted to be able to stay somewhere unfamiliar without believing that one different meal had destroyed months of effort.

The discipline therefore had to mature. Early discipline said, Protect the routine. Mature discipline said, Know how to return to the routine. Both were useful at different stages.

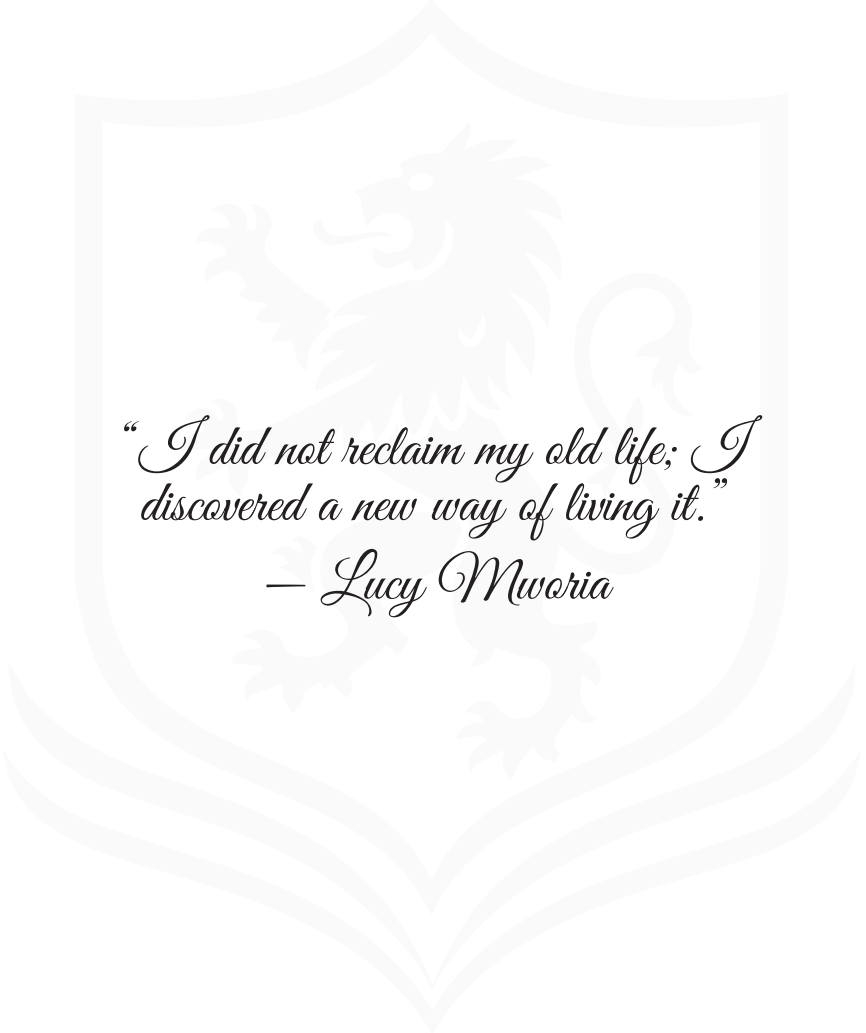
This changed my relationship with mistakes. I stopped treating every deviation as a moral event. There are choices I make deliberately because I want the experience. There are choices I make because I am tired or unprepared. There are days that simply unfold differently. I can examine a pattern without turning every meal into a confession. If something begins happening often enough to move me away from how I want to live, I pay attention. If it is one ordinary human day, I let it be one ordinary human day. That distinction has brought me more peace than perfection ever could.

Maintenance is also where identity becomes important. At first I was a woman trying to lose weight. Eventually I became a woman who walks, a woman who pays attention to what she eats, a woman who values sleep, a woman who can enjoy movement, a woman who returns. Those descriptions are not rules carved in stone. They are reminders of the life I prefer. When a habit becomes part of how you understand yourself, returning to it feels less like beginning a programme and more like coming home.

I remain aware that bodies change. Age continues. Health circumstances can change. A routine that works in one season may need to be adapted in another, and professional medical guidance matters when health conditions, medications, pain or other concerns enter the picture. I do not measure success by whether I can freeze my body at one exact moment forever. That would simply be another

impossible demand. I measure it by whether I remain engaged. Am I paying attention? Am I caring for myself? Am I willing to adjust rather than abandon myself when circumstances change? Those questions can travel with me into whatever comes next.

Perhaps this is the part of transformation I wish we discussed more. The after is not a destination where the woman finally earns the right to relax because she has solved herself. There is nothing to solve in that way. There is a relationship to maintain. Some days I will feel close to the woman I found. Other days I may have to look for her again. I am no longer frightened by that. I know the route. It is made of small choices, truthful reflection, humour when possible, help when needed, faith, movement, rest, food, friendship, and the decision not to make my own care optional. I can return as many times as life requires.



*“I did not reclaim my old life; I
discovered a new way of living it.”*

— Lucy Mwarira

The Last Word

If you have read this far, I hope you do not close the book believing that my exact routine is the point. The point is that I stopped treating my own life as something I would attend to after everything else. My methods were specific; the invitation is broader. Pay attention. Ask questions. Seek appropriate help. Make a decision small enough to practise. Keep the promise. Laugh when life becomes ridiculous. Return when you wander. Let age give you wisdom without allowing it to take possibilities you have not actually lost.

And when the process feels slow, remember that slow is not the same as stuck. I began with fifteen minutes in one direction. I began with a kitchen. I began with a doctor's sentence. I began with the uncomfortable recognition that I had been postponing myself. None of those beginnings looked like a finished book or a transformed life. They were simply beginnings. That was enough.

Choose yourself. Then, tomorrow, choose yourself again.

One final thing: I do not want this story to make change sound solitary. Personal responsibility mattered because nobody else could make my daily decisions for me, but I was never a woman without relationships. Friends fed me, walked with me, laughed with me and sometimes tempted me. Family watched the changes. Strangers commented. Professionals offered guidance.

My children had opinions. Murithi encouraged my writing. Community surrounded the entire journey. Choosing myself did not require pretending I had done everything alone. It required understanding which part could only be mine.

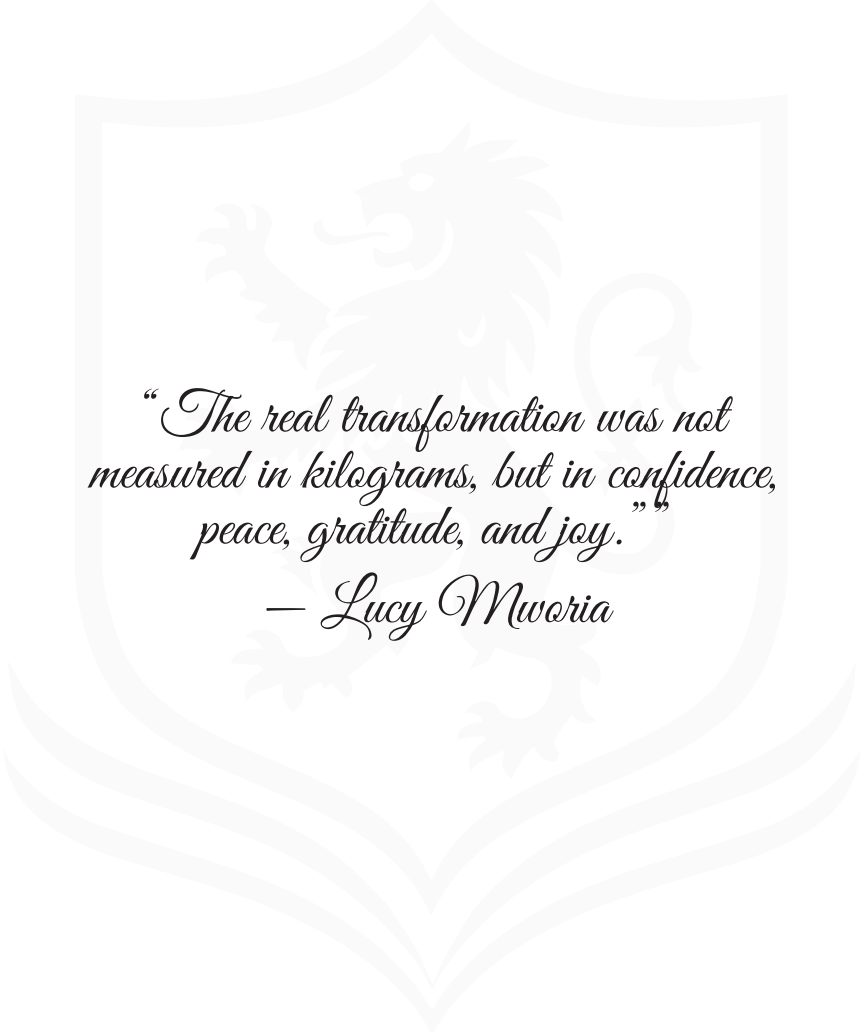
That distinction has become important in other areas of my life too. We can receive love and still make our own decisions. We can accept help and still be responsible. We can belong deeply to family and community without surrendering every boundary. We can be influenced without being controlled. We can listen without obeying every voice. Maturity, for me, has become less about proving independence and more about knowing what belongs to me to carry and what I can allow others to help carry.

So I end where I began, but with a different understanding. I wanted to lose weight. I did. I wanted my knees to feel better, my clothes to fit differently and my body to feel more like a place I enjoyed living in. Those things mattered. But the journey became larger because it taught me to notice the woman making the decisions. She had spent years serving, striving, rebuilding and continuing. She did not need to be replaced. She needed to be included.

That is the invitation I leave with you. Include yourself. Not above everybody. Not instead of everybody. Among everybody. Put your name somewhere on the list of people whose health, peace, joy and future deserve your attention. Then begin with whatever honest next step belongs to you. The step may be small enough that nobody else notices. Take it anyway. A life can change quietly before it ever looks different from the outside.

A Note for My Granddaughters

And to my granddaughters, Olive and Sofia: thank you for your excitement about this book and for all your questions while it was being written. Olive, who was quite determined to become a character, and Sofia, who was ready to proofread every page—you made the process even more joyful. I hope that one day, when you are old enough to read these pages for yourselves, you will remember one thing from your grandmother: you are never too young to know your worth, and never too old to choose yourself.



*“The real transformation was not
measured in kilograms, but in confidence,
peace, gratitude, and joy.”*

— Lucy Mworira

The Gallery

A Journey in Pictures

There are parts of a journey that words cannot quite hold. They find their way into a photograph, in the quiet difference between one image and another, in the colours of a meal prepared with care, and in the face of a woman who has begun to see herself with new eyes.

These pages are a little gallery of my journey.

Here, you will meet the woman I was, the woman I was becoming, and the woman I am still discovering. The photographs are not simply records of weight lost or inches changed. They are little signposts along the road, reminders of where I began, the choices I made, the days I struggled, the days I celebrated, and the quiet moments when I realised that one small choice, followed by another, could slowly change the direction of a life.

You will also find some of the food that became part of my new way of living. These plates carry colour, simplicity and the pleasure of eating well. They are not pictures of deprivation. They are reminders that nourishment can be beautiful, that healthy food can be enjoyed, and that caring for ourselves need not mean taking joy out of life.

So, as you turn these pages, linger for a moment. Look closely. Let the photographs speak in their own language. Notice the changes,

but look beyond them too. Somewhere among these images is a woman who stopped waiting for a different life and began, one choice at a time, to make room for it.

Welcome to my gallery.

Lucy Mvoria





The photo that sparked off the journey of Finding Lucy



*"This photo made me stop in my tracks and changed the course of my story,"
says Lucy*



Lucy: Before the weight came off



Before the Weight loss



Lucy at 115kgs



Lucy, the advocate for the Aging



Lucy Shares love and hugs



Listening is a critical part of caring for the elderly.



In listening, we affirm their dignity.



Thirty minutes one way meant I still had to walk back another thirty minutes to get home.



At times, all I need to do is sit and meditate, thanking God for the journey behind me, and for the one I have embarked on.



Walking afforded me time to think, meditate and pray. And so, I laced up my shoes and walked down Bofa Road



Once again I found joy of dressing up in nice clothes and it didn't even have to be any occasion at all.



A platter of sliced boiled eggs, sautéed green veggies, cherry tomatoes, avocado and baked sweet potatoes. Fresh watermelon juice. The platter is enough for two people



Grilled fish, steamed French beans, mashed potatoes. Pineapple juice with a dollop of ginger



Baked chicken salad with boiled sweet potatoes. Coconut water with mint for a refreshing drink

A Prayer Of Gratitude

Heavenly Father,

When I look back at the woman I was and the woman I am becoming, I can see Your hand in places I did not always recognise at the time. There were seasons when I was busy carrying responsibilities, caring for other people and simply getting on with life. I did not always stop to ask what was happening to me. Yet You were there, quietly giving me the strength to keep going and, when the time came, the courage to begin again.

I am grateful that You did not let me disappear completely from my own life.

You met me in the middle of ordinary things: in the walks, in the music, in the dancing, in the decision to change what I was eating, and even in the photograph of a younger Lucy that reminded me that another version of my life was possible. Slowly, I began to understand that I was not too old to change, not too far gone to begin, and not too set in my ways to become healthier, stronger and happier.

There were days when I doubted myself. There were comments that hurt. There were moments when I wanted comfort more than discipline and moments when discipline itself became uncomfortable. Yet somehow I kept returning. Perhaps that was

grace too.

You taught me that a late meal was not failure, that a difficult day did not have to become a difficult week, and that I did not have to be perfect to make progress. You taught me to return to myself without shame.

I am grateful for the people who have walked beside me, for family, friendship, laughter and the unexpected joy that can find us even in seasons of grief. I am grateful for my children and for the memories we share, including the moments that made us laugh when we probably should have been behaving more seriously. I am grateful that life has continued to hold beauty alongside loss.

I carry Murithi in that truth too. Grief taught me that love does not disappear when a life ends, and that laughter does not betray the person we miss. It simply reminds us that we are still here.

I am grateful for this body that has carried me through so much. I did not always treat it with the care it deserved, but it remained faithful to me. It walked when I needed to walk, danced when the music called, grew stronger when I challenged it and kept going even when I had not yet learned how to listen properly.

You have taught me to see my body with greater kindness, not as an ornament to be judged, but as the place in which I live this one life.

I am grateful too for the discipline that grew quietly through small promises kept. Every walk I completed, every choice I made when nobody was watching, every time I began again after getting it wrong, helped me rebuild something I had not realised I had

misplaced: trust in myself.

And perhaps that is what I am most grateful for.

I found Lucy.

Not the woman in the old photograph, although I am still rather fond of her. Not a perfect woman, because she does not exist. I found the woman who can laugh at herself, wear her heels, dance without waiting for permission, enjoy a good meal without turning it into guilt, and still return to what matters the next day.

I found a woman who understands that caring for herself is not selfish and that age is not a sentence.

Lord, help me to keep living this lesson. Let me continue to care for the body You have entrusted to me, to choose health without becoming rigid, discipline without becoming harsh, and joy without apology. Give me wisdom to know when to persevere, humility to begin again, and gratitude for the ordinary blessings that are so easy to overlook.

Most of all, keep me mindful that this life is not something to postpone until everything is perfect.

Let me live it.

Let me move.

Let me laugh.

Let me love.

Let me dance.

And when I lose my way, as I surely will from time to time, remind me that I already know how to come home.

Amen.

